QATAMON by Ali al-Khashkhash

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CHAPTER I

The House of Condolence

By half past eight the drawing room had already been corrected for

grief. The coloured cushions had been removed. The brighter rug had been

turned so its faded side faced up. The blue glass vase on the sideboard

stood empty because Maryam's mother had said, from the sofa and without

properly opening her eyes, that fresh flowers looked festive. The

curtains were half-drawn against a pale Jerusalem morning that might

have belonged to any other day in Qatamon, if Uncle Yusef had not been

lying in the mortuary room at the church, waiting to be prayed over,

handled, buried, spoken of, and sorted.

Maryam stood in the doorway a moment before going in. The house had

already ceased to be private. That happened quickly in a condolence

house. A room in which one had eaten, quarrelled, read letters, or

scolded a child the week before became public property as soon as the

first caller crossed the threshold. Cups bred on every surface. Women

entered the kitchen and opened cupboards they had never opened before.

One's own tiredness became almost indecent, as though fatigue were a

form of selfishness.

She was wearing the dark grey dress she had put aside after Aunt Salwa's

funeral rather than the black, which was too shaped through the waist

and had a neckline she no longer trusted under the inspection of older

women. The grey did not flatter her, which on such a morning counted in

its favour. As she fastened it, she remembered with immediate annoyance

that Uncle Yusef had once told her grey improved her because it forced

the face to do the work. She could not decide whether that memory

amounted to affection. Buttoning the collar, she had seen with disgust

that even the unbecoming dress made her look composed. For one wretched

instant she had thought people would say she wore sorrow with dignity,

and then despised herself for caring how she might be seen before the

day had properly begun. The disgust changed nothing. Vanity merely

learned better manners.

Leila sat on the carpet near the sofa with a pack of cards that had once

belonged to Yusef, building a crooked little house out of them with the

concentration children reserved for games they believed secretly

serious. One card kept sliding out of place. She pushed it back,

frowned, and then saw her mother.

"Must I stay downstairs?" she asked.

"For now."

"Will everybody cry?"

"Some will."

"Will you?"

Maryam bent to lift the loose cards before someone stepped on them. "Not

in front of everyone."

Leila accepted this as a practical arrangement rather than a revelation.

"Amina says I must keep my shoes on."

"That is because Amina is wise."

Leila looked down at her own feet, one shoe buckled and one lying beside

her like a small declaration of resistance. "I do not like wise people."

Maryam straightened the child's stocking and fastened the second shoe.

Behind them, from the back of the house, came the sounds of labour

already under way: cupboard doors, running water, crockery being lifted

more quickly than was safe. Amina had arrived late by no more than

twenty minutes, and even that had been enough for Maryam's mother to say

from the sofa that people's habits went to pieces the moment the city

turned troublesome. Amina had not replied. She had gone straight to the

kitchen with her scarf still half-pinned and begun boiling water with

the speed of someone who knew the house would punish her for every lost

minute even if nobody raised a hand. She never wasted an answer when

work would serve in its place.

Uncle Yusef had died the previous evening just after seven. The porter's

son from his building had gone up with a bag of oranges and found the

door not properly shut. A chair had been tipped over near the writing

desk. One slipper lay in the passage and the other in the sitting room.

Maryam had not seen the body. Hanna had. He had gone at once when the

message came and returned an hour later carrying Yusef's spectacles, the

key to the flat, and the look he wore whenever practical matters had

begun arranging themselves behind his eyes.

"A stroke, most likely," he had said in their bedroom while she took off

the blue earrings she suddenly felt ashamed of. "The doctor came. He had

not been long dead."

"Was anyone with him?"

"No."

What stayed with her was not the stroke or the doctor, only the fact

that no one had been with him.

Yusef had lived alone for eleven years, since his wife's death, and had

done so with the irritated independence of a man who considered company

both necessary and overrated. He read in three languages and kept

important documents in none of the places sensible people kept them. He

fed Leila sweets before supper and argued with priests without ceasing

to think of himself as devout. He once told Maryam that tidy drawers

were proof of a limited moral imagination, which she had laughed at more

than the remark deserved because it had been one of the few times in

recent years that she had been honestly amused in his presence. When she

was fourteen she had returned a book to his flat and found him at the

desk with three letters open before him in three languages. He had

tapped the English one and said, "Civilisation is a conspiracy of

letters written by people who never have to open them." Then he had

given her coffee far too sweet because, he said, only children and

optimists deserved that much sugar. For years she associated the flat

with that illicit coffee and with the deeper illicitness of being spoken

to as if one might already possess a mind.

Now he was dead, and the first visitors had not yet arrived, and already

the day belonged more to coffee, chairs, and protocols than to the fact

itself.

Amina came in carrying a tray of glasses still damp from washing. Her

apron had been tied on crookedly. A strand of hair stuck to her cheek.

She set the tray down and looked around the room with the appraising

glance of a woman who knew that whatever the family had decided about

mourning, it would be her back that carried it.

"The coffee is enough until noon if the first wave is not too great,"

she said. "After that we will need the better tin."

Maryam frowned. "Why not the ordinary one?"

"Your aunt sent it next door before I arrived. They were short."

"My aunt sent our coffee next door?"

"For the soul of the deceased, apparently." Amina picked up a glass and

held it to the light, checking for smears. "It seems coffee travels well

between houses when souls are concerned."

Leila said, "How much coffee does a soul need?"

"An indecent amount," Amina said.

Maryam almost smiled. She did not. "Use the reserve tin."

Amina's face altered very slightly. The reserve tin was for feast days,

priests, or people her mother wished to impress. "As you wish."

"What about sugar?"

"We have enough sugar if the ladies mourn modestly."

A moment later Hanna came in carrying two folding chairs under one arm

and a notebook in his hand. He had taken off his hat because he knew

Maryam's mother disliked hats indoors, but the mark of the band was

still pressed faintly into his hair. His tie was straight. His face

looked composed in the way it always did when he was most tired.

"The chairs from Nabil are broken," he said, setting the usable pair

against the wall. "Samir will bring more from the club before eleven."

He looked at Leila. "No running today."

"I know."

"You may know after I have finished speaking."

Leila looked down.

Maryam felt the familiar inward tightening. Hanna was not cruel with the

child. He was exact, and exactness in him often felt colder than

anger in other people.

"She has been very good," Maryam said.

"I am glad to hear it." He turned to Amina. "The ice is on its way. Keep

one basin in the back room. If the men remain after the burial we will

need more water. And ask the boy to fetch another packet of cigarettes."

"You do not smoke," Maryam said.

"The men do."

Amina nodded and went out. Hanna looked at Maryam then, though not for

long. "The undertaker may need proof of the family plot. Your uncle

appears to have kept the relevant papers in at least four places, none

of them obvious."

"Must that be dealt with today?"

"It must be begun today."

Yusef had not been dead twelve hours and the world was already asking

for receipts.

A knock sounded at the front door — three brisk raps, the knock of

someone who knew she was expected to be admitted — and the day began.

The first women arrived in pairs, which was somehow more oppressive than

if they had come one by one. A single visitor might enter as herself.

Two entered as condolence embodied: one speaking, the other nodding,

both scented with powder and damp wool. They kissed Maryam on both

cheeks, lowered themselves into chairs, accepted coffee, and began

sorting Yusef into the approved categories of the dead. A good man,

difficult but kind. A man of books, impossible with practical matters.

Lonely at the end, but perhaps that had suited him. Sharp-tongued, but

soft-hearted. One never really knew such men.

Maryam listened and inclined her head at the right moments and thought

that death edited a life as much as it ended one. Whole sections

were cut for tone. Other sections were softened until they became almost

false. No one said he could be rude for sport, or that he held on to

letters and grievances equally, or that he had once insulted a bishop

over dessert. Yet these things had belonged to him as much as his

tenderness with Leila or his habit of arriving with oranges.

Her mother received the women as though condolence were a rank to be

conferred and properly borne. She did not rise. She let them come to

her, press her fingers, and tell her that God gave and took according to

mysteries no one could question. From time to time she laid two fingers

against her temple and closed her eyes — not theatrically, exactly, but

with the grave self-command of a woman who had decided that visible

strength might be mistaken for indifference. Maryam knew the gesture

well. It meant her mother had chosen fragility as her most dignified

form of control.

By ten o'clock there were already too many cups in the room and too many

sentences being repeated as though repetition turned them into truth.

Leila had been sent upstairs once and had come down twice. The second

time she sat on the arm of Maryam's chair and whispered, too audibly,

"Why is everyone saying he loved children when he was rude to Uncle

Fawzi?"

"Because this is not the day to inventory everything," Maryam murmured.

"It seems the best day. He cannot interrupt."

Before Maryam could answer, Father Elias arrived. He wore his ordinary

black coat rather than ceremonial dress, which somehow made him seem

more human and more clerical at once. He smelled faintly of tobacco and

rain.

"Your uncle had a restless mind," he said to Maryam after paying his

respects to her mother. "That is often mistaken for impiety by those

with calmer ones."

It was the kindest thing anyone had yet said.

"He liked to provoke people," Maryam answered.

"Only those who needed provoking."

She almost smiled. He lowered his voice. "The city is awkward today.

Some people may be late. Do not take offence at absences."

"Was there trouble?"

"A lorry stopped. A road watched. Men made nervous. It is enough these

days."

He moved away to speak with Hanna, and Maryam stood a moment with the

phrase in her mind. This was how the city entered houses now: through

altered expectations, not speeches. Someone might not come. A servant

might be delayed. A driver might take the longer road. Ordinary life had

begun carrying precautions inside it like hidden seams.

In the kitchen the real day was taking place. Amina had committed the

onions to the pot. Aunt Widad sat at the table with a list on her lap

and the expression of a woman determined to defeat chaos by accounting

for it. The errand boy was shelling pistachios as though the task

personally insulted him. Maryam had taken Leila there on the pretext of

feeding her because there was nowhere else in a condolence house to put

a child except directly in the path of labour.

Leila, seated on a low stool with bread and butter because Amina did not

believe in discussing death on an empty stomach, said, "Uncle Yusef said

Aunt Widad arranged drawers the way generals arrange borders."

For a second the kitchen froze. Even Aunt Widad had to look down to hide

the movement at the corner of her mouth.

"There you are," Aunt Widad said, recovering. "Your mother has eaten

nothing, which is foolish, and the undertaker requires the cemetery

receipt. Did Yusef keep it in that hideous leather case?"

"The hideous leather case contains theatre programmes, two tax notices,

one photograph of a woman no one can identify, and a tram ticket from

God knows when."

"Which woman?"

"I have no idea. The point is that there is no logic."

"There is always a logic," Aunt Widad said, tapping the pencil against

the page. "Only some men are too vain to make it visible."

This was one of Aunt Widad's ruling convictions, alongside the belief

that grief should be expressed in a controlled key and that servants

invariably heard more than was good for them. To watch her at that table

with her lists and pencil was to see one version of love performed as

management so steadily that it became indistinguishable from necessity.

If she could total the bread and account for missing cutlery, she did

not have to stand still before the fact that Yusef, who had tormented

her over trifles for twenty years and then brought her apricots without

ever admitting it was an apology, was gone.

The burial took place under a sky that threatened rain without

committing itself. By the time the procession formed, the undertaker had

arrived late, the committee man had forgotten the smaller wreath, a

cousin from Baq'a had been delayed by some inspection or some driver's

fear of inspection, and even the priest had the expression of a man

already calculating how long he might stay before another grief required

him.

At the cemetery gate, just as Hanna had anticipated, there was a

question about the family plot papers. The clerk, a stooped man with the

grave anxiety of minor authority, turned the pages of a ledger and said

there ought to be a supplementary notation after the death of Maryam's

grandfather, in whose name the plot had originally been registered.

Hanna produced receipts, a parish acknowledgment, and a letter with an

old church stamp. The clerk said yes, but the supplementary notation.

Father Elias said the dead would not improve by waiting while the ledger

was admired. The clerk reddened.

Hanna did not raise his voice. He never did when it mattered. He pointed

to a line on a receipt and said, "This is the parish acknowledgment when

my wife's grandfather died. This receipt shows payment for maintenance

of the same plot four years later. If you require the additional

notation in the register, it will be found. If you need to satisfy

yourself that we are not attempting to bury a family member in somebody

else's ground, you are already satisfied."

The clerk looked at Father Elias, who declined to rescue him. A moment

later he closed the ledger and said there was, of course, no difficulty.

There had never been any difficulty, Maryam thought. Only the theatre of

one.

She watched Hanna return the papers to the envelope and felt, not for

the first time, both gratitude and irritation. He was better than most

men at making institutions behave, and he did it without pride because

for him it was simply part of being a competent adult. He understood

bureaucracies in the way some men understood horses: by instinct

sharpened through attention. He knew when another man's insistence came

from rule and when it came from fear of appearing lax. She had never

loved this quality in him. She had relied on it more times than she

could remember.

The burial itself was mercifully short. Earth, prayer, the priest's

voice, women shifting their weight on uneven ground. Maryam had expected

some inward rupture proportionate to the fact of Yusef entering the

earth. What came instead was smaller and more exact: his spectacles were

still at home on the sideboard. No one would now remember properly how

much cardamom he liked in his coffee or how badly he filed anything that

mattered. The world folded the loss into a series of tasks.

On the drive back Hanna leaned forward and said quietly to the driver,

"Take the longer way," before they had fully reached the knot of men and

the lorry blocking half the road.

"Was that necessary?" Maryam asked.

"Yes."

"You did not even look."

"I had looked already."

The answer irritated and reassured her in the same instant.

When they returned, the house was full again. That was perhaps the worst

thing about a condolence day: one's own grief never remained long enough

in a room to settle before more people arrived carrying theirs, or what

they called theirs, and changed the air again. Amina moved through it

with the flattened expression of someone who had ceased expecting the

day to end at any reasonable hour. By late afternoon the front room

smelled of damp coats, coffee, tobacco, and the onions Amina had

committed to the pot because grief on an empty stomach began to look

indecent.

In the lull between callers Maryam stood alone at the window and watched

a British lorry move slowly uphill. Two boys stopped to stare at it and

then moved on. A woman crossed herself before entering the house

opposite. Farther down, someone was quarrelling with a driver in tones

of ordinary irritation. The city was maintaining itself through trivial

arguments, as though refusing to surrender the right to annoyance might

keep more frightening things at bay.

By evening the house had altered for the third time. Morning had been

preparation, afternoon endurance, evening was the work left after grief

had gone home to eat. The room was no longer crowded but marked by

occupation. Cups stood in little constellations where conversations had

ended badly or well. Ash had fallen on the turned rug despite

convictions about women who mourned properly. Two spoons were missing.

Someone had left a black glove on the sideboard beside Yusef's

spectacles. Maryam's mother had retired to bed with the exhausted

grandeur of a monarch after public duty. Leila had fallen asleep on a

blanket in Maryam's room after resisting sleep as if it were an argument

she could win. Aunt Widad still sat at the dining table with the

accounts for bread, ice, lentils, cigarettes, sugar, and candles.

"We are short four spoons," she said.

"We are short an uncle as well," Maryam answered.

"That cannot be entered as an expense."

"It will be anyway."

Aunt Widad set down her pencil. "You are tired."

"Yes."

"That is when people become clever in unhelpful ways."

This was perhaps one of the kinships between Aunt Widad and Amina: both

believed in remedies that could be set on a table. Amina put bread in

front of you. Aunt Widad counted the spoons first and then told you to

eat.

Hanna came in carrying the borrowed condolence mats rolled under one

arm. "Nabil will collect these in the morning," he said.

"Four spoons," Aunt Widad repeated.

"Then we have fed the poor more thoroughly than intended."

He set the mats down, picked up Yusef's spectacles from the sideboard,

seemed about to clean them, and then put them back untouched. That

unfinished motion struck Maryam more sharply than any open show of

grief. Feeling in Hanna only became visible after crossing a good deal

of discipline. He had respected Yusef in the way men sometimes respect

those who would not have made their lives easier but had made them

sharper.

"The porter's son will sleep in the flat tonight," he said. "It seemed

wiser than leaving it entirely empty on the first night."

"Wise," Aunt Widad said. "Did you tell him not to touch the desk?"

"I told him not to touch anything he was not eating."

That earned the first brief real laughter of the day.

Later, when Aunt Widad had gone home and Amina had wrapped the remaining

lentils and rice into smaller dishes because she would not see good food

wasted merely because educated people were tired, Hanna spread the

contents of Yusef's leather case across the dining table.

He did it with a method Maryam found almost offensive. Death ought to

leave some disorder; Hanna stacked even that.

There were the theatre programmes from the 1920s. Two tax notices. A

postcard from Alexandria on which Yusef had written only, The fish is

still better here. There were parish receipts, none bearing the precise

year they most needed. There was the photograph of the unknown woman in

an extravagant hat. There were letters from a bank written in English

and a small tied packet of papers in French which looked, to Maryam,

like the residue of some old tenancy matter or compensation claim.

"Did he understand any of these?" she asked.

"He understood enough to be annoyed by them," Hanna said.

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

He had removed his tie and rolled his sleeves. He looked like a man at

honest work, which perhaps explained some of the irritation Maryam

always felt before he had even spoken.

"This can wait until morning," she said.

"Some of it can."

"You have been saying that all day."

"Because it remains true."

She picked up the photograph of the unknown woman and turned it over.

Nothing on the back. No name. No date. No place. "It is not respectful."

"What is not?"

"This." She gestured at the papers, the case, the table. "He is barely

buried."

"If I leave a municipal notice unanswered, the municipality will not

become more reverent because your uncle is dead."

She looked down. He was right, which did not improve the answer.

There were also, he told her, papers in the flat itself: in the desk,

beneath it, in drawers, in books. The porter's son had reported that

when they righted the chair, a sheaf had slid under the table and

another had fallen from a drawer.

"Please do not describe the room," Maryam said.

"I was describing the papers."

"You know what I mean."

He did know, which was why he paused before saying only, "I know."

She picked up one of the English bank letters, then one of the French

papers, then set both down. "I can translate some of it."

"Some," he said.

She heard in that the precise measure of her limits and disliked him for

being accurate.

"What are we actually looking for?" she asked.

"Anything that tells us what he owned, what he owed, what was owed him,

what he promised, and what he neglected to arrange."

"You make him sound impossible."

"He was impossible in many of the ways men become charming only because

they are not one's husband."

The dryness of it made her look up. For once he was saying what he

thought.

"And if he had been your husband?" she asked.

"I would have put his papers in order while he was alive."

That was Hanna entire: love, to him, was often indistinguishable from

prevention.

From the kitchen came the sound of a cup breaking. Amina did not curse,

which meant she was too tired for curses. Upstairs Leila turned in her

sleep and asked for water without waking. The house had become small

again.

"We will need help," Hanna said at last, sorting the English letters

into one pile and the French papers into another.

"From whom?"

"There is a man I know."

"From your office?"

"No. A schoolmaster originally. He does translation work now as well.

Petitions, letters, forms, tenancy matters. Nabil used him once and said

he was exact."

"A stranger at the flat?"

"Not tonight. Tomorrow perhaps. If we cannot make sense of all this

first."

Maryam looked down at the papers. The thought of an outsider moving

through Yusef's disorder felt like another small violence. Yet the

alternative was worse: that the disorder should remain unsorted,

endless, humiliating, and active.

"What is his name?" she asked.

Hanna gathered the French papers into a tighter stack before answering.

"Tariq," he said. "Tariq al-Khatib."

The name meant nothing to her, which was perhaps why it stayed in the

room.

"Tariq al-Khatib," she repeated, searching for a face from weddings,

school events, church halls, offices, and finding none.

"He is Muslim?" she asked, and hated the narrowness of the question even

as she asked it.

"Yes."

"And that troubles no one?"

"Nabil is troubled by tenants who do not pay and roofs that leak. He has

a useful sense of proportion."

She might have argued. She did not. The photograph of the unknown woman

still lay between the bank letters and the receipts as though she, too,

were waiting to see what the family would do next.

In the hall Amina stood tying on her scarf, ready at last to leave. "I

may be later tomorrow," she said. "If the road by the lower gardens is

watched again, I will have to come round."

"Come when you can," Maryam said.

Amina's eyes flicked once to the sorted papers on the table. "Do not

leave the front window unlatched. The catch is loose."

Then she was gone, and the house was quiet enough at last to hear the

rain.

Maryam remained at the table after Hanna had gone upstairs. The room

smelled of coffee gone stale and rain on stone. Yusef's spectacles still

lay beside the empty blue vase. The key to his flat sat in her handbag,

heavier than its size justified. On the table were all the things that

had survived him badly: receipts, tax notices, bank letters, theatre

programmes, an unidentified woman's face, and the first practical shape

of the days ahead.

She thought of Yusef sitting at that desk with his three open letters,

speaking to her as though intelligence were not an inconvenience in a

daughter. She thought of the flat she had not yet entered since his

death — the narrow sofa, the books in double rows, the single pillow

indented beyond recovery. A life arranged to look sufficient because no

one else had been allowed fully inside it.

Death, she thought, had created no grandeur, only work. And somewhere

just beyond the circle of family, church, cousins, aunt, porter's son,

and municipal clerk, there was now a man whose name meant nothing and

would tomorrow begin meaning something.

Tariq al-Khatib.

Upstairs Leila slept. In the kitchen the last spoon was placed in the

last drawer. Rain touched the shutters with more certainty now. On the

table, in ordered little piles, lay the first evidence that whatever

sorrow the day had granted them, tomorrow would belong to papers.

CHAPTER II

Uncle Yusef's Flat

The house, the morning after a condolence, always looked faintly ashamed

of itself.

The borrowed chairs were still where exhaustion had left them. Cups

stood in the drawing room in little groups, some empty, some with a skin

of coffee gone cold and grey. The turned rug had collected ash despite

everything Maryam's mother believed about women who mourned properly. In

the hall an umbrella with a silver handle leaned against the wall with

the calm entitlement of an object convinced it belonged there. The

curtains were half drawn. The house had not yet decided whether it

remained in grief or was merely continuing.

Maryam came downstairs later than she would ordinarily have allowed

herself, not because she had overslept but because Leila had kept her

awake with questions out of the dark in a voice already thick with

sleep.

"Will he know where we put him?"

"No."

"Then how will he find us?"

"He does not need to."

"That seems rude."

By the fourth or fifth question Maryam had stopped answering and begun

smoothing the child's hair until both of them had fallen asleep from the

sheer fatigue of being alive after burial.

Now Leila sat at the breakfast table in her nightdress with one stocking

on and one off, watching Amina butter bread with the concentration

children brought to small acts of injustice.

"You said we were not going to church," she announced when Maryam

entered.

"We are not."

"Then why must I wear the better stockings?"

"Because you are staying here," Amina said before Maryam could answer,

"and I will not have you greeting respectable ladies in stockings that

make the house look abandoned."

Leila accepted bread with gloom. "Where are you going?"

"To your uncle's flat."

"I want to come."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because there will be dust, papers, your Aunt Widad, and no patience

anywhere."

"I could help with dust."

"You could help dust become worse," Amina said.

Maryam sat, though she did not want breakfast. Her mother had sent word

through the closed bedroom door that she was too tired to go to the flat

and would receive no one before noon, which meant in practice

that she would receive anyone who arrived and complain afterwards of her

weakness. Aunt Widad, by contrast, had already been heard in the passage

asking whether the leather case had been tied back up after last night

and whether Hanna had remembered to bring string. She spoke of string

the way generals spoke of flank positions.

Hanna came in as Maryam lifted her cup. He had shaved already and

changed into a fresh shirt; only the slight greyness under his eyes

admitted he had slept badly. He carried Yusef's key and a folded sheet

of paper.

"Nabil's man will come at half past ten," he said.

"That soon?"

"If we wait, the papers will remain papers. If we begin, some of them

may become answers."

"And Leila?"

"Amina."

Amina, without turning from the stove, said, "Unless the city decides

otherwise."

This was how people spoke now. Roads, visits, the time of arrival of

milk, whether a servant could cross from one quarter to another — all

rested under the broad and imprecise sovereignty of whether the city

decided otherwise.

They left Leila with Amina, who stood in the doorway as they went with

her sleeves rolled and a dishcloth over one shoulder like a soldier's

sash. Leila stood behind her in better stockings than she deserved.

"Bring me something that was his," she called.

"There is nothing there you need," Maryam said.

"That seems unfair," Leila replied, and the door shut on the rest.

They went on foot because the flat lay near enough and because walking

still preserved the fiction that the city belonged to those who moved

through it. Qatamon looked both ordinary and slightly thinned, as if

part of its attention were elsewhere. A milk cart stood outside the

Abu-Rashids' wall. Two schoolboys kicked a stone rather than a ball

because stones remained available when balls disappeared into gardens or

windows. A woman in a navy coat carried bread under her arm and nodded

to Aunt Widad, who had fallen into step beside them on the corner,

without slowing. There was no spectacle to the street, nothing a

stranger might have named crisis. Only a faint withdrawal of ease.

People looked up sooner at unfamiliar engines. Men stood a little longer

at corners talking.

Maryam kept pace beside Hanna and thought, not for the first time, that

marriage produced strange forms of intimacy and of ignorance. She knew

the exact shape of his shoulder under three of his jackets, the order in

which he buttoned cuffs, the smell of tobacco that clung to him only

after business dinners because he did not smoke and always returned

mildly disapproving of those who did. She did not know what he had felt

when he entered Yusef's flat the previous evening and found the chair

overturned and the body not yet fully cold. One could live beside a man

for years and still not know whether silence in him was absence or

concealment.

Uncle Yusef's building stood on a street that would once have seemed

merely quiet and now seemed watchful. The porter's son was sitting on

the bottom step with a newspaper open on his knee and leapt up at once.

"I slept there, as you said. In the passage. The cat objected."

"The cat?" Maryam repeated.

"The late master fed a grey one. It came through the kitchen window and

behaved as though I was the intruder."

"There is always a cat with men who live alone," Aunt Widad said darkly,

as if such arrangements encouraged one another.

Hanna took out the key. Maryam looked up at the windows of the flat and

had the sudden plain thought that a place could become strange in one

day without anything inside it having moved.

The smell met them on the landing before the room itself did. Not decay,

not yet, but the particular smell of a place inhabited by one person

whose habits had not been corrected by anyone else: books, old tobacco,

coffee grounds, dust warming slowly in a room kept too long closed, and

something faintly medicinal from the bottle the doctor must have left

uncapped. When Hanna opened the door fully the smell came out into the

stairwell with the intimacy of a secret overheard.

The flat was exactly as she remembered it. The same narrow passage, too

crowded with umbrella stand, coat pegs, and newspapers. The same sitting

room with the sofa beneath the window, its cover gone shiny where Yusef

had sat reading. Books in double rows, old receipts marking places in

them, a brass lamp with a shade permanently listing to one side. On the

low table beside the armchair sat an ashtray with two cigarette ends,

though Yusef rarely smoked unless someone particularly foolish had

visited. In the grate lay the grey remains of a fire too small to have

been worth the ash. All of it had altered by being ownerless. Yesterday

the room had belonged to a difficult, solitary man. Today it had become

evidence. Nothing in it had been arranged for posterity. That was its

mercy. Death had found it mid-sentence.

Maryam crossed to the desk and touched the edge of the blotter. The

leather was cracked where Yusef had rested his wrist for years. Beside

it lay a half-sheet in his hand containing only four words and a number:

Ask Nabil re water.

"Do not begin by touching everything," said Hanna.

"I touched the edge of a blotter."

"That is how people begin touching everything."

He opened the windows one by one. Light came in reluctantly and showed

only more dust. In the bedroom the bed had been remade badly —

one corner of the blanket tucked with conscientiousness, the other

hanging free. On the chair lay yesterday's jacket with one orange pip

dried to the cuff. An empty spectacles case on the chest of drawers. A

bottle of hair tonic. Cuff links in a saucer. The sort of objects that

suggested maintenance rather than character. One forgot, until rooms

like this, how much of a person was simply the work of continuation.

There were oranges in the kitchen beside the sink, eight of them, one

already softening. Yusef had gone up the previous evening with oranges

and died before managing them. The fact seemed so petty that it hurt

more than larger facts.

When she returned to the sitting room, Aunt Widad had stationed herself

at the round table and begun making piles according to a system she had

invented in the last thirty seconds and would defend like canon law.

Hanna had gone straight to the desk. Papers were on the floor beneath

it, and a drawer hung half open. There were envelopes, letters in

English, typed pages in French, two account books, a biscuit tin full of

receipts mixed with theatre stubs and visiting cards. On the chair lay

Yusef's jacket, carefully folded by someone else. He had never folded

jackets.

Maryam went to the bookshelf before she meant to. Between a French

grammar and a volume of sermons she found a tram ticket still serving as

a marker. The sight of it irritated her more than it sorrowed her. The

dead left behind such useless little continuities.

"Do not begin with the books," said Hanna without turning.

"I was not beginning."

"You were standing exactly like someone about to begin."

A knock sounded at the open door.

Maryam turned too quickly. A man she had never seen stood on the landing

with a hat in one hand and a leather satchel in the other. He was not

handsome in any easy way. His face was too spare, the lines of it held

close, as if excess in him had long ago been forced inward. His coat was

good but worn at the cuffs. His collar was clean. He had the look of a

man who took trouble with himself not from vanity but from some refusal

to let neglect do its usual work.

"Hanna Bey," he said. His voice was lower than she had expected,

controlled rather than rich.

"Mr al-Khatib. Thank you for coming."

Maryam knew at once that this was Tariq. The name had sat all night in

the house without an image attached to it. Now it had a body and a

manner, and both complicated things rather than clarifying them. Nothing

in him asked for favour. Nothing in him performed humility for the

household into which he had stepped.

Aunt Widad said, "You are very kind."

"It is not kindness," he answered, and then, seeing the sentence land

harder than politeness preferred, added, "Your kinsman is known to Mr

Nabil. He spoke warmly."

This was almost certainly not true. Nabil did not speak warmly of

anybody whose roof leaked or whose claims kept him from luncheon. But

the phrase served.

Hanna made the introductions. "My wife, Maryam. My aunt by marriage,

Widad Hanania."

Tariq inclined his head to each of them. His courtesy was exact, without

the faint softening men often brought into rooms like this when faced

with women they assumed needed gentleness. Maryam noticed the absence at

once.

He set down the satchel, removed his coat, and went to the desk without

asking leave. Not rudely; like a man who knew why he had been called. He

looked before touching anything. That, Maryam noticed, was the first

sign of competence in almost any field: the refusal to move until the

thing had been properly seen.

"These on the floor were dislodged yesterday?" he asked.

"So Elias says."

He touched the half-open drawer with two fingers, as though testing not

its weight but the truthfulness of its appearance. Then he looked at the

piles Aunt Widad had made.

"With your permission," he said, "I would first separate by source

rather than by apparent subject. Men like your uncle often hide their

subject under the wrong heading, but they are more faithful to the

origin of a paper than to its function."

"And how do you know that?" Aunt Widad asked.

He glanced at the biscuit tin. "Because he kept parish receipts with tax

notices and theatre programmes, but all three are still folded according

to whoever sent them, not according to what they mean. That is an

administrative conscience, however bad the filing."

Maryam looked at him properly then. Not with interest, not yet, but with

the attention one gave a person who had said something so exact that

one's own thoughts suddenly appeared slovenly by comparison.

Hanna said, "Do whatever makes them intelligible."

"That may take time."

"We have some."

Tariq rolled back his cuffs one by one. The inner wrist of one sleeve

had been patched neatly enough that the patch had almost become part of

the cloth. He drew the nearest bundle towards him, opened the blue

account book, and read two lines in silence.

"Your uncle wrote English figures as if he disapproved of them," he

said.

Even Hanna smiled.

From there the work became oddly absorbing. Tariq sorted not by tidiness

but by pressure: what would cause trouble first if left unanswered, what

concerned money already moving, what could wait, what could not. The

bank letters and insurance papers he placed to the left. Parish receipts

and cemetery matters to the centre. French pages and municipal notices

to the right. Yusef's own notes he left in a pile of their own because,

he said, men like your uncle often told the truth in irritation but

never in order.

Maryam translated where asked, though not as often as she expected.

Tariq's French was better than hers, or perhaps only less school-shaped.

He did not translate aloud every line to display possession of it. He

read, paused, and said things like, "This is a tenancy dispute that

predates the war and never understood it had ended," or, "This appears

to be water damage complicated by wounded pride."

Once he turned a page towards her and put his finger on a line in the

margin. "Is that your uncle's hand or the clerk's?"

She leaned over the desk. "My uncle's. He is calling the man a donkey,

but politely."

"Can one insult politely in French?"

"One can insult beautifully in French."

He glanced up. "And in Arabic?"

"In Arabic one need not pretend beauty is the point."

The smallest shift at the corner of his mouth acknowledged the line and

then vanished. He returned to the page without surprise or praise, and

that, more than any compliment would have done, let Maryam feel the odd

steadiness of being used accurately. Most men, discovering that a woman

knew French, treated the fact either as an adornment or an error. Tariq

treated it as one more available instrument on the table, neither more

nor less remarkable than Hanna's eye for receipts or Aunt Widad's for

missing spoons.

At the third English bank letter he tapped one line with his pencil. "If

not answered within thirty days, the account may be frozen pending

formal confirmation of holder identity. Since the holder is dead,

identity is no longer his best feature."

Maryam took the paper from him. Yusef dead, Yusef buried, Yusef mourned,

and meanwhile a bank prepared to continue the relationship only if he

proved himself in writing.

"Bureaucracy," Tariq said, as if answering a thought she had not spoken,

"does not object to death. It objects to incomplete death."

She looked up before she meant to. For one second she was not the keeper

of her uncle's papers or Hanna's wife. She was simply someone who had

heard the sentence she herself would have wanted to say had she trusted

a room to receive it.

Hanna, who trusted sentences less than outcomes, made a note in his

book.

The Armenian tenant arrived before noon. He was shorter than Maryam had

expected, with the offended briskness of a man who had practised

respectability too carefully to be denied by death. He removed his hat,

held it with both hands, and said he regretted intruding under such sad

circumstances but his trunks contained winter cloth, which if left in a

damp room would mildew beyond redemption.

Hanna handled him. Of course he did. But Tariq's presence altered the

handling. Where Hanna managed the practical dignity of the conversation,

Tariq quietly extracted the terms: three trunks and a crate, stored

since October, paid in cash to the deceased, unwitnessed. A folded

receipt more legible than any in the flat emerged from the Armenian's

inner pocket, and the matter moved at once from rhetoric to paper. The

trunks, Hanna said, might remain until week's end. The Armenian relaxed,

thanked them all, and then apologised to Maryam for mentioning mildew in

front of a lady.

When he had gone, Aunt Widad said, "He wanted to seize the moment."

"He wanted his cloth," said Hanna.

"Men's motives are always smaller than women permit them to be," said

Tariq, still looking at the receipt.

Maryam had to lower her eyes then because the sentence struck too close

to laughter.

By the time the light began flattening, the room had altered without

becoming cleaner. There were now tied bundles on the table, labelled

stacks by the desk, a separate pile for papers needing formal reply, and

one depressing heap of bills whose importance death had not improved.

The flat no longer looked like a private man's interruption. It looked

like a small office assembled inside the remains of one.

Hanna gathered the most urgent papers into the leather case. "Tomorrow I

will take the bank letters and the certificate question to the office.

After that, there is my sister's rent matter."

"Must that be tomorrow as well?" Maryam asked.

"It has already waited."

He said it without complaint, as a man stated weather. The sister's

needs, the bank's requirements, the parish records, the insurance

inquiry — all of them queued in him with the same orderly patience he

brought to claims at work. She sometimes wondered whether he experienced

obligation as weight or as architecture.

Tariq began gathering his notebook and spectacles. "I can return

tomorrow. After one — I must stop at the school first."

That was the first mention of his other life. Maryam realised, with a

small surprise, that until then she had not thought of him as existing

outside this room. The reminder that he belonged elsewhere — pupils,

lessons, another building in another quarter — made him at once more

ordinary and harder to place.

Aunt Widad said, "Bring better string if you come through the market."

Tariq looked at the tied packets. "That is the first practical order I

have heard all day."

"It is the only kind worth giving."

He inclined his head. "Then I will obey it."

On the landing, because the stair was narrow and the others were ahead,

Maryam and Tariq found themselves level for one moment.

"You knew the room well?" he asked.

It was such a small question that she nearly answered with the small

lie. Instead she said, "Well enough to know what is missing when

strangers put things in order."

He accepted that without softening it. "Order is often a form of theft,"

he said. "Sometimes a necessary one."

Then Aunt Widad called from below that the landing light was indeed

unreliable and that everyone with functioning legs ought to use them

before Providence withdrew the rest, and the moment ended exactly before

it could become one.

On the walk home, Aunt Widad asked over her shoulder, "What do you think

of him?"

Maryam said, "He is exact."

"That is not a character judgement."

"It is enough for a day."

Hanna, without turning, said, "It is more than enough for most days."

At the house they found three women had called and gone, one priest had

left a note, and Leila had made Amina read aloud from a geography primer

because apparently mourning suspended ordinary lessons only for adults.

"Did you bring me something that was his?" Leila demanded.

"No," said Maryam.

"That is mean."

"It is sensible," said Hanna.

Leila looked to Amina for justice. Amina, peeling potatoes with the

brisk vindication of a woman whose afternoon had been harder than

theirs, said, "If you want something of his, keep the card pack and stop

asking."

That night Maryam stood in the dining room with the lamp lowered and

looked at the topmost page in the packet Hanna had tied. Beneath it,

half visible, lay the lines Yusef had copied from the French novel he

had loved enough to transcribe rather than trust himself to remember.

She did not untie the string. She only stood with her fingers on it,

thinking of the flat's single pillow, the oranges softening by the sink,

the cracked blotter, and a man rolling back patched cuffs before sorting

chaos into sources.

She blew out the lamp and left the packets where they were. The work had

ceased to be one visit. Yusef's life would take longer to put in order

than any of them had yet admitted. And whatever else tomorrow required —

claims, certificates, a clerk at the bank, a road taken the longer way —

the flat would go on needing them, and Tariq would return to it carrying

better string and another morning's teaching behind him.

That was enough to know for now. More than enough for a day in which

nothing had happened except usefulness and paper.

CHAPTER III

Claims

Hanna had left before the second kettle boiled.

Maryam knew it at once from the arrangement he had left behind: the cup

on the table with coffee not entirely finished, the crust of bread on

the small plate, the butter knife laid beside it in a line too straight

to have been accidental, and the blue file tied with string where Uncle

Yusef's packet had lain the night before. Even in haste Hanna contrived

to make haste look orderly. Maryam sometimes found this reassuring and

sometimes exhausting.

Amina, standing over the stove with the expression of a woman injured by

weather and human appetite alike, said, "He took no breakfast. Coffee

standing up. Two mouthfuls of bread. Then he went."

"He said he had the office first."

"He said many things. Men say work first as if the body does not notice

being neglected."

Leila, in one stocking and no shoes, had climbed onto Hanna's chair and

was tracing the embossed pattern on his leather case with one finger.

"Does that one contain sad papers or boring papers?"

"They are often the same papers," Maryam said.

"That seems unfair."

"Most systems are."

Leila considered this with the seriousness children reserved for the

more unnecessary cruelties of adult life. "He promised to come back

before luncheon."

"When?"

"Before he left."

"That is not when. That is where."

Leila frowned, aware she had erred but not yet convinced language ought

to punish her for it. "Do people still have to work after a funeral?"

"Yes."

"That seems rude."

"It may be rude. It remains true."

Amina set the kettle down harder than she needed to. "If little ladies

are going to ask philosophy before breakfast, they may at least put both

stockings on."

On the table, beneath the string of the blue file, Maryam found the note

he had left.

Maryam,

If you can, come after one. Huda will be less agitated if there is

another woman in the room. The landlord is due at two, and she has

persuaded herself that men speaking in low voices over paper means

eviction. There is also the matter of the ceiling.

H.

No endearment, no apology for the instruction, and no explanation beyond

the practical one. That, too, was Hanna: to make a request as though

usefulness were the most ordinary thing in the world and therefore owed.

Her mother, who disliked being reminded that other households' troubles

continued during her own, tapped the note with one lacquered nail. "She

always becomes dramatic over rooms. Even before her husband died she

treated every crack in a wall as though the British had laid the mortar

personally."

"Huda lives under a leaking pipe," said Maryam.

"She lives under insufficient income, which is a different weather

entirely."

Aunt Widad, who had arrived in time to hear only the final sentence and

therefore chose at once to disagree with its tone, said, "And what do

you imagine insufficient income does to a widow's nerve? It makes her

hear rain as prophecy."

Maryam folded the note again. "I will go after luncheon."

Amina nodded as if she had settled the matter herself. "Then eat first.

People who go to other people's disasters on tea alone return with

headaches and self-pity."

The morning resumed the ordinary injured rhythm of a household returning

from public sorrow to private repair. Amina counted spoons and found one

still missing. The condolence mats were rolled and tied. Maryam's mother

came down in a wrapper of mauve silk and faint resentment and announced

that grief sat not only in the heart but in the nerves. Aunt Widad

declared that sympathy had impoverished the pantry. By half past eleven

the house had resumed its usual family argument over what had been

consumed and which relative had gone home with the better umbrella.

"Hanna should not spend the whole day on other people's roofs and rent,"

her mother said. "Your uncle has not been dead two days."

"Huda is not other people," said Aunt Widad.

"She may be his sister, but the flat and its papers concern this house

directly."

Maryam said nothing. Her mother loved rank because it arranged the world

into concentric duties with herself at the centre of the nearest one.

Hanna's sister, married years before into a less comfortable life and

widowed within it, had never fit neatly into those circles. She was

family, but not central family; pitiable, but not convenient.

She left after one, walking because the distance did not justify a car

and because the city, for the moment, still offered the illusion of

ordinary passage. The streets between their house and Huda's quarter

altered less by architecture than by means. In Qatamon the fronts still

held. Even houses falling into gentler decline managed curtains,

polished knockers, the fiction that disorder had chosen not to enter. By

the time Maryam reached the narrower street where Huda lived, the

fiction had thinned. Laundry crossed above the lane. A basket of

cabbages stood outside a greengrocer's as if the world could still be

negotiated through vegetables and weighing scales. Two little boys threw

bottle caps against a wall marked with old damp.

Huda's building was not poor, exactly. It was a building that had

resigned itself before its inhabitants did. The stair smelled of soap,

onions, and one persistent drain.

Huda opened the door before Maryam had properly knocked, as if she had

been listening for the steps. "You came," she said, and then seemed

embarrassed by the nakedness of the sentence. "Of course you came. Come

in. The kettle has boiled itself stupid twice already."

The room was small and clean and tired. The curtains had been washed so

often the pattern had almost left them. The carpet had once been red. A

blanket had been folded over the sofa arm not to look poor but to keep

it from becoming poorer. On the wall above the back room, a dark stain

spread across the plaster with the soft-edged patience of something that

had all the time in the world.

Maryam took off her coat and felt the old involuntary tightening in

herself, the one she despised. Rooms like this, where every object had

to justify its place and where care was visible because want was close

enough to bruise it, exposed something ugly in her. Pity and superiority

sat too close together.

"When did it begin?" she asked.

"After the last rains. First a stain. Then powder falling near Ibrahim's

pillow. Then the landlord promising to send a man and sending no one."

Huda poured tea into narrow glasses, her hands moving quickly because

stillness made her more transparent than she liked. "Hanna came

yesterday evening, looked up, and became very quiet."

That was another way of saying he had begun making arrangements.

"Everyone says I should move," Huda said. "Move where? On what money?

With what advance rent? Widows are told to move as though we travel like

hats."

The sentence pricked Maryam because the thought had crossed her mind.

As arithmetic, if not as judgement. Huda saw enough in her face and said,

more gently, "It is not wickedness. It is only that women who have never

had to calculate every room think in larger units."

She sat down again and folded her hands around the glass. "Do you know

what widowhood is mostly made of? It is not grief, after the first

months. Grief becomes part of the wallpaper. Widowhood is being

addressed by men who think you are suddenly a bad risk and by women who

think you are suddenly available for every weary kindness. 'Come to

luncheon.' 'Take my old curtains.' 'Have you considered moving nearer

your family?' One becomes public in the most tedious possible way."

From the back room came the sound of Ibrahim reciting something under

his breath. Maryam had met the boy at Christmas and forgotten him in the

way one forgot children who stood politely in doorways and resembled

photographs of their fathers not yet old enough to hurt.

Before Maryam could answer, the door below banged and a man's tread

sounded on the stair. Huda set her glass down too quickly. Tea spilled

into the saucer.

It was Hanna, carrying the blue file under one arm and Ibrahim at his

side. Behind them came Mr Halabi, the landlord - careful beard, careful

shoes, the practised respectability of a man who considered his own

decency an asset from which others benefited.

"What exactly is the complaint?" he asked before he was properly inside,

as though having named it complaint he might reduce its force.

Hanna prevented the argument from becoming circular by putting the blue

file on the table and opening it as though the file itself possessed

more authority than indignation. He had written the dates on which the

porter had been told, the date Huda had spoken to the landlord's wife,

the date of visible seepage, the names of the insurer and mason, and the

clause under which repairs affecting habitability could not be

indefinitely postponed. He laid the pages out one by one, not for drama

but because sequence was his native language.

"You have been busy," said Halabi.

"I dislike repeated conversations when one will do."

There was no heat in Hanna's voice. That was what made it difficult to

oppose. Men who raised their voices could be answered with more voice.

Men who remained precise in other people's rooms had to be refuted by

fact.

"The question," said Halabi, "is security. Your sister pays month to

month."

"She pays every month."

"That is not the point."

"It is always the point."

"A widow alone in uncertain times -"

"In uncertain times," Hanna said, "you want more than punctual rent. You

want assurance that if she leaves you may still claim something before

everyone begins claiming from everyone else."

The room went still. Huda looked down. Halabi said nothing for two

seconds too long.

Maryam watched her husband then as if from a slight distance. He did not

speak warmly. He did not play the outraged brother. He simply made space

around Huda in which the landlord could not crowd her without becoming

visibly mean.

The discussion lasted twenty minutes. A mason would come the next

morning. The insurer's surveyor within two days. No increase to the rent

before quarter's end. Hanna would receive a copy of the surveyor's

report. Halabi wanted it noted that the problem might not have been

visible to him earlier. Hanna allowed the phrase visible to him and

conceded nothing else.

When the landlord left, Huda remained seated for several seconds as

though movement might dissolve the agreement. Then she said, very

quietly, "If he had his way, I would have apologised for the ceiling."

"He did not have his way," said Hanna.

He was already gathering the papers back into order. "Move the bed from

the wall tonight. And the cabinet."

"I cannot move them alone."

"You are not being asked to."

He and Ibrahim shifted the bed together, scraping wood over tile. The

movement exposed a darker run of damp lower down the wall. Huda made a

small sound in her throat.

"It looks worse now," she said.

"No," Hanna answered. "It looks visible."

He pulled the cabinet clear as well, then crouched to check the skirting

board. In the narrow room his shirt pulled across his shoulders. Ibrahim

copied each gesture half a second late, eager to be useful and just old

enough not to be sent away. When the bed and cabinet had been moved,

Hanna said, "If anything comes down tonight, it will hit the chair."

"That is not comforting," said Huda.

"It is not meant to be. It is a chair."

Ibrahim, who had stood in the doorway throughout with one sock on and

the other in his hand, said, "Can I still put my books by the wall?"

"No," said Huda at once.

"You may put them on the chair," Hanna said. "And if the surveyor comes

tomorrow, do not improve the story. Tell it as it happened."

The boy nodded solemnly, absorbing this as law. There was, Maryam

thought, something almost tender in the way Hanna spoke to boys: not

softer than with adults, but more direct, as if he respected in them the

possibility of plain instruction being enough.

While Huda was in the kitchen rinsing glasses, Maryam saw the folded

receipt tucked under the sugar bowl. She should not have looked. She

looked. The school fees had been paid two days earlier in Hanna's hand.

Not a great sum. Not a small one either.

Huda came back and saw at once what Maryam had seen. "He should have

told you," she said, and then, because honesty was easier in small

rooms, added, "No. That is not true. If he had told you, it would have

become a conversation. He prefers receipts."

It stung because it was true. Maryam would have turned it into one - not

from meanness, perhaps not even from self-defence, but because she had

grown too used to reading Hanna's practical loyalty as if it were a

climate rather than a series of acts.

On the walk home she said, "You might have told me."

"About what?"

She gave him the look he deserved.

He went two more steps before answering. "It did not concern you."

"Your sister does not concern me?"

"The fees concerned her and the school. If I told you every sum I

settled for every relative, we would never speak of anything else."

It was not quite the truth. But neither was it a lie. His feeling for

money was never greedy and never ostentatious. It was structural. A sum

paid was a wall kept standing. A fee covered was a future made slightly

less damaged.

"She said you left the receipt under the sugar bowl."

He glanced at her briefly. "That was where she would find it."

"And where I would not?"

"If I wanted you not to find it, I would have put it somewhere more

imaginative."

Again that irritating accuracy, leaving no clean place for resentment.

They walked on. A delivery cart passed under canvas. Two girls in school

coats shared one umbrella and still found reason to laugh before the

corner took them. Farther up, a British jeep stood outside a building

while two soldiers smoked with the blank detachment of men to whom every

street was temporary. The city maintained its double aspect: ordinary

enough to force one to keep buying bread, altered enough that every

ordinary thing felt provisional.

At the house they found Aunt Widad and Maryam's mother in the drawing

room discussing whether one ought to send proper thanks to those who had

attended the burial or whether thanks would make a transaction of grief.

Leila was sitting on the bottom stair with Yusef's card pack, building

something that might have been a house and might have been a ruin and

was, in either case, collapsing.

"Did you bring me something?" she asked at once.

"No," said Maryam.

"Did the ceiling fall?"

"No."

"Then nothing interesting happened."

Amina appeared from the kitchen carrying a spoon she had evidently just

found. "One," she said, holding it up. "Under the sideboard. That still

leaves three unaccounted for and my faith in the parish permanently

reduced."

Hanna set down the blue file and Uncle Yusef's packet side by side.

That, Maryam thought, was perhaps the truest thing about him: he did not

know how to care for one obligation without carrying another beside it.

It ought perhaps to have moved her more cleanly than it did. Instead she

felt the familiar mixture: gratitude, irritation, admiration, fatigue.

No one of them ever arrived alone.

That evening he untied Yusef's packet again. The same papers, the same

columns of figures in his hand. He pushed one of the French pages

towards her. "This note in the margin - his?"

She leaned over. "His. He is calling the clerk a donkey, but with

grammar."

"That may help."

"It never helped him."

He made a small mark in his notes. "No. But it may help us."

On the sideboard Yusef's spectacles still waited. Outside the rain had

begun again. The house had gone quiet enough to hear a child being

called in from the lane.

Maryam put her hand on the French pages and thought that the work had

already changed shape. It was no longer one visit to one flat after one

funeral. It had become sequence. Another return. Another packet. Another

hour at the table, perhaps with Tariq al-Khatib again at the desk,

translating Yusef's disorder into categories the living could survive.

CHAPTER IV

Mrs Farah

By the first Sunday after Uncle Yusef's burial, the house had already

begun the indecent work of looking as though it could continue without

him.

The condolence mats were gone. The borrowed chairs had been carried

back. The rug had been turned the proper way again. The blue vase held

flowers because Maryam's mother had said that a house could not remain

corrected for grief indefinitely without beginning to resemble neglect,

and neglect, in her view, was not sorrow but slovenliness. Only Yusef's

spectacles remained on the sideboard because no one had yet agreed

whether removing them would count as tidiness or betrayal.

In the five days since his death, the house had settled into a rhythm

that was no longer an interruption and not yet a habit. Hanna had been

twice more to the flat and once to his sister's rooms. Tariq al-Khatib

had come twice, once with better string, as Aunt Widad had demanded,

once with a municipal form that required two copies, three signatures,

and an intelligence no municipality had yet produced. The Armenian's

trunks remained where they were. The bank wanted more proof of death

than death itself had thought necessary.

Maryam had spent the same week with the vague and irritating sense that

the neighbourhood now saw her through a second layer of glass. Not pity.

That had arrived with the first callers. Something smaller and more

persistent. A notice taken. An amendment entered in other people's

books. One was now the niece of the dead man in the upper flat, the

household through which papers moved, the family whose evenings no

longer belonged entirely to itself.

On Sunday morning her mother declared that church was indispensable.

"We are not Latins," she said, fastening her brooch. "We do not

disappear into private feeling."

Aunt Widad, who had arrived before nine in a hat too old to be

respectable and too well brushed to be called shabby, said, "No. We

disappear into church coffee and complain of it afterwards. It is our

more ancient rite."

Maryam, pinning Leila's collar while the child twisted as though proper

clothing were a personal injury, said nothing. Sunday after bereavement

required attendance not because faith demanded it but because absence

would create its own commentary. In neighbourhoods like theirs, one was

seen at church even when one was not looked at.

Leila said, "Must I come this time?"

"Yes."

"I came for the funeral."

"That was the burial."

"It had church."

"Today also has church."

"Church is repetitive."

"That is one of its points," said Aunt Widad.

The service passed with the curious collapse of time that happened when

words known by heart were spoken over lives one did not yet know how to

continue. The familiar phrases did not comfort Maryam; they refused to

flatter the novelty of her grief. God had heard too many

names, too many prayers for the newly dead, to be made dramatic by one

more. There was a kind of rough mercy in that impersonality.

Leila spent the first part examining the saints with the suspicious

concentration she reserved for painted adults who appeared both

important and inaccessible. At one point she whispered, too audibly,

"Why do they all look as though they know a secret and do not approve of

it?"

"Hush," Maryam murmured.

"Do saints mind children?"

"Not if children mind saints first."

"That seems like a poor arrangement."

Hanna, a little forward among the men, did not turn, but she saw his

shoulders shift. He had heard. Whether he was suppressing amusement or

the desire to exercise authority in a building that belonged, for once,

to a higher management than his own, she could not tell. With him the

two often shared a border.

Maryam found herself looking not at the icon screen but at the backs of

heads, at the tilt of Mrs Farah's hat three rows ahead, at the way

Father Elias paused before the longer prayer, at the child who had

fallen asleep against his grandmother's side, at the hand with which

Hanna steadied Leila when the child swayed from boredom and then removed

his hand at once, as though even protection should not become

conspicuous. She thought that parish life

trained the body in humility and the mind in surveillance. One knelt,

crossed oneself, accepted the kiss of peace, all while seeing who had

come late, whose daughter had changed her hat, which widow had stopped

wearing her ring too soon, which family now occupied the pew where the

Jiryeses had once sat before leaving for Beirut and calling it

temporary.

Outside, after the final blessing, the courtyard became what it always

became on Sundays: a market of manners. One could not cross from the

door to the gate in a straight line without consenting to seem

monstrous. Women arranged themselves into clusters according to kinship,

appetite, and old grievances. Men formed looser groups around politics,

business, and municipal complaints.

Three women stopped Maryam within as many yards. None asked directly

about Yusef. One asked after her mother's nerves. Another after Leila's

sleep. A third wanted to know whether the cemetery matter had settled

itself.

Mrs Farah approached not like an enemy but like weather. There was

nothing in her manner to justify offence. She simply moved through other

people's lives with an attention that made privacy feel self-indulgent.

She wore dark silk and a spray of violets pinned a little too close to

her shoulder and carried a small prayer book she had almost certainly

not opened again after leaving the pew.

"My dear," she said to Maryam's mother, and then to Aunt Widad,

"Thursday was very well done. So many people. One could see he was

cherished, whatever one says about difficult men."

"He had his qualities," said Aunt Widad.

"And his papers, apparently," said Mrs Farah lightly. "You are fortunate

that that translator gentleman has been so useful. He seems almost one

of the family already."

Maryam was near enough to hear and far enough to pretend she had not.

She bent towards Leila, who was trying to determine whether the widow

Elias's handbag might contain sweets. Mrs Farah continued, still in the

same harmless tone.

"I saw him leaving rather late one evening. Poor Amina was still

carrying tea at dusk. It is a mercy when competent help appears at the

proper time."

There it was. No accusation. No sharpened pause. Nothing except

observation in the same register one might use to note that the Karabets

had repainted their shutters or that the butcher's new apprentice was

clumsy with string. That was what made it land. Warning implied danger.

Observation implied record.

Maryam kept her face still. Her mother made the small sound she made

when a truth and a displeasure arrived together. Aunt Widad said, "He is

exact."

"Exactness is a blessing in men and a burden in women," said Mrs Farah.

"That is how one knows God was in a complicated mood when He made us."

Two women laughed. Mrs Farah pressed one more condolence into the

conversation, touched Maryam's sleeve with fingers always cooler than

the weather required, and moved on towards another cluster.

Only after she had gone did Aunt Widad say, in a tone pitched just

inside humour, "You see? We have discovered competence and now the

quarter will never let us forget it."

Maryam kept her eyes on Leila, who had finished investigating the widow

Elias's handbag and was now rubbing sugar from the sweet she had found

onto the rail of the church steps with devotional concentration. She

wiped the rail with her glove, more sharply than the action required.

A little later, when her mother had been manoeuvred as far as the gate

and Aunt Widad had been captured by someone else's difficulty, Maryam

heard her name in a voice she liked before she fully recognised it.

Nawal Khoury stood just beyond the church wall in a hat that would have

looked too jaunty on another woman and on Nawal looked merely like a

refusal to surrender entirely to widowhood, or whatever half-condition

she now occupied between widow, sister, aunt, and independent nuisance.

She was perhaps ten years older than Maryam and had the sort of face on

which fatigue turned first into candour rather than complaint.

"You are impossible to catch," Nawal said. "I had to wait until God had

had His portion of you."

Maryam kissed her lightly. "You were away Thursday."

"My cousin's boy had a fever, and his mother received it as a personal

attack from heaven." Nawal looked at her properly then. "How are you?"

Nawal had the irritating gift of hearing arrangement inside arranged

sentences.

"Tired," Maryam said.

"Good. Tiredness is at least true."

They moved aside to let two men pass. Nawal's gloves were old and

beautifully kept. The seam on the right thumb had been repaired so

carefully it looked original until one saw it.

"I kept meaning to come yesterday," she said, "but my sister insisted on

feeding every relation she possesses and three she does not. One should

never allow bad timing to marry family duty. They produce whole litters

of obligation."

Maryam smiled. She always smiled more easily with Nawal than with women

who asked less effort of her. Perhaps because Nawal did not present

herself as a moral success.

"I am at the Semiramis for another week at least," Nawal went on. "Aunt

Salma has taken rooms there while her brother's people from Jaffa decide

whether property papers are still a form of reality or only of hope. She

dislikes hotels, hotel food, hotel widows, and me. Come one afternoon

and save us both."

"You are staying there?"

"Do not sound as if I have joined a touring company. Simply come. Around

four. Before supper and before Aunt Salma begins explaining why girls

who read novels lose whatever small chance they had of good judgement."

Years earlier, after Leila's birth, when half the women Maryam knew had

descended on her room carrying broth, advice, and improved versions of

pity, Nawal alone had said, "You look as though everyone has been

congratulating you into exhaustion," and then removed two over-scented

bouquets without asking because the child had begun sneezing. Maryam had

loved her a little for that and mistrusted herself for loving anyone on

such practical grounds.

"I will come," Maryam said, and meant it in the clean uncomplicated way

one meant a thing still far enough away not to require moral force.

"Good," said Nawal. "If you delay, I shall count it as vanity and not

misfortune."

"That is an unkind way to secure a visit."

"It is an efficient one."

Leila appeared at Maryam's side as if conjured. "Who is she?"

"This is Mrs Khoury."

"I know that. Who is she really?"

Nawal laughed, not loudly but with genuine pleasure. "A scandalous woman

with an excellent jam cupboard."

"What makes you scandalous?" Leila asked.

"Persistence," said Nawal.

"That does not sound scandalous."

"No. That is why it works."

From the gate her mother signalled. "Wednesday or Thursday," Nawal said.

"Before you vanish into papers again."

"I will come."

"Come before dusk if you can. My sister becomes virtuous after dark and

impossible before supper."

On the walk home, with her mother in front and Aunt Widad beside them

recounting how Mrs Farah's daughter had once nearly lost an engagement

through nothing worse than badly timed honesty, the remark returned to

Maryam as enclosure rather than insult. The translator gentleman. Almost

one of the family already. Amina carrying tea at dusk. Nothing false in

any of it. Nothing one could publicly resent. The neighbourhood had

simply recorded what it saw, and the record, once entered, did not

require malice to do its work.

Her mother said nothing about it on the walk. That was worse. Silence in

her never meant the subject was closed. It meant the subject had been

filed for better conditions.

At luncheon the conditions arrived. Hanna had joined them after speaking

with Father Elias by the gate. He ate as he always did in working weeks:

with the concentration of a man to whom food was fuel. Her mother waited

until the lentils were served, then said, with the precision of someone

who had rehearsed the approach during the entire walk home and the

better part of one sherry, "He should not remain there in the evening."

Hanna did not look up. "Who?"

"The translator gentleman. Mrs Farah saw him leaving after seven."

"He was there because the municipal copy arrived after office hours."

"Municipal copies do not improve by moonlight."

Aunt Widad set down her fork. "The point is simple. The work remains

necessary. The hour requires managing."

Hanna nodded once. "Then I will manage the hour."

He accepted that a new fact had entered the problem and that procedure

would alter.

"What does that mean?" her mother asked.

"It means I will not ask him to stay late. If copying must be done after

school, it can be done at the stationer's rather than at the flat."

"That is better," her mother said, in the tone of a woman to whom better

and pleasant had always been dangerously conflated.

Maryam said nothing. The trouble with her mother was that she could

occasionally be right for reasons too mean to endorse and too accurate

to dismiss. There was no impropriety in Tariq's work at the flat. There

was only the fact of being seen. In places like theirs, one did not wait

for impropriety itself. One managed in anticipation of the commentary

that might gather around it.

Amina, carrying away the first emptied dish, said under her breath as

she passed Maryam, "So now paper will go out walking instead of staying

in its proper room."

Maryam should have corrected her. Instead she said, equally low,

"Apparently."

The afternoon dissolved into its separate domains. Her mother rested.

Aunt Widad went home. Leila built and demolished card houses on the

drawing-room carpet until Amina removed her upstairs with a firmness

that required no second attempt. Hanna remained at the dining table with

Yusef's packet and one lamp lit, making notes in his narrow hand and

once or twice reaching for the spectacles on the sideboard as if

proximity to the dead man's lenses might improve the legibility of the

living problem.

Maryam sat with a mending basket she did not need and did not mend. She

sorted handkerchiefs into one pile and socks into another and then

looked for a long time at the socks. The neighbourhood beyond the shutters resumed its ordinary

Sunday sounds: a radio somewhere too loud, boys being called in before

supper, a door closing, another opening, a dog objecting to the

existence of bicycles. Ordinary life. That was the phrase everyone used

for the thing they were losing without yet admitting it. One clung to it

— the phrase and the life — as if both might be preserved by repetition.

After a while Hanna said, without looking up, "Will you go to Mrs Khoury

this week?"

"Nawal. Yes."

"Which day?"

"I said Wednesday or Thursday."

"Then choose one before Wednesday becomes Thursday and neither becomes

anything."

It was exactly the sort of sentence that would have sounded oppressive

from another man and from Hanna emerged merely as the practical

translation of time. Yet it irritated her because it was true, and

because Nawal's invitation, which had felt so easy to accept under the

church wall, already had to pass through the machinery of other

obligations before it could become real.

"Wednesday," she said.

He nodded as though a form had been properly completed.

That evening, after Leila had surrendered her cards and her indignation

and been carried upstairs by Hanna with the same practical steadiness he

brought to every small body and large problem, Maryam stood for a moment

at the dining-room window while he bent over Yusef's packet at the table

behind her. Outside, the rain had begun again. The neighbourhood was

shutting itself down in the usual way: a radio silenced, a shutter

drawn, someone calling a child in from the lane. Ordinary life closing

its books for the night.

She thought of Mrs Farah's cool fingers on her sleeve. Of the phrase

almost one of the family, spoken in the same tone one might use to note

that a shutter had been repainted. Of her mother's silence on the walk

home, which was never silence but only patience in better clothes. Of

Aunt Widad saying at luncheon, as if it were practical: the hour

requires managing.

And of Nawal, touching her wrist in the church yard, saying come before

you vanish.

Wednesday. She meant it. That was always the trouble with failures of

attention. One usually meant them until something smaller and more

immediate took the place where intention had been.

CHAPTER V

Papers and Pretexts

The first violence done to a house by death was public. The second was

domestic. One went back to breakfast.

Leila refused egg on the principle that mourning had already imposed

enough discipline without further assistance from poultry. Amina put the

plate in front of her again. Her mother, still in her wrapper, said that

children heard too much when left at table after nine. Aunt Widad, who

had arrived before breakfast carrying her handbag of papers, receipts,

and emergency notions, replied that people heard too little everywhere

else.

Hanna came in with Yusef's leather case under one arm and two tied

packets under the other. He set them beside the marmalade as if paper

had every right to breakfast.

"These need copying," he said. "One set for the municipality, one for

the bank, and one in case either of them develops a taste for

repetition."

Her mother looked at the packets as if they had been placed there

specifically to affront her. "Must they sit beside the food?"

"They must go somewhere."

"Not beside the marmalade."

"Then after the marmalade."

He untied the upper packet. Maryam saw the municipal form, one of

Yusef's receipts, two English letters from the bank, and the typed

French pages regarding the lower room's water damage. The papers had

already begun to lose their first shock and acquire instead the

exhausted familiarity of an illness one had accepted would not depart

because one was bored of it.

"Habib will make the copies," Hanna said. "On Jaffa Road."

Her mother put down her spoon. "Why Habib?"

"Because Habib has a machine and carbon paper, and because after

yesterday's useful conversation it seems better that copying be done

there rather than at the flat after school."

He said it without edge. What most infuriated people when Hanna was

right was that he made no performance of it. He merely altered

procedure.

"And who will take them?"

"I must go first to the office and then to Huda's landlord. If I take

them, they will sit in my desk until afternoon. Habib said yesterday he

could do them by midday if someone brought them before ten." He looked

at Maryam. "You can leave them and collect them later."

The sentence sounded simple enough.

"If you are going into town," her mother said at once, "bring back black

ribbon. The better kind. And if Habib has mourning envelopes still, two

packets."

"I am going for copies, not supplies."

"That is how errands become suspect. They return empty-handed and call

it purpose."

Leila said, "Bring me a slate pencil."

"You have two."

"One is short and the other is unjust."

Amina set down the toast rack. "If ladies are making lists, add hooks

for the blue dress in the upstairs cupboard. It is hanging by one

shoulder like a sinner."

Maryam might have objected. She did not. The packet on the table had

already begun attracting cover to itself. Ribbon, envelopes, a slate

pencil, hooks. One errand now contained four. None of them was false.

Together they formed a screen.

Hanna retied the string. "Ask for Habib himself. Not the boy with the

blotched chin. He charges for mistakes twice."

"Why does everyone in this city answer to the wrong boy first?" Aunt

Widad said.

"Because the right man is usually at the back pretending not to listen,"

said Amina.

Maryam smiled despite herself. Because it had come too easily, she

lowered her eyes at once to hide it. She was still the niece of the dead

man in the upper flat, still the woman whose household had been entered

in the quarter's record by Mrs Farah's mild observation. One could not

go smiling into Jaffa Road on a Monday morning as though paper and

absence had become diverting.

After breakfast Hanna put on his hat in the hall. "When you collect the

copies, count them there," he said. "Do not trust bundles tied by any

man whose ink gets under his nails."

He left. Amina, already tying her scarf because she meant to go out for

lentils, handed Maryam the better umbrella.

"It is not raining," Maryam said.

"It has not yet decided."

Then, lowering her voice: "If paper is going walking, it may as well

come home carrying groceries."

"Apparently that is the family doctrine."

"It is not doctrine," said Amina. "It is camouflage."

The word landed too squarely to be comfortable. Before Maryam could

answer, Amina was already on the step, pulling her scarf tighter against

a wind that had not quite decided whether it belonged to autumn or

something harsher.

Jaffa Road was not far enough to justify a car and too far to feel like

a household errand only. One had to enter the city for it. That was

perhaps why Maryam felt the mild unease proper to any excursion beyond

purely domestic boundaries — the smaller, more social knowledge that one

might be seen by people who did not know why one was there and would

therefore improve the reason for themselves.

The morning had not yet settled into heat. Shop shutters were being

raised. The tram bell clanged with the impatience of a governess. A boy

pushed a handcart of copybooks towards the school quarter. Two British

soldiers stood outside a post office smoking with the boredom of men

placed in a country too long. At the baker's a woman in a green coat

argued over change with such conviction that one might have thought

sovereignty hung on the coppers. Men spoke at corners in clusters that

looked casual until one noticed how they did not disperse when no

transaction required it.

One still bought bread and walked to stationers and offices. One simply

did it under an extra layer of attention, as if other eyes had acquired

rights in the matter.

Habib's shop stood between a bookseller and a man who repaired fountain

pens while pretending to despise anyone who used them. In the window

were exercise books, cheap envelopes, black sealing wax, two bottles of

violet ink, and a framed certificate from some British supply company

that had yellowed without losing its self-importance. Above the door,

the sign announced Stationery and Copying in Arabic and English, though

time and rain had made the English look doubtful of itself.

Inside, the place smelled of paper, dust, glue, and the metallic heat of

the copying machine. Habib himself stood at the counter with a loupe in

one eye and a pen behind his ear, smaller than Maryam remembered from

schooldays and more irritated-looking. An apprentice folded foolscap

beside him.

Maryam laid the order note and packet on the counter. "My husband sent

these."

Habib took the note first, not the packet. "Ah. Hanna Bey. Death,

certificates, municipal copies. A profitable sorrow."

The apprentice looked alarmed. Habib ignored him.

"Will it be by noon?" Maryam asked.

"If the machine behaves. If it does not, by one. If the electricity

chooses patriotism rather than function, by two."

He weighed the packet in his hand. "Mr al-Khatib?"

"He is coming."

"He always comes with too much exactness for my liking and too little

tolerance for my nephew's hands."

He disappeared behind the curtain with Yusef's papers. The machine's

clicking changed, became angrier, and then steadied.

Maryam stood at the side shelf with mourning envelopes in hand and

pretended to compare the weight of paper. Two schoolgirls came in for

copybooks, speaking in English because the school morning had not yet

released them into their first language. A clerk from the Patriarchate

arrived with a ledger and left muttering that no one in authority ever

read the second copy. The apprentice licked his finger to separate

stamps, failed, and licked it again with hopeless persistence.

When the door opened again, she knew before seeing him that it would be

Tariq.

He came in without haste, a satchel under one arm and two rolled forms

in hand. He wore the same dark coat as at the flat, though with a

different shirt, and he had not yet shed the expression of school from

his face — the concentration of a man who had spent the morning

persuading other people to submit to grammar. He took off his hat when

he saw her and paused just long enough for surprise to register and be

mastered.

"I did not know you would be here," he said.

"Neither did I," she answered.

He set his own forms on the counter. "Habib?"

"In mechanical distress."

"That is his natural habitat."

There was no space in the shop for a conversation that could admit

itself. Every sentence had to fit alongside ledgers, schoolboys, and the

possibility of interruption. Oddly, that made speech easier. One did not

have to mean more than one said. One had to say it exactly.

Habib emerged with one copied sheet held to the light. "The machine has

developed religious scruples. Half the stamp disappears in the second

copy."

Tariq took the page. "Stamp the first copy and note by hand on the

second that the original bore the full seal."

"And when the municipality objects?"

"The municipality will object whether the stamp is whole or pious."

Habib considered this. "You spent too much time among children."

"It has made me empirical."

The sheet went back through the curtain. Habib returned with the parish

receipt. "This will be one copy."

"Two," said Maryam, surprising herself. "If one is lost, I will not come

back here to grieve over paper."

Tariq looked at her properly then. Not long. Long enough.

"Two," he said.

Habib, already writing the number in his book, gave no sign of having

witnessed a correction. That was perhaps his greatest professional gift.

He treated every customer's self-possession as part of the goods.

While the French pages were copied upstairs, Tariq worked through the

insurance sheet at the counter. He unfolded it and laid a finger at the

margin.

"Water damage from the ceiling in your uncle's back room," he said. "He

had written three letters, none answered. This acknowledgment proves

only that someone received the complaint."

"Is that enough?"

"It is more than complaint alone. Less than remedy."

"Which is the natural relation between the two."

Something moved at the corner of his mouth and was gone.

She leaned closer to read the English line. The insurance clerk's hand

was thin and self-important. Below it, on the French page, Yusef had

added a marginal note so sour that even Maryam could recognise its

contempt.

"Did you tell Habib to copy even the insult?"

"No. Your husband did. Or rather he instructed that the French pages be

copied exactly, which in a man like your uncle includes insult as

naturally as punctuation."

"Hanna is very faithful to documents."

"He is faithful to consequences."

The sentence irritated her because it carried both respect and limit

without false generosity.

"You say that as though faithfulness to consequences were a species of

deficiency."

Tariq folded the page. "No. Only as a species."

A customer entered just then, sparing them any need to answer the

answer. The apprentice knocked over a jar of nibs. Habib closed his

eyes.

"One day I shall replace every boy in this city with a better table."

"No," said Tariq. "The table would only ask for wages."

Maryam had to look away.

When the French pages came down at last, Habib inspected them, corrected

one misplaced accent himself, and stacked the copies with the originals.

"All exact. The insult reproduced with respect."

She paid for the copying, ribbon, envelopes, hooks, and the slate pencil

that waited best. Tariq paid for exercise books and ink separately. The

division, conducted so cleanly in public, seemed part of the thing that

could not be named: not intimacy, not distance, but a competence in not

obliging one another falsely.

He picked up one of the school copybooks. On the cover was the old line

about duty, discipline, and national improvement.

"The Ministry still uses this?" he asked Habib.

"The Ministry uses whatever was printed before it lost its courage."

Maryam took the copybook from his hand. "National improvement through

this paper?"

"Perhaps the nation is being held back by poor margins," he said.

Their eyes met then, not because either meant them to but because the

sentence had landed between them fully formed and neither could pretend

it had not.

She set the copybook down first.

Outside, the pavement was momentarily blocked by a wagon unloading tins.

For a few seconds they stood near the shop door watching the negotiation

of commerce and obstruction.

"This is an improvement on dusk," Tariq said.

It took her a second to understand he meant the new geography of the

papers.

"Yes," she said. "Though it leaves less room for error."

"Public rooms do that."

"And private ones do not?"

He looked at the wagon, not at her. "Private rooms permit invention.

Public rooms permit only reputation."

Before she could answer, Habib's nephew called that the way was clear, and the moment was

forced forward into movement.

"You are returning home?" Tariq asked at the corner.

"Yes."

He hesitated just enough to make the hesitation visible and not enough

to require comment. "The post box is two doors down. If you mean to send

anything."

She had Nadia's reply still unwritten. He could not know that. It was

public talk. It could not be misunderstood without someone first

deciding to misunderstand it.

"I mean to buy stamps first," she said.

He inclined his head and went back towards the school quarter with his

forms under his arm.

At home her mother asked whether the copies were complete. Amina asked

whether the blotched boy had survived. Leila asked whether the

translator gentleman had laughed. Maryam answered the first, gave the

second enough shape to satisfy the kitchen, and ignored the third.

Only after luncheon, when Hanna had gone back to the office with the

bank letter and one municipal copy, did Nadia's letter find her alone.

It lay on her dressing table beneath the silver-backed brush, thinner

and bluer than the house's own paper. Nadia had always preferred

stationery that made itself visible across a room.

Maryam sat on the edge of the bed and opened it with the hairpin already

in her hand.

Beirut, Nadia wrote, had turned out to be exactly as everyone had

promised and not at all as anyone had meant. The flat was smaller than

the word flat ought decently to cover. The coffee in the first week had

been weak enough to imply a moral defect in the landlord's family.

Everywhere there was talk of who had come, who had not yet come,

who had come only for a fortnight, and who was already pretending the

fortnight had meant something longer.

If matters become too unpleasant, come at once, Nadia wrote. There is no

room, naturally, but room is a concept on which civilisation places

excessive emphasis. We will stack one another artistically and call it

temporary. Everything is temporary. Beirut is tiresome but civilised,

which at present feels like praise. Bring papers first and silver

second. Leave sentimental objects to those with larger luggage and

weaker sense.

The tone was brisk, managerial, faintly pleased with its own resilience,

and beneath all that something else Maryam did not yet want to name.

Nadia had always made discomfort sound like anecdote until the anecdote

revealed, by accident, the shape beneath it. Even now there were slips

in the gaiety: a line about children underfoot written too sharply, a

remark about borrowed rooms that had not quite disguised the humiliation

of dependence, a small gap before the sentence insisting everything was

temporary.

Maryam read the letter twice and then looked through the window at the

Abu-Rashids' washing line, where one white sheet and three little vests

moved in the thin wind. Beirut. Papers first and silver second. Come at

once if matters become too unpleasant, though of course they probably

would not. The thought of going seemed both impossible and falsely

available, real enough to imagine and not yet real enough to choose.

She answered at once because that was what one did with the first letter

from elsewhere. One did not leave it. She wrote that they had had a

death in the family and the house had been full beyond patience. She

wrote that Leila was well, Hanna overworked, her mother grand in grief,

Aunt Widad more useful than any government office, which would have

offended Aunt Widad and therefore made it true. She wrote that Jerusalem

remained itself in most outward ways, that the quarter was still full of

women who mistook observation for charity and men who mistook paper for

power, that there was no need yet to think of artistic stacking in

borrowed rooms. She signed with more warmth than she

had felt while reading and sealed the letter before warmth could thin

under revision.

Only then did she realise she had written there is no need yet where

once she might have written simply there is no need. The small adverb

seemed to have entered the sentence without permission. She disliked it

enough to consider opening the letter and writing the whole thing again.

She did not. That would have been theatre for an audience of one.

Late in the afternoon, after Hanna had gone back to the office and Aunt

Widad had left carrying half the shelled peas because she claimed

shelling in one district and cooking in another saved money and kept the

mind from politics, Maryam walked up to the flat because Hanna had asked

her to bring back the blue account book before evening.

The room was emptier by almost nothing and different by more than that. One chair had

been moved to the wall. Two bundles were gone from the round table. The

cat was asleep on the bed as if ownerlessness had already taught it the

geography of advantage. On the desk lay one blotter, one penknife, and a

page in Yusef's hand beginning, as so many of his notes did, with a

grievance against a man whose name he had reduced to initials as if even

in anger the full identity bored him. At the end he had written in a

slant steeper than the rest: They mistake delay for power because they

have never had work worth doing.

Maryam sat in his chair and looked at the sentence longer than it

deserved. It sounded like him. It sounded also like something the city

itself might have written if the city kept a notebook and no fear of

libel.

She found the blue account book where Hanna had said it would be,

beneath the municipal notices and beside the tin of receipts. As she

tied the string again she realised, with some annoyance, that she was

now looking at the room partly through Tariq's categories: source,

pressure, what mattered first, what could wait, what truth irritation

had accidentally preserved. It seemed an intrusion of a particularly

elegant kind and therefore harder to resist.

At supper her mother asked whether Nadia sounded comfortable or merely

brave. Aunt Widad asked what cousins in Beirut ate and whether landlords

there were Levantine or French. Hanna, late again, asked only for the

copied packet.

"And?" her mother said, because answers were not answers until shaped

for table use.

"She says Beirut is cramped and civilised," Maryam said.

"That sounds worse than Jerusalem," said Aunt Widad.

"It sounds like Beirut," said Hanna, already checking the pages.

"Her advice?" asked Aunt Widad.

"Papers first and silver second."

Her mother looked offended. "Silver? Who takes silver in a crisis?"

"People with silver," said Aunt Widad.

"There is no crisis."

"There is always a crisis somewhere," said Aunt Widad. "The question is

when it learns your address."

Her mother said, "Wednesday, Maryam."

"What about Wednesday?"

"Mrs Khoury. If you are going, go."

"Nawal," Maryam said, because Hanna had looked up. "Her aunt has taken

rooms at the Semiramis."

"Which day?"

"Wednesday."

Hanna nodded as though a form had been properly completed. "Then go

before dusk."

"Why before dusk?"

"Because after dusk your mother will worry, and before dusk you may

still return to this house as though it is a house rather than a public

institution."

"That is not a romantic reason."

"It is not meant to be."

That evening, after the lamps were lit and the house had settled into

weekday quiet, Maryam addressed Nadia's envelope and placed it on the

hall table so it would not be forgotten in the morning. Then she stood

with her hand on the wood and realised she was thinking not of Beirut,

nor of weak coffee, nor of Wednesday with Nawal, but of noon at Habib's

and the fact that a sentence about paper margins and nations had made

her feel, for an instant, less alone in her own exactness.

That was absurd. It was also true.

Upstairs Leila called for water. In the drawing room her mother coughed

in the manner that announced dissatisfaction rather than illness. Amina

put away the last cup. Life resumed its innumerable small demands, all

of them innocent one by one.

Maryam moved Nadia's letter half an inch straighter on the hall table

and thought of Wednesday and of tomorrow, when there would likely be

another errand, another packet, another hour shaped by house, flat,

street, paper, and the exact man moving between them. Wednesday and

tomorrow sat side by side in her mind, each asking to be treated as

though it were only an errand.

CHAPTER VI

The Radio

On the last Saturday of November the air had the cold exactness

Jerusalem sometimes produced without warning, as if the stone itself had

cooled overnight and were now returning its judgement to anyone foolish

enough to touch a railing bare-handed.

Leila, looking out into the pale street before breakfast, announced that

the day resembled a doctor.

"Why a doctor?" Maryam asked.

"Because it looks clean and unfriendly."

Amina, carrying tea into the dining room, said, "That is better than

most doctors I have met. Drink before it becomes unfriendly as well."

The house was not at ease, though there was no obvious reason a stranger

might have named. Saturday had been intended for account books, mending,

and perhaps the last box from Uncle Yusef's wardrobe, which Aunt Widad

had declared must contain either tax papers or moral compromise because

no bachelor kept a locked box for innocent reasons. Instead there was a

waiting in the air that moved ahead of explanation. Men had stood longer

at corners the evening before. The butcher's boy had carried gossip with

his meat and been told twice to shut his mouth. Her mother had gone to

bed saying only that America ought not to be trusted with maps because

Americans named places after themselves and then expected gratitude.

By the end of November, Uncle Yusef's papers had ceased to behave like

grief and begun behaving like work.

This was a relief in some ways and an insult in others. During the first

weeks after a death, disorder could still borrow a little dignity from

feeling. A pair of spectacles left on the sideboard might be called

tenderness. A packet of receipts on the dining table might be called

continuation. By the time autumn had hardened towards winter, however,

the same spectacles had become something people dusted round, and the

receipts had begun travelling from flat to stationer's, from stationer's

to house, from house back to office, gathering stamps, annotations, and

the exhausted familiarity of a problem no longer dramatic enough to

excuse itself.

The leather case lived more often on the dining table now than in the

sideboard. The Armenian had removed his trunks after two more receipts

and one more objection. The bank still required proof of death from men

who were clearly incapable of appearing in person. The water-damage

dispute in the lower room had multiplied into a second clerk and a

blue-ribboned file. Tariq al-Khatib had, by degrees, become one of those

names spoken in the house without preliminaries. He was no longer the

translator gentleman except in her mother's more brittle moods. He was

simply Tariq. Houses like theirs shortened names quickly once work

began arriving daily. Names altered by usage. So did rooms.

At breakfast Hanna ate quickly and without comment until the tea had

been poured, Leila had rejected one egg on the grounds that sadness had

already demanded too much sacrifice from children, and her mother had

asked whether Aunt Widad intended to sit all morning over the account

book like a tax collector at the gates of hell.

Only then did he say, "The vote is today."

Her mother looked up. "Which vote?"

"The United Nations."

Aunt Widad, shelling peas into a bowl because no serious conversation in

her hands ever remained unaccompanied by some lesser form of order,

said, "So the gentlemen in New York are awake at last."

"What time?" Maryam asked.

"Not yet. This afternoon perhaps. But the reports will come in fragments

first." He glanced towards the drawing room. "We should keep the

wireless on."

Her mother made a small dismissive sound. "I dislike hearing foreign men

divide cities they could not find on foot."

"You may dislike it more if others hear first," said Hanna.

This was one of Hanna's more useful gifts: he rarely argued with an

opinion when the practical consequence of it could do the work instead.

Leila said, "Who is being divided?"

"No one," her mother answered too quickly.

"Then why is everyone talking as if they are cutting a cake?"

Amina put another piece of bread on the table and said, "Because grown

people discuss disaster best when it sounds like luncheon."

The wireless had to be coaxed into cooperation. Hanna carried it from

the side room to the drawing room because the plug there behaved more

faithfully. Its wooden case had a scratch from the year Leila had tried

to see whether saints could hear the BBC if the dial was turned hard

enough. For some time it produced only static, then the tail end of a

dance band, then static again, and finally a voice in Arabic so smooth

and self-assured that Maryam mistrusted it before it had delivered

anything at all. The room arranged itself around the set with the

awkwardness of people pretending not to concede its authority.

Her mother remained in the high-backed chair with her hands folded over

a handkerchief she was not using. Aunt Widad took the edge of the sofa,

still shelling peas into her apron because a hand once set to work would

not surrender itself to politics. Leila was placed on the rug with

copybooks on the strict condition that she ask no questions while the

announcer spoke, a condition she violated within three minutes and then

continued violating with enough regularity that it ceased to be

scandalous and became part of the room's rhythm. Only Amina moved

as usual. She laid out cups, fetched bread, opened and shut doors, and

let the wireless speak over her shoulder as though foreign men dividing

cities were one more domestic inconvenience, no more dignified than milk

boiling over.

The first reports came as reports often did then: incomplete, already

shaped by the tone in which they were delivered, and accompanied by

opinions too finished to have been formed by facts. The announcer spoke

of speeches, proposals, abstentions, numbers. He used the phrase

international administration, which made her mother close her eyes. He

used the phrase partition, which made Aunt Widad stop shelling peas for

the first time in twenty minutes. He used the phrase Jerusalem to be

placed under a special regime, which meant less than it should have and

more than anyone liked.

"Special to whom?" her mother asked the room.

"Men who do not live here," said Aunt Widad.

Hanna said, "It is only paper yet."

"And paper never becomes anything?" her mother asked.

"Paper becomes trouble when men decide to carry it."

After Mrs Farah's remark, Hanna had done exactly what he said he would

do. Work that might once have stretched untidily into dusk at Uncle

Yusef's flat now found its way, by bundles and pretexts, into public

rooms: Habib's counter, the school office, the dining table beneath the

lamp. No one had declared this an arrangement. It had become one all the

same. Maryam noticed, and because she noticed, thought more often than

she wished about how little in Qatamon required outright prohibition.

Timing altered, doors remained open, one errand acquired another

companion, and private life adjusted itself under the weight of other

people's eyes.

Maryam had not meant to learn the shape of his routine. She knew,

however, that he arrived most often carrying two things at once, because

men who worked for themselves learned early that one errand must carry

another. She knew his cuffs were mended neatly enough to resist pity.

She knew he read papers first by source and only afterwards by subject.

She knew he sometimes checked his watch with a sharpness that had

nothing to do with the room and everything to do with wherever he was

supposed to be next. None of this constituted intimacy. It was the sort

of knowledge repeated work produced.

On Wednesday she had gone to the Semiramis because she had said

Wednesday and because a promise once made in their quarter acquired a

solidity beyond inclination. Nawal was staying with Aunt Salma in rooms

that had the compressed, provisional air of lives not yet willing to

call themselves displaced. The visit had been good — good in the way

Nawal was good, which meant too perceptive to be entirely comfortable.

She had asked about the quarter, about Mrs Farah's remark, and then,

with the infuriating plainness that made evasion childish, about him.

Maryam had said he was useful. Nawal had said one did not wear gloves

like that for accountants. At the door she had said something that

stayed: if the quarter has begun talking, that matters; if you have

begun thinking, that matters more. Those are different dangers. Maryam

had thought about the sentence on the walk home, and then again before

bed, and then had stopped thinking about it because thinking about it

was itself the proof Nawal had been right.

When Tariq arrived he did so at an hour that made him seem both exactly

appropriate and socially awkward. He had, Hanna said at once, brought

back the corrected municipal copy and the reply from the bank clerk

whose nephew he knew through the school. This explanation, furnished

before Maryam had even stood, was another of Hanna's forms of care: he

always noticed when a room required a reason laid down in advance.

Tariq removed his hat in the hall, greeted her mother and Aunt Widad

with the level courtesy Maryam had by now come to recognise in him, and

paused when the wireless voice named another vote total. He had not yet

sat down. For a second he seemed uncertain whether decency required him

to leave the papers, promise to return later, and withdraw from the

family's private listening. Then Hanna said, "Stay. The numbers are

changing every five minutes. We may as well have witnesses."

So he stayed.

Maryam thought, with annoyance at herself, that she had become aware of

his physical presence before he had fully entered the room. Not in any

vulgar way. Merely as one became aware of a second exact clock in a room

already governed by a first. He wore the same dark coat as on working

days and carried under one arm a packet tied with the kind of competent

string Aunt Widad respected instinctively. There was chalk dust on one

cuff and a line in his forehead that suggested a morning spent speaking

more than he liked.

He sat not in the deepest chair but on the straight-backed one near the

writing table, which was exactly what he ought to have done and

therefore irritated Maryam slightly for reasons that had nothing to do

with chairs.

Hanna and Tariq went first through the bank letter because that was the

excuse by which Tariq was present and because practical labour remained

the family's preferred method of withstanding abstraction. The bank had

now advanced from demanding confirmation of Yusef's death to requiring

identification of all interested parties, certified copies, and one

phrase Hanna mistrusted because it seemed to leave the bank free to

invent further appetite later.

"It says pending satisfactory clarification of beneficial entitlement,"

Hanna read.

"Which means," said Tariq, "that they have not yet decided what they

want but mean to sound as though dissatisfaction is already your fault."

"Is there a polite answer to that?"

"No. There is only a correct one. Politeness only encourages further

ambiguity in men paid to admire it."

Maryam watched the two men over the paper. Hanna's attention moved in

straight lines: phrase, consequence, next phrase, next consequence.

Tariq's moved differently, less like accounting and more like pressure

being translated before it could be carried. The distinction was not

flattering to either man. It existed.

Then the announcer gave the final tally, or what sounded final until it

might not be: thirty-three in favour, thirteen against, ten abstentions.

The figures fell into the room with the dead certainty of numbers read

aloud, which is not the same thing as truth but often behaves like it

for the first hours.

Her mother stood. Not dramatically. Simply because sitting through the

result had become impossible for her body. "They have voted on our

city," she said. "How civilised."

Aunt Widad resumed shelling the peas she had long since finished and

then realised it only when her hand closed on nothing. Hanna turned the

wireless down but did not switch it off. The room, suddenly quieter,

seemed both fuller and less inhabited.

No one said anything large. That, Maryam realised, was how fear first

entered houses like theirs. Not through shouting or prophecy, but

through an odd deficiency of proportion. People asked after roads,

office hours, schools, deliveries, cousinly routes, and whether visiting

should now be done earlier in the day. They did not yet ask what would

happen if the thing on the wireless refused to remain on the wireless.

Hanna fetched the English-language newspaper and spread it on the dining

table, weighing the corners with the salt cellar and Yusef's old

paperknife. The map was a stranger's idea of land: blocks of grey,

hatching, lines bold where the city itself was not. Even the paper smelt

foreign.

"So that is us," Aunt Widad said, pointing not to Qatamon but to the

vague patch of central Jerusalem left uncoloured. "Neither fish nor

Christian."

"International," said her mother.

"Which means fish with documents."

Hanna traced one margin with a finger. "If this is accurate, the office

falls here. The school?"

Tariq leaned over the opposite side of the table. The gesture brought

him nearer to Maryam than he had yet stood all day, though the table,

the paperknife, the salt cellar, and her mother's suspicion still lay

between them in force. "Here," he said, touching the map. "Or rather

here if one believes the line understands roads. The road does not care

for the line."

Leila slid off her chair and came to peer under his arm. "Why have they

left the middle blank?"

"Because they cannot agree how to colour it," said Aunt Widad.

"Then why not leave the whole thing blank until they learn?"

"Because men are ambitious with pencils," said Amina from the doorway.

"What does it mean in practice for Jerusalem to be under a special

regime?" Maryam asked.

Her mother gave a little sound. "You ask as if practice will be

consulted."

Tariq did not answer at once. He looked at the map the way he looked at

papers before deciding where their lies were most efficiently arranged.

"In practice, first, very little. Then rumours. Then permits perhaps. Or

committees. Or two authorities each waiting for the other to become

real." He glanced at Hanna. "Enough to confuse office hours, which may

be the true beginning of history."

"Offices are only one part of it," said Hanna.

"Yes," said Tariq. "Schools, routes, deliveries, men who decide after

dark that one neighbourhood is suddenly less reachable than it had been

at noon."

Leila touched the paperknife. "If the lines change, do we change

schools?"

"No," said Maryam too quickly.

Tariq looked down at the child. "Not because of a line on paper."

"Then because of what?"

He considered before answering, and again Maryam saw the thing in him

she had begun, unwillingly, to rely on: he gave children the courtesy of

not lying where a lie would require stupidity to sustain. "Because of

roads," he said. "And grown people becoming frightened in practical

ways."

Luncheon was late and badly paced. The lentils had softened too far. The

bread had gone dry at the edges while everyone listened to the wireless.

Tariq should probably have left before luncheon, and everyone knew it.

Yet a morning spent listening in a family drawing room to the division

of Jerusalem had loosened ordinary exits. No one quite knew how to

recover the right hour for courtesy. So he stayed.

Meals interrupted by larger matters develop their own obstinacy. No one

had much appetite, which meant everyone became exacting about the food

itself. These were not complaints exactly. They were the ordinary

language by which families like theirs went on speaking when the subject

in the room was too large to be named at every turn.

It should have been harmless. It was only luncheon in a troubled city.

Yet by the end of the meal ordinary words had begun gathering more than

one use.

After the plates were cleared, Aunt Widad insisted on coffee because

nations had no right to spoil digestion. Hanna accepted one cup and then

rose, but did not leave immediately because the coffee arrived too hot.

That too kept Tariq in the room another ten minutes. It was nearly half

past two. He had told Khalil after one. He knew this. Maryam saw him

glance once towards the hall, where his hat remained on the peg, and

then back at the map on the table. He did not

move.

She recognised the gesture because she had made it herself, with Nawal,

with letters, with every manageable claim she had ever postponed by

sitting still a moment longer than the moment required. The excuse was

always reasonable. The radio. The coffee. The map. One more minute.

Reasonable excuses accumulated into unreasonable time without anyone

having to decide.

"Then Khalil will already be waiting," she said.

He looked at her fully then. "Yes."

"And you are late because of the radio?"

He paused just long enough to make the truth visible and not long enough

to theatricalise it. "Not only because of the radio."

Then he put on his hat, took the bank letter from the sideboard, and

went out after Hanna into the thin cold light.

Maryam stood where she was for another minute. Nothing had happened

that a sensible woman could not account for. That was the trouble.

Nothing at all had happened, and the nothing had begun quietly

rearranging weight.

Her mother retired for half an hour and did not call it that. Aunt Widad

went to the kitchen to tell Amina something severe about lentils and

returned having apparently said it to the kettle instead. Leila was sent

upstairs for an hour's quiet and asked whether history allowed quiet or

only adults. Amina answered that history allowed whatever kitchens could

survive.

By late afternoon the wireless still murmured at the lowest volume her

mother would tolerate, so that the drawing room seemed to breathe around

another room somewhere else. Static moved from station to station like

an indiscreet relation arriving ahead of the rest. In the street beyond,

another wireless somewhere further down had been turned up and not

lowered. The city was beginning the slower work of translating the news

into errors.

The front bell rang.

No one moved for one second because every bell under altered conditions

becomes a question larger than itself. Amina looked towards the hall.

Hanna rose. Before he reached the door, the bell rang again, shorter

now, as if its owner disliked drama and intended to be admitted on

practical grounds.

It was Khalil Darwish.

Maryam knew it must be him before the name was said because this man

entered as outer weather rather than household disturbance. He was

broader than Tariq, less carefully arranged, his coat bearing the day's

dust in a more public way. He nodded to the room in order of probable

seniority, tactful enough to prove he had needed tact all day.

"Forgive the hour," he said to Tariq. "I was told you were here."

"This is Khalil Darwish," said Tariq. "My colleague."

"Missed a title there," said Aunt Widad.

Khalil inclined his head. "I feared to begin too high and never

descend."

"That is a promising answer," she said.

He remained standing. "The headmaster wants you tomorrow morning. There

are fathers still at the school, and three more notices need copying

before church empties men into opinion."

The line might have sounded rehearsed in a man who enjoyed it more. In

Khalil it was fatigue made articulate. He had spent the afternoon

fielding other people's panic while Tariq sat in a drawing room in

Qatamon listening to the radio beside a woman whose uncle's papers he

had long since ceased to need as pretext. No one in the room said this.

No one needed to.

Hanna said, "Sit. At least for tea."

Khalil hesitated only long enough to show that he had intended to go

straight back out. Then he accepted, which meant he was more tired than

the coat admitted. He took the least comfortable chair without ceremony

and kept his notices in hand.

"What does the school need?" Hanna asked.

"Nothing it does not always need. Paper. Ink. Time. Better fathers." He

glanced at the radio. "Tonight it needs to look as though routine still

outranks imagination."

"Routine is for peaceful countries," said her mother.

"No," Khalil answered. "Routine is what countries use when peace has

failed and breakfast still has to happen."

It was the sort of sentence later attributed to history, though it

belonged first to a tired man in a doorway asking for tea.

"Keep that one," said Aunt Widad. "It is better than the radio."

"The radio may remain and do its damage without supervision," said

Khalil.

"What sort of notice?" Hanna asked.

"The kind that says nothing untrue and nothing useful. Classes will

continue as scheduled. Parents are asked to avoid unnecessary alarm."

"That is longer than a gate deserves," said Tariq.

"It is also shorter than parents deserve."

Amina, from the doorway, spoke before she could stop herself. "Does

legal keep buses running?"

Everyone looked at her. She lowered her eyes at once but did not

retreat. It was the right question and therefore the sort

families like theirs usually preferred not to hear from the person

serving tea.

Hanna answered her, not unkindly. "It keeps offices open longer than

justice does."

"That is not what I asked."

"No," he said. "I know."

Leila, who had listened with the fierce patience children reserve for

conversations they only half understand and therefore mistrust

correctly, said, "Can a country move?"

"No," said Hanna.

"Then what are they moving on the radio?"

"Paper," said Aunt Widad.

Leila considered this. "That seems stupid."

"Yes," said Khalil.

The agreement landed too cleanly to be comic.

The talk turned towards the future in forms small enough to hold. Roads.

Schools. Offices. Whether servants should go out early for bread on

Monday. Whether church would be full. By the time Amina brought bread

and olives because long conversation became, in her system, a meal

whether the household admitted it or not, the room had ceased listening

for revelation. It had begun measuring Monday.

Khalil stood first. "If I do not go now, the headmaster will imagine I

have joined a militia or a better school."

Tariq rose at once.

"You are going back tonight?" Hanna asked.

"Only to collect the school stamp and the Arabic register," said Khalil.

"If we are to produce nonsense by morning, it may as well look

official."

"I will come," said Tariq.

Maryam looked at him before she could stop herself. The movement was

small. Everyone in the room saw it except Leila, who was

buttering bread with the gravity of treaty work.

"No need," said Khalil. "I can manage."

"Then you would not have come," said Tariq.

That answered it. One man had asked without asking; the other had heard.

But there was debt in it as well. Khalil had spent the afternoon alone

at the school while parents arrived asking whether Monday could still be

trusted, and Tariq had spent it in a drawing room that did not require

him. The offer to go back now was not generosity. It was payment on a

lateness whose real cost neither man would name.

At the hall table, as coats were taken up and scarves found, Khalil

paused by the sideboard where Yusef's spectacles still lay beside the

vase.

"The dead are the last to hear news in this house," he said.

"No," said Aunt Widad from behind him. "The dead hear first. They simply

no longer waste comment."

He accepted the rebuke as if it were instruction and went out. Tariq

followed, then turned back because Amina had called that his scarf

remained on the chair. He came two steps into the light of the hall,

took it, nodded once to the family, and was gone.

When the door closed, the house did not fall quieter. It merely returned

to its own vocabulary.

"I do not like the look of streets after such broadcasts," said her

mother.

"Streets always look worse from doorways," Hanna answered.

"That is because doorways know what can be lost."

He did not reply. He went back to the drawing room, turned the radio

down until it became only a murmur and not an authority, and sat once

more with the bank draft as if sequence could still be drafted by hand.

Later, when Aunt Widad had gone home under protest and Leila had been

taken upstairs arguing that nations ought not to interrupt bedtime,

Hanna made three brief notes on the bank letter and then conceded that

no more clarity could be forced from paper that evening.

"Do not go tomorrow if it feels foolish," he said without looking up.

Maryam knew at once what he meant. "To the hotel?"

"To Mrs Khoury."

"Nawal."

"Yes."

"It would not be foolish."

"No," he said. "Only perhaps crowded. By tomorrow half the quarter will

be telephoning or calling on one another in order to turn hearing into

knowledge."

"I said I would go."

He nodded, still not looking at her. "Then go. But do not stay after

dusk."

It was an ordinary sentence. Protective, practical, mildly irritating.

Yet after the evening's noise it sounded almost tender by the standards

of marriage.

Maryam went to the hall table to straighten the pile that no longer

needed straightening: Nadia's last letter, the bank draft, Tariq's

copied notes, the hotel card tucked beneath a saucer. From upstairs came

Leila's voice arguing with Amina about whether countries ought to be

allowed to interrupt copybooks. Amina's answer was lost in the

floorboards.

She stood a moment with the hotel card in one hand and heard, not from

this house but from somewhere two or three houses over, another radio

being turned up as if the quarter itself could not bear to receive the

evening only once.

She set the hotel card down beside Nadia's letter and, without deciding

to, placed it beneath the bank draft rather than above it.

Outside, the neighbourhood went on listening to itself receive the news.

Inside, the papers lay where she had left them, one pressure covering

another.

CHAPTER VII

The Wrong Reasons

On Sunday the quarter woke before the bells.

The radios had been on too late for anyone to claim surprise in the

morning, yet surprise persisted in the form people from Qatamon

preferred when reality had behaved badly: the determined circulation of

interpretation. Voices were already in the street before breakfast. A

bread boy shouted twice in the same place because the first answer he

received had become a discussion by the time he reached the next gate.

Somewhere downhill a wireless was still playing the previous night's

report in a room where no one had had the discipline to turn it off. The

neighbourhood had the air of having slept in clothes.

Maryam came down to find the hall table transformed from a place for

gloves and visiting cards into a kind of domestic frontier post. Nadia's

first letter from Beirut lay beside the bank draft. Tariq's corrected

notes rested under the saucer. The hotel card from the Semiramis

remained where she had left it the night before: half beneath the bank

draft, half showing, as if one pressure had not quite succeeded in

covering the other.

Her mother was already dressed for church, which in itself meant the day

had become larger than piety. On true Sundays she spent the first hour

downstairs in wrapper and brooch, issuing judgement with tea. When she

dressed before breakfast it meant she intended to be seen thinking

correctly.

"We are going early," she said at once. "The church will be

intolerable."

"That is not an argument for earliness," said Aunt Widad, who had

arrived with the punctuality of a woman to whom other people's crises

were invitations. "It is an argument for whisky, and unfortunately the

Orthodox have shown no imagination in that regard."

Leila, her collar unfastened and her hair carrying the memory of the

pillow with more integrity than any comb had yet managed, said, "Are

countries still being divided?"

"Not at table," said her grandmother.

"Then where?"

"In New York, apparently," said Aunt Widad. "Or on radios by men with

unsatisfactory voices."

Leila considered this. "Can they not wait until after church?"

"No," said Amina, setting down bread. "Countries have very poor

household training."

Hanna came in last, already shaved and tie-fastened, which meant he had

worked before breakfast. He carried no packet today, only a small

notebook and the expression of a man who had already tried to order the

day and disliked the evidence that it would not stay arranged.

"The road by the lower gardens is slower," he said to Amina before

sitting. "If you go out later, use the convent side instead."

Her mother said, "No servant should be out later than necessary today."

"No one should be out later than necessary," Hanna answered.

It widened the category in a way her

mother disliked because it prevented her from arranging anxiety by rank.

Maryam broke her bread and kept her eyes on the table. She was supposed

to go to the Semiramis that day. Saturday had been lost to the radio and

the room and the transformed evening. Sunday remained. Nawal had said

come before dusk. Hanna, the night before, had told her not to go if it

felt foolish and, when she insisted, had said only: then go, but do not

stay after dusk. That sentence had left the responsibility with her,

which was neither kindness nor unkindness. It was one more instance of

Hanna's habit of placing time in her hands as if time were a thing that

behaved better when properly allocated.

Aunt Widad buttered toast with unnecessary authority. "Mrs Khoury will

be entertaining parliament by noon," she said. "Half the quarter will

visit her aunt in the hotel simply to hear itself have views."

Her mother looked at Maryam. "There is no need to go today."

"I said I would go."

"Yes," said her mother, "before last night."

"Last night did not abolish social obligations."

"It complicated them."

Hanna looked once towards the hall table where the hotel card lay under

the bank draft. "If you go after church, go directly and come directly

back."

"There," said her mother, as if he had at last become useful. "Even

Hanna says so."

"What I say," he answered, "is that the city has begun wasting time in

groups."

Maryam ought to have said then, clearly enough to be heard by herself as

well as by the room, that she would go after church and return before

dusk. Instead she drank her tea and let the matter remain among the

dishes. It was a small failure of definition, invisible to everyone else

because households of that kind lived on postponed clarity. Yet she knew

the exact moment in which it had happened: the moment her mother had

offered the day as excuse and she had not refused the gift.

The church was fuller than on the previous Sunday and less devout.

Devotion was not absent. It had been required to stand beside

geography and rumour, which were at present louder companions. Father

Elias altered the prayers without altering them enough to provoke

notice. He invoked peace more than once and wisdom more than anyone

present believed governments were likely to accept.

After the blessing the courtyard did what it always did and what, that

morning, it seemed almost indecently ready to continue doing: it sorted

itself into conversational weather. One could not cross from church door

to gate in a straight line unless willing to seem monstrous. Maryam was

stopped first by a widow who wanted to know whether Beirut seemed calmer

than Jerusalem. Then by a cousin whose name she had not caught. Then by

Mrs Farah, who arrived not like a predator but like a woman perfectly at

home with the fact that nothing worth noticing should escape her.

"My dear," she said to Maryam's mother, then at last to Maryam herself.

"I hardly slept for people telephoning to repeat what the radio had

already made ungentlemanly enough. And hotels must be impossible this

morning."

Her mother said at once, "Exactly."

Maryam knew, with the peculiar irritation produced only by being

protected in the wrong tone, that the sentence had been offered for her

benefit. Hotels must be impossible. Therefore civil women did not go.

Therefore no explanation need pass through lips at all; the quarter

itself had supplied one. That was the difficulty. No one in Qatamon had

to forbid what they could merely arrange into obviousness.

Nawal herself was not there. That mattered more than it should have. Had

Nawal appeared in the courtyard, hat tilted, face already alert with

amusement at the solemnity around her, the matter might have narrowed

into one decent obligation. In her absence it remained distributed

across the general intelligence of the quarter, which was a far softer

and more effective method of prevention.

On the drive home her mother spoke as though the matter had been settled

for anyone still capable of reason. "It would be ridiculous to go to the

hotel today."

Hanna, looking out of the window as though routes had become a document

needing exact reading, said, "By afternoon everyone will be calling

there who does not need to, simply to convert hearing into attendance."

There it was again: another reason, perfectly decent, practically

framed, carrying no accusation and therefore harder to resist than

accusation would have been. Maryam said nothing. That silence, she knew,

was already a choice.

At luncheon the house filled in the way houses did when public events

turned drawing rooms into annexes of the city. Her mother received

callers who did not sit long but spoke with compensating certainty. Men came with newspapers folded into

quarters, speaking in the singular about Arabs, Jews, Englishmen, or the

United Nations with the confidence of people who had never had to manage

a servant or a fever by committee. Women came with the more dangerous

ease of those who claimed only to be hearing what other women had heard.

Maryam's mother received them from the long sofa as though she had

personally warned the world against the consequences of foreign

arbitration and was now too tired by vindication to rise. Hanna, when he

was in the room, stripped away whatever was loudest and asked what roads

had been watched, whether the post had come, which office had remained

open, and why the butcher's boy claimed flour would rise before morning.

People left him both frustrated and better informed. At some point,

without formal decision, it became too late to go to the hotel and still

arrive there as a friend rather than a woman making a symbolic

appearance after the useful hours of friendship were over.

What made the hour pass so efficiently was not pressure in the dramatic

sense but sequence. A caller was announced. Coffee had to be poured.

Leila needed her copybook found. Her mother developed a headache

convenient enough to be genuine. Maryam might still have risen in the

middle of all this, taken hat and gloves, and said she was calling at

the Semiramis. No one would have barred the door. But the whole

structure of a house like theirs was designed to make self-directed

motion feel slightly theatrical unless justified by unanimity. If one

left during callers, one appeared impatient. If one left while one's

husband had only just come in, one appeared unhousewifely. If one left

while one's mother was holding her head and receiving sympathy, one

appeared cold. Respectability did not imprison by walls. It imprisoned

by making every exit available only at the cost of becoming a type.

Maryam knew that, had always known it, and had used the same system to

judge other women often enough to make innocence impossible.

By four o'clock the light had turned that pale gold which in Jerusalem

could make stone look briefly forgiven. The hotel card remained beneath

the bank draft.

Her mother, after the last of the noon callers had gone, had asked with

her eyes still closed, "Did you send word to Mrs Khoury?"

"Not yet."

"That is something less than something."

In her mother's mouth that passed for observation rather than rebuke: the

acknowledgement that standards existed and had not been met. Even so, Maryam

felt the irritation of having the note acknowledged at all. A promise

made and broken was tolerable while it remained between women. Once it

entered family notice, it acquired moral edges not wholly her own.

Amina came through carrying folded napkins.

"You have not gone," she said, not inquisitively.

"It became difficult."

"In this house everything becomes difficult if left till afternoon."

Maryam did not answer. Amina moved on. She had not said more than the

sentence warranted. Yet the effect was irritatingly similar to being

answered by conscience, which was precisely how Maryam refused to think

of her. Amina was not conscience. Amina was labour, timing, cleared

surfaces, the person who knew whether a tray had been set for three or

four and whether a woman had truly been prevented from going somewhere

or had merely failed to go.

By dusk Maryam had still not written a note. This, later, would trouble

her more than the missed visit itself. One postponed; people did; life

asked for postponement hourly. But the note — the decent, minimal,

ordinary repair — would have cost almost nothing. She sat at the little

table in the morning room and began: My dear Nawal, forgive me.

Yesterday became impossible in the most ordinary and therefore most

oppressive way — She stopped. The sentence was true and already looked

false. It dressed failure in decent cloth and invited admiration for the

cut. She tore it up, folded the scraps once and then once more, and

began again.

My dear Nawal, forgive me. With the vote yesterday and everyone in the

house listening and speculating, the afternoon escaped me. I should have

sent word earlier. If you are still there on Thursday, may I come then,

at the same hour?

She read the note twice. It was not a lie. It was only not the whole

truth. The afternoon had not escaped her; she had let it be taken from

her in pieces small enough to look blameless. There was a difference.

She folded the note anyway, sealed it, and addressed it to the Semiramis

in the neat convent hand she disliked in herself because it made even

apology look educated.

What disturbed her was not simply that she had not gone. It was that

some small part of her had been relieved not to go, and had accepted the

quarter's excuse with gratitude. Not because she disliked Nawal. The

opposite. Nawal had the dangerous gift of making a person feel seen at

exactly the level where self-deceptions still hoped to survive as

nuance. To see her again, so soon after the radio, would have meant

being looked at by the only woman in Maryam's circle whose intelligence

she trusted not to mistake politeness for depth. Nawal had a way of

making delay sound less like burden than like preference. Maryam did not

want to be read so clearly on a Sunday when the city itself had begun

reading everyone aloud.

There were, after all, excellent reasons not to trust hotel afternoons

under altered political weather. Hotels made gossip efficient. Corridors

lengthened small observations into reputational fact. The whole quarter

had already decided that the Semiramis would spend the day hosting

people who wanted to be able to say they had been there. All of that was

true.

That was the first wrong reason.

The note went out with Elias' younger brother before the lamps were lit.

Maryam watched him from the window for no reason she could have

defended. He trotted rather than walked, one hand on his cap because the

wind kept lifting it. For a moment she envied the simplicity of a life

in which notes were carried, not composed.

The second wrong reason arrived on Monday morning dressed as paper.

A schoolboy from Khalil Darwish's quarter came to the door with a folded

note and the embarrassed gravity of one entrusted with material too

adult for his age but too minor for ceremony. The note was from Tariq.

Brief, practical, and written in the hand she had already begun to

recognise.

Two school notices and one revised English circular need fair copies by

tomorrow noon if possible. The headmaster distrusts the first phrasing

and Khalil distrusts the headmaster. The bank draft can wait until

Tuesday.

Maryam read that final line twice. He had taken one nuisance off the

table without making anything of it.

Hanna read the note when she handed it across the table. "He is right.

The bank draft can wait. The school circular is the more immediate

nuisance." He looked at Maryam. "You have Leila's exercise books still

to buy. And your mother needs thread. If you take the marked sheet to

Habib first thing tomorrow, you can collect the copies by noon and bring

them to the school."

It was practical, unornamented, entirely legitimate. That was

precisely why the small movement inside her was so annoying.

Monday afternoon, before the errand could arrive to justify itself, the

house exposed something else. After luncheon Maryam remained downstairs

with Leila's blue frock across her lap and a needle she had no real need

to be using. The hem was sound. A button at the back had been loose

since the week before, but not so loose that it explained the afternoon.

She sat in the drawing room near the hall and near the table where the

packets usually arrived, telling herself she ought not to be upstairs if

school papers came or if Hanna sent some instruction by boy. She

listened, without appearing to listen, for the gate.

Amina, passing through with the tea tray, said, "If you are mending that

dress by duty alone, it will resent you."

"The button is loose."

"The button has been loose since Wednesday."

"Then I am a woman of unusual patience."

Amina lifted the tray. "No. Only of selective urgency."

By five o'clock she had sewn the same inch of hem twice, unpicked it

once, and learned something she disliked learning: that his absence from

the house altered its arrangement more visibly to her than it had any

right to. The fact was too small to admit and too clean to ignore.

On Tuesday morning she left the house with the marked circular, Leila's

exercise books on a list, and the small collection of errands that made

the trip respectable. The streets below Qatamon had changed not in shape

but in attention. More heads remained turned after greetings were

completed. More men spoke in twos and threes with the compressed

animation of people who had discovered that public events improved their

sense of personal relevance.

At the boys' school the gate stood open, though not in welcome. Fathers

were lingering under the pretext of escorting children further than

children required escort. A porter with a broom stood near the entrance

performing the useless labour institutions assign to frightened

mornings: making order visible where no real order could yet be

guaranteed.

Khalil Darwish stood just inside with a sheaf of papers and the face of

a man who had slept no more than duty considered sufficient. "You have

saved us from original composition," he said when he saw the envelope.

"The headmaster has spent the morning writing as if Empire still reads

us for style."

A boy tried to leave by the gate carrying another boy's ruler in plain

sight. Khalil caught him by the shoulder without looking and returned

both boy and ruler to the corridor with the absent exactness of a man

performing a movement long since stripped of drama.

He opened the marked copy and his face improved. "This at least sounds

like adults addressing adults."

A father at the gate interrupted to ask whether classes would be held

through the week. Khalil answered with a patience so exact it almost

qualified as contempt. "We are open today. We are open tomorrow unless

tomorrow objects. If tomorrow objects, we will let you know in a form

more reliable than corridor prophecy."

Tariq emerged from the corridor carrying a stack of exercise books under

one arm and a fountain pen uncapped in the other, with ink on two

fingers and the look of a man who had already been interrupted too often

that morning. He stopped when he saw her, not dramatically, only long

enough for recognition to separate itself from routine.

"You brought the condemned version."

"Khalil said the headmaster distrusted the first phrasing."

"The headmaster distrusts all phrasing that does not sound like the

Foreign Office suffering politely."

He unfolded the circular on the ledge by the gate. The English copy had

been crossed through and amended in two hands: the headmaster's heavier

one and Tariq's smaller, more economical corrections. "The problem is

that it sounds as though the school intends to punish fear for bad

manners."

"What does the Arabic say?" Maryam asked.

Khalil answered. "More or less: do not spread confusion and send the

children as usual unless told otherwise."

"Then the English wants less schoolmaster and more Arabic."

Tariq looked at her properly. "Go on."

There it was again: the ordinary, dangerous pleasure of being wanted for

something practical.

"Parents are asked to rely on official notices from the school and to

send pupils as usual unless informed otherwise."

Khalil's face changed first. "Yes. That sounds as though the children

belong to sentences rather than to a magistrate."

Tariq read the line twice. "Yes."

That was enough.

At the door, while Khalil went back to the school with the circulars,

Tariq asked with complete surface innocence, "Did you make it to the

hotel yesterday?"

"No," said Maryam. "The day was crowded."

True enough to serve, though not the whole of it.

He nodded once. "Sunday has become unreliable."

The answer seemed to leave him neither relieved nor disappointed, which

made it harder rather than easier to bear. Relief or disappointment

would have belonged to a clearer world. What passed over his face

instead was the quick acceptance of another fact to be carried alongside

the rest.

"Will you go today?" he asked.

"I do not know."

He looked at her for a moment, then at the packet in her hands. "Then do

not let the city turn one postponement into a habit. It has an appetite

for that."

It landed harder than warmth would have. It carried neither special

claim nor protective softness — advice given to an equal, which was

precisely why it moved too far inward.

When she returned, the house was quieter than on Sunday but not

steadier. Amina took the parcels from her hand, separated groceries from

paper without consulting labels, and said, "Mrs Khoury's porter came."

Maryam turned too fast. "When?"

"At noon. A card."

The card lay on the hall table beside Nadia's letter. The same

decorative hand. Mrs Khoury regrets missing you yesterday. Tuesday or

Wednesday afternoon would be better. Aunt Salma insists. Nothing

accusatory. Nothing wounded. That, too, was part of what made

postponement so morally convenient before it turned lethal. The world so

often accepted delay in language gentle enough to help one continue.

At tea Hanna came in and wanted first the school copies, then the bank

figure. When Maryam told him the phrase in the notice had been altered,

he read the line and said, "Good." To Hanna the matter was one nuisance

settled. At the school the words themselves had mattered. The

distinction stayed with her more than it should have.

When the lamps were lit and Leila had been sent upstairs, Maryam stood

at the hall table once more. Nadia's letter from Beirut. The bank draft.

Nawal's card. The corrected school circular copied now in clean type.

The table had become, without anyone's consent, the place where her days

were being laid out in instalments she had not chosen.

She could still go on Wednesday. Nothing had been destroyed. Nawal was

alive in a hotel room with Aunt Salma and tea and hotel chairs and

likely a judgement already prepared about the people now suddenly making

visits with patriotic expressions. The visit had not yet become loss.

That was what made the card feel heavier than paper ought. If some

external force had made the visit impossible, the matter would have

become history at once. Instead it remained choice, and choice was the

medium in which she trusted herself least.

From the drawing room came the small scratch of Hanna's pen over the

bank draft. From the kitchen came the china-sound that meant Amina was

stacking cups for morning. Maryam placed Nawal's card beside the bank

draft, then moved it away from the bank draft, then placed it back

again, irritated by her own hands as if they belonged to someone less

educated in consequence than she had imagined herself to be.

That movement was small enough to be called nothing. It was also, she

knew with a clarity too cold to be melodramatic, the first inward act

she could not pretend was accidental.

On Wednesday, she told herself, she would go.

The sentence comforted her less than it should have. It sounded not like

intention but like another instalment in a debt already learning how to

grow.

CHAPTER VIII

Amina Covers

The second letter from Beirut arrived with a different address and a

thinner hand.

Maryam saw that before she broke the seal. The envelope itself was bluer

than the paper Nadia had first used and cheaper by the look of it,

though Nadia had managed, by the angle of the writing and the firmness

of the downstrokes, to make even borrowed stationery appear to have

opinions. The new address was in Ashrafieh rather than in the quarter

near the sea named in the first letter. A different cousin, then. A

different flat. A different arrangement for saying temporary with a face

meant to survive being watched.

It came down in the post with two circulars for Hanna, an account from

the grocer which Aunt Widad said had been inflated by optimism, and a

church notice asking for subscriptions in aid of families recently

arrived from elsewhere and not yet properly distributed among relatives.

The city had begun receiving itself in pieces.

Since the vote, the house itself had altered again. The wireless had

been on too late on Saturday and too early on Sunday. Men now paused

outside gates with newspapers folded under their arms as though carrying

proof of themselves. Every flat surface had begun attracting papers that

once kept to their own jurisdictions. Church notices. Office circulars.

School sheets. Addresses in Beirut. Receipts from Habib's. One no longer

laid a glove down without first moving some smaller piece of evidence

about the future.

Her mother, who believed no morning ought to become morally serious

before coffee, said, "If that is from Beirut, open it before the tea

goes cold. Otherwise one has to spend the whole meal pretending one does

not want to know."

Aunt Widad, already there and slicing bread with the air of a woman

whose right to breakfast in other people's houses had been sanctified by

age, said, "If it is bad news, tea cannot help it. If it is bearable

news, tea will not mind waiting."

Leila said, "If it is from Beirut, ask whether they have better cakes

than here."

"Everything outside Jerusalem is judged first by cakes," said Amina from

the sideboard.

"Then Jerusalem should be pleased," Leila answered.

Maryam opened the letter with the hairpin she had left beside her cup.

The first letter had made hardship sound like inconvenience arranged by

taste. This one did not sound panicked; Nadia would rather have been

found dead among camphor than panicked. But the tone had shifted. The

gaiety had thinned into management. There was less on coffee and more on

beds. Less on apricots and more on storage. The address, the cousin, the

passage, the child in the passage — all of it said what the sentences

refused to. Room had become a negotiation. Dependence had moved from

anecdote into floor plan.

Bring papers first and silver second, Nadia wrote again. Do not bring

books unless they are necessary to your soul or your vanity, and be

honest enough to distinguish between the two. My husband still says this

will settle. He now says it with the look of a man asking the weather to

admire him. If matters become too unpleasant, come. We will stack one

another by kinship and call it temporary. Everyone here calls everything

temporary, which is usually how one knows some of it is not.

Hanna read it standing up. He never read family letters for pleasure and

never pretended otherwise. He read them for consequence.

"She should keep every receipt," he said when he reached the second

page.

"That is what you have taken from all this?" her mother asked.

"It is one of the things."

"There are always papers with you."

"There are always people who regret not having kept them," said Aunt

Widad.

Leila, who had extracted the word silver before anyone could redirect

her, asked, "Why silver second?"

"Because silver can be sold later," said Amina.

"Then why not bring it first?"

"Because papers get you across doors before silver does."

The child absorbed this gravely. "Do countries ask for papers too?"

"Only countries that want to pretend they are offices," said Aunt Widad.

Hanna folded the letter again and set it by Maryam's plate. "Answer her

today."

"As advice or as instruction?"

"As fact. The later the reply, the more room she has to imagine what has

not yet happened here."

That, Maryam thought, was Hanna's kind of kindness: not softening a

burden but putting it in the right order so damage did not enlarge in

the wrong direction. It annoyed her that such kindness was real. It

annoyed her more that she relied on it.

The morning then filled itself in the ordinary way: washing to be sent,

one woman from the church committee who called and stayed too long, and

a note from Hanna's office asking that the bank draft be sent over

before three. Maryam sat in the morning room and wrote Nadia a reply she

disliked before it was half done. It was brief, tactful, and almost

empty. It told Nadia that all remained outwardly manageable, that the

city was tense but still itself, and that affection remained. She knew,

as she sanded the page, that she had underpaid the truth. But a fuller

letter would have required her to decide what the truth was, and she was

not prepared to give the morning that much authority.

On the hall table Nawal's card from the Semiramis still lay beneath the

pin tray. Leila had been coughing earlier in the week, which had

disposed of Wednesday. Thursday had gone to the parish committee and the

bank draft. The promise made under the church wall, extended once and

postponed twice, had now been rescheduled so often that each new date

arrived carrying the weight of all the ones before it. Nawal's second

invitation — Tuesday or Wednesday afternoon would be better, Aunt Salma

insists — had not been answered with a visit, only with another note

promising another day. The card seemed no larger than before and more

visible. Maryam had begun to understand that postponement did not shrink

obligation. It allowed obligation to acquire interest.

After luncheon her mother said, "If you are going to post that and fetch

the copied parish sheet from Habib's, go before the light goes poor."

Her mother added the mourning ribbon to the list because no errand

crossing Jaffa Road should return morally naked. Amina added lamp wicks.

Leila wanted a green pencil. The packet thus entered town sufficiently

armoured by plural purpose to satisfy the household gods.

The afternoon had the suspended quality Jerusalem now acquired after

lunch. The tobacconist on the corner had pulled his shutter halfway down

although it was not yet late. Men paused outside shops with newspapers folded in half. A lorry stood too long at one

corner while three people discussed whether the road below the convent

was quicker or merely less watched. Maryam walked with the letter in her

glove and the ribbon list in her bag and told herself she was only going

to Habib's.

Habib's was half stationer's, half copyist's, and wholly proud of both

occupations. It smelled of paper, gum, dust warmed by glass, and the

faint iron scent of the copying machine when it had been run too hard.

Habib himself stood behind the counter reading an invoice as though it

had insulted his ancestors.

"You again," he said. "The quarter is keeping me in mourning and

municipality at once. Neither pays well."

"I came for the parish receipt copy."

"Not ready."

"It was to be ready by noon."

"It was ready to be ready by noon," he said. "Then the seal blurred."

She ought perhaps to have been irritated. Instead she felt only the

small inward release of having been given time by something outside

herself. She said she would wait. He nodded as if she had sensibly

acknowledged an arrangement existing prior to both of them.

She had been standing there perhaps four minutes when Tariq came in.

He stopped no more than a fraction when he saw her, then set down a

rolled sheet and asked for six copies of the school circular, one on

better paper if any remained. Habib's nephew said better paper had

become philosophical, meaning it could be discussed but not relied upon.

Tariq accepted this with the expression of a man who refused to waste

feeling on facts that had no interest in being altered by it.

Maryam ought to have left. The parish copy was still being redone and

the letter still needed posting, yet no reason for immediate departure

presented itself that did not sound, even in her own head, manufactured.

So she remained.

He looked at the envelope without touching it. "Beirut?"

"My cousin. She has moved again."

"Then Beirut has begun behaving like Jerusalem."

"She still writes as though inconvenience were a style."

"That is what people do when they are afraid of becoming burdens before

they have formally arrived."

The sentence was not only about Nadia. That had become one of the

difficulties between them: remarks travelled with second cargo.

"She says papers first and silver second," Maryam said.

"That is sensible."

"I was hoping you would call it tragic."

"It can be both. But if the road closes, silver does not stay tragic for

long. It becomes something to sell."

Outside, someone splashed through the gutter. Habib's nephew fed the

sheet through the copier and it emerged with the seal still too weak. He

fed it through again. The rain thickened and thinned by turns against

the glass. Maryam stood by the wall and watched the minutes at which an

afternoon quietly disqualified itself from being used for anything more

elevated than paper.

At one point she said, "Do you ever become tired of words solving

nothing?"

Tariq placed the receipt he was holding precisely on the stack before

answering. "Words solve very little. At best they stop people calling

the wrong thing right."

"That sounds like the schoolmaster's creed."

"It sounds like a man who has spent too long with clerks."

"And if the right thing is impossible?"

He looked at her. There was no one else at the side table then but the

two of them and the machine's intermittent metallic complaint.

"Then one stops pretending the impossible is temporary."

Habib re-entered carrying three small cups of coffee and an opinion

about the weather. The break in the air was so abrupt that Maryam nearly

thanked him, which would have revealed more than silence. They drank

standing at the side table. Habib complained of ink prices. Tariq

corrected a figure in the bank draft note Hanna had sent. Maryam found

herself speaking too little because speaking the wrong amount seemed

suddenly dangerous.

She should have gone then. Instead she stayed while Habib coaxed the

machine back into obedience and while Tariq rewrote a school line in his

smaller, firmer hand. A clerk from the Patriarchate arrived and began

arguing over the price of foolscap with such conviction that one might

have thought paper itself a theological matter. Through all of it time

went by in pieces too small to accuse.

That was the trouble. Had there been one clear extravagance — an

invitation, a pause too long, some softness no room could mishear —

Maryam would have known what to refuse. But usefulness made its own

weather. One stayed to hold a page. One read a line. One waited for a

seal to take properly the second time. One remained because leaving in

the middle of a task looked theatrical and staying did not. This was how

days were stolen in respectable households: not whole, but by

quarter-hours too ordinary to be defended against.

When the corrected pages were finally ready, the hour had travelled

farther than any errand of that sort had a right to demand. Habib tied

the packet, found the mourning ribbon, forgot the lamp wicks, found the

lamp wicks, and accused the rain of moral weakness. Tariq put on his

coat and said he was walking as far as the tram because he had to leave

two forms at the school office.

"You need not," Maryam said at once.

"No," he said. "I do not."

He took up his umbrella anyway.

The walk to the tram stop was short enough to be explained and long

enough to quicken the blood. They spoke chiefly of safe things: the

headmaster's handwriting, Khalil's belief that timetables could shame

politics into obedience, whether Habib had charged too much for the

ribbon. Such safety was by then one of the least safe parts of speaking

to him. Their caution no longer protected innocence; it kept

desire dressed in clerical clothes.

At the tram they paused beneath the shallow awning while two schoolboys

argued over fares.

"You are becoming difficult to find," Tariq said.

"I am standing in front of you."

"That is not what I meant."

She ought to have answered lightly. Instead she said, "There is a great

deal in the way."

"Yes," he said. "The city has been unexpectedly helpful to your delays."

"So have children. And relatives. And rain. And municipal receipts."

He did not smile. "That is how habit begins. Other things begin doing

the work for it."

The tram came. He placed the packet more firmly into her hands as she

stepped up, an ordinary practical gesture which became unbearable only

because it was ordinary. He did not touch her skin. The pressure of the

papers against her glove was enough.

When she reached the house the lamps were already lit. That, more than

the rain or the hour, made the return feel wrong. A woman coming back

before dusk from Habib's, from any errand sanctioned by household need,

belonged to the day. A woman coming back under lamplight belonged to

explanation.

Her mother was in the drawing room with two callers from the parish.

Aunt Widad sat opposite her. Before Maryam could speak, Amina came from

the dining room carrying the small bowl used for olives and said, in the

same tone with which she might have remarked upon weather or bread,

"Habib kept her. The machine jammed again and the carbon tore. She has

been standing there half the afternoon waiting for the seal not to

smear."

Her mother's expression changed from prepared annoyance to the lesser

irritation one reserved for tradesmen and paper. "That man will die

beneath a mountain of receipts and expect Paradise to sort them."

One of the callers said, "Habib always keeps people too long. He treats

paper like a sick relative."

"Yes," said Aunt Widad. "Which is better than the municipality, which

treats it like revenge."

Maryam held out the copied sheet and the ribbon because now that Amina

had supplied the room with its reason, the objects had to exist visibly

inside it. The room took the offered explanation and moved on. Tea was

poured. One woman began speaking of an uncle in Jaffa who now slept in

his shop. The machinery of afternoon resumed.

There was nothing in Amina's sentence that could be called a lie from

outside it. Habib had kept her. Carbon had indeed torn. The seal had

indeed smeared. Amina had built the explanation entirely out of

materials already available to the house. That was what made it so

exact. She had not guessed where Maryam had been. She had only

understood, from the hour, the rain on the hem, the packet in her hand,

the look with which she entered, what sort of account the room required

and supplied it before Maryam's hesitation could produce something

worse.

Only when the callers had gone did Amina say, quietly, "Come to the

pantry a moment."

Maryam followed because not following would have been visible.

Inside the pantry, where shelves of jam and lentils made a small

practical nation immune to rhetoric, Amina took Maryam's right hand

without asking, dampened a cloth, and rubbed at the thumb and cuff where

the copying ink had left its small dark proof.

"If your mother sees that on the table linen she will speak of it for

three days," Amina said.

The stain lightened under the cloth. Only then did Maryam speak.

"You did not need to say that."

"No."

"Then why did you?"

"Because if you had stood there choosing among reasons, your mother

would have begun improving them."

"It was not necessary."

"In this house," Amina said, "many things are not necessary until they

become tiresome." She set the cloth down and added, not sharply, "If a

room catches on a thing, everything goes slower."

Maryam heard no accusation in the sentence and, because there was none,

felt the shame more precisely. Amina had not rescued her out of

sympathy, still less out of romantic curiosity. She had protected the

room, the tea, the callers, the child, the whole weary machine of

afternoon. What had happened was that concealment had dropped a class in

the house. Whatever existed between Maryam and the hours she had begun

losing was no longer held only in glances, silences, and postponed

visits. It was being upheld, corrected, and cleaned by labour beneath

her own position. Amina did not need to know where each minute had gone.

She knew enough from timing, stain, and the difference between a packet

delayed by incompetence and an afternoon elongated by wanting. It was

practical knowledge, which made it worse.

Leila burst in before either woman could improve or worsen the exchange.

"May I have the quince now?"

"No," said both women at once.

Leila looked from one to the other. "Then someone is lying."

"Exactly," said Amina, and took the child by the shoulder back towards

the kitchen.

Maryam remained where she was for a second longer, her hand still

resting on the shelf where the better thread lay. She thought, with a

clarity she could not sentimentalise, that the house had begun working

on behalf of something she had not yet admitted even to herself. Not the

family, not the quarter, not Hanna, not her mother. The house: tray,

kettle, tea, servants' knowledge, the management of hour and

explanation. Something had shifted from inward trouble into shared

labour. It might have been cleaner had someone accused her. Accusation

drew lines. This only smoothed them.

What made it dirty was labour.

When Hanna came home he asked first for the receipt, then whether

Habib's seal had behaved, then whether the ribbon was the better kind or

merely the kind her mother would call better if no one argued. He did

not ask whether Maryam had been delayed for any reason beyond the room's

accepted one. She almost wished he would. He did not. He simply took the

receipt, checked the seal against the light, made a note in his book,

and moved on to the next item in the sequence by which he kept the world

answerable. Even his grace, she thought, arrived in the form of not

asking.

After supper, when Leila had gone up and her mother had retired with a

headache she regarded as both symptom and rank, Maryam took Nadia's

letter and looked at it again by the dining-room lamp. The reply she had

written that morning was still too smooth. She took up the pen and

altered one line.

Here all is still manageable in outward ways, she had first written.

Now she wrote: Here all is still manageable in outward ways, which may

be the most dangerous form of manageability.

She read the sentence twice. It was better and worse. Better because it

admitted something. Worse because it sounded like writing. She left it

in and hated herself a little for choosing cadence where candour had

briefly appeared.

From the kitchen came the soft sound of cups being stacked. Maryam did

not need to turn to know Amina was there, returning things to their

places, making the room ready for morning as if nothing in it had

shifted by more than an hour and a copied receipt. On the hall table,

Nawal's card still waited.

Hanna came in to collect the bank papers. "Will you go tomorrow?"

"To whom?"

"To Mrs Khoury."

"Nawal."

"Yes."

His tone carried neither suspicion nor encouragement. It was simply the

practical mind moving one obligation forward once another had consumed

the wrong amount of time.

"Yes," she said.

He nodded and went back to the table.

Maryam remained standing with her hand on the short letter to Beirut.

She could still tell herself that the day had been taken from her by

paper, machine, weather, trams, the city's new appetite for delay. All

those things were true enough to bear weight. The trouble was that

another truth now sat beneath them like a second sheet under a blurred

seal.

She had not wanted the hour to end quickly.

Small enough to deny. And the first fact in this matter that belonged

wholly enough to her to become dangerous.

CHAPTER IX

Semiramis

The explosion came before the house had properly surrendered the night.

It did not arrive first as history but as a violent correction to sleep.

Glass shivered in its frames. Somewhere downstairs a plate struck

another plate with the offended clarity of china moved against its will.

Leila cried out once from the room at the back, not yet from fear but

from the more childish indignation of being dragged awake by a sound

that had no business entering a respectable house before dawn.

Maryam was on her feet before she had fully understood why. The floor

was cold enough to send its fact through her slippers. In the corridor

the darkness was already altered by movement: a door opened, then

another; a strip of lamp from her mother's room; Amina's quicker tread

from the servants' side with a shawl dragged around her shoulders and

pinned badly at the throat because the hour had not allowed dignity. For

one second the whole house seemed to pause in the passage together,

listening for the second sound that would declare what category of

danger had entered. None came. Only the after-silence remained,

unnaturally attentive, as if the neighbourhood itself were holding its

breath in the dark.

"What was that?" Leila called, now crying in earnest.

"Nothing that requires crying," her mother answered from behind her

half-open door in the tone of a woman who believed order could sometimes

be restored by naming it before it existed.

Hanna, already in his shirtsleeves and buttoning his collar as he moved,

said, "It was not nothing."

He crossed the hall and opened the front shutter one slat at a time. A

draught came in sharp and damp. Somewhere lower in the quarter a dog

began barking and was answered at once by another. Then, after the

barking, came human sound: a door thrown open too quickly, a man's voice

raised not in speech but in direction, the irregular thud of feet on

stone steps. Maryam stood with one hand on the banister and had the

irrational thought that the hall table ought not to be there in this

light, with its day things waiting in the wrong hour — the bank papers,

Nadia's thin blue envelope, Nawal's card half visible where it had

slipped from beneath the pin tray. Such objects belonged to delay and

sequence. They did not belong in a house that had just been struck

awake.

"There has been an explosion," Hanna said.

"A tyre?" her mother said, because domestic life always offered lesser

explanations first, not out of foolishness but out of self-defence.

"No."

"Where?"

"I cannot yet tell."

Amina had already gone to Leila. The child's crying softened into the

protesting hiccup of someone being lifted and told that the house was

still a house. Aunt Widad emerged fastening the belt of her dressing

gown and said, "If this is one of those absurd boys with dynamite again,

I shall personally write to the governor."

"There is no governor who can help you now," Hanna said.

Her mother, refusing helplessness in a passage, ordered the drawing-room

lamp lit. When the telephone finally rang it startled them more than the

explosion had because telephones carried intention. Her mother took the

call standing, one hand pressed to the table as though receiving bad

news required ballast.

"It was the Semiramis," she said when she turned back to the room.

Hanna hung his coat by the door.

"It was placed," he said. "Not thrown. Placed."

Nothing moved at once. Not because the name required explanation. It

required too little. The hotel lay close enough to the quarter's idea of

itself that everyone there had some relation to it, however faint: a tea

taken on a wet day, a cousin who had lodged an aunt there, a room

borrowed because pipes had burst elsewhere. The building had entered the

morning as damage.

Maryam heard the sentence and not its meaning. The meaning lagged

behind, arriving in pieces that did not wish to fit: Nawal in the little

sitting room with the bad chrysanthemums; Aunt Salma at the window; the

card on the hall table; Wednesday; tomorrow; before dusk. A person could

hear the name of a building and understand immediately what it did to

stone. The more difficult thing was understanding what it did to a

promise.

By six the house had accepted that it would not return to sleep. Amina

had put bread near the stove not because anyone wanted breakfast but

because in houses like theirs food was one of the few ways alarm could

be kept from becoming theatre. Her mother changed into a dark morning

dress. Hanna shaved. That, more than anything, told Maryam the day had

moved into serious difficulty rather than chaos. If he could still

shave, he had not yet granted the world authority to cancel sequence

altogether.

Her mother telephoned twice and was telephoned three times. Each

exchange produced one more fragment and three more questions. The vice-consul had been

there. No, perhaps not. An entire wing had come down. No, only the lower

rooms. There were dead already. No one knew how many. Aunt Salma might

have gone elsewhere after supper. Nawal might not have been in her room.

These last two possibilities were offered by no

source at all, only by the household's instinctive attempt to place hope

where knowledge had not yet hardened enough to forbid it.

Maryam said once, "I will go there."

"No," said her mother.

"Not now," said Hanna.

The difference between the two refusals might have been lost on another

person. To her mother it was obviously improper, crowded, impossible in

the social sense. To Hanna it was a question of timing and routes, of

being in the way of men carrying rubble. His refusal admitted a future

in which going might become possible. Her mother's did not.

"I said I would visit today," Maryam answered, and heard at once how

inadequate the sentence sounded beside a demolished building.

At breakfast Amina moved in and out with the tea urn, toast, the sugar

bowl, and an extra cup that no one admitted to wanting and everyone

used. Her labour was not faster than usual. It was more exact. When she

reached Maryam she set down the cup and, in the same motion, moved

Nawal's card from the edge of the sideboard to the safer side of the

tray as if she were protecting paper from tea and not recognising that

one visible rectangle had become too prominent in the room.

By nine the quarter had entered the second stage of disaster: not event

but circulation. News began travelling by the slower, more contaminating

routes of social interpretation. Men who had gone to the site returned

with dust on their shoes and statements that bore the unmistakable

shape of having improved while spoken. Women telephoned to ask whether

the family had heard. Her mother received these calls with a composure

that had in it equal parts charity and disgust.

On the hall table lay Nadia's letter, the bank draft, and Nawal's card.

For weeks the table had staged the comedy of delay: one thing awaiting

answer, another awaiting signature, everything manageable so long as

management itself remained the highest local virtue. This morning the

arrangement looked not cluttered but accusatory. Maryam picked up the

card and read the line she had long since memorised. Tuesday or

Wednesday afternoon would be better. Aunt Salma insists.

When Hanna came into the hall she put it down too quickly.

"Can you find out whether she was there?"

He did not pretend not to understand. "I am trying to find out who can

currently distinguish the living from the dead without vanity."

"I was to go today," she said, and hated herself for hearing how the

sentence still placed her own schedule at the centre of the rubble.

He looked at her then with something that might almost have been

softness if it had not been so carefully rationed. "I know."

Those two words made the morning worse. Because if he knew, he knew not

only the day's plan but also the pattern that had preceded it: notes,

rescheduling, the card passing from pin tray to sideboard and back

again. He knew enough to know there had been time. He merely lacked the

temperament to make an indictment out of what could still be called

sequence.

"Do not go down there until there is some use in it," he said. "Crowds

are another form of damage."

The late morning belonged to arrangement. Father Elias asked whether her

mother could receive two women who had come from lower down and no

longer knew which cousins they were waiting for. Her mother told Amina

to put out the less chipped cups. The instruction was neither callous

nor absurd. One did not offer bad china to women who had spent the

morning under news.

The women arrived in black coats damp at the hem, carrying the smell of

wool, cold stone, and dust. There was coffee. There were facts that

might become facts. The hotel had partially collapsed. Men were still

digging. Aunt Salma had been seen. No one could swear to Nawal.

One caller who genuinely knew one of the dead replaced one who knew of them. This altered the quality of the room at once. Even her

mother became less composed and more specific.

"She had a brown hat she never pinned properly," her mother said once,

half to herself and half to Aunt Widad, when no one had yet spoken of

hats at all.

Maryam looked up so fast her neck hurt. It had not occurred to her that

her mother, too, had fragments of Nawal stored somewhere unwitnessed.

There was no moral in this. It was one more insult grief offered

to neat self-knowledge: other people had known the dead in ways one had

not supervised.

Aunt Widad said, "And she laughed with all her teeth. Sensible girls

should not. She had good teeth."

"That is not the point," her mother answered.

"It is a point," Aunt Widad said. "The dead are not improved by being

general."

At half past eleven a boy from Khalil Darwish's school came with a

folded notice for Hanna and a separate slip in Tariq's hand. The school

would close at noon. Tariq's note was shorter still: Roads near the

lower quarter are badly crowded. Do not attempt the hotel district

unless you have family already there and no one else who can go.

The sentence was entirely proper. It might have been written to any

household. Yet it entered Maryam's nerves differently from the rest of

the morning's paper: not as tenderness — he was too exact for that,

especially in ink — but as urgency stripped of surplus language. He

had written as one who knew she might still try to turn guilt into

action and that action, at the wrong hour, often served only the person

performing it.

Her mother saw the note and said, "There. Even the schoolmaster says

no."

Maryam folded the slip before anyone could ask to see it again. She

disliked that she wanted to keep it not for its instruction but because

his hand, entering the house in the middle of the morning's ruin, made

the whole disaster bend for one second into personal scale. This too was

contamination. Nawal might be beneath a collapsed hotel and still some

part of Maryam's inward life insisted on noticing the pressure by which

one man formed his letters.

It was during luncheon that the first true certainty arrived, though

even then it entered the house wearing the hesitant shoes of report. A

cousin of Aunt Widad's sent word that bodies had been brought out and

names were beginning to settle. Manuel Allende Salazar. Several from the

hotel families. A child. More still under masonry. One woman from the

Khoury side believed missing.

More information. As if death were a file.

Maryam put down her fork and found she had been gripping it as though

utensils could be made to testify. Khoury could mean cousins, in-laws, a

whole Christian geography of names. It could mean Nawal or not Nawal.

The room offered that ambiguity as relief. She recognised relief when it

was handed to her and despised herself for accepting it even

provisionally.

Hanna, who had eaten almost nothing, said, "Until someone names the

person, all grief is hypothetical and all panic vanity."

"You speak as though people choose whether panic arrives before

precision."

"No. I speak as though precision is still preferable."

"To clerks, perhaps."

"To the living," he said.

After luncheon Maryam carried plates to the sideboard simply because her

hands needed instruction. Amina was already there.

"If she is alive, they will know by evening," Amina said. "If she is

dead, they will also know by evening."

"That is not help."

"No. But it is probably the day."

The afternoon tightened. Hanna went out and returned with mud on the hem

of his trousers and dust on his coat. The road below the convent was

heavily blocked. St John's had taken several wounded. When her mother

asked whether he had gone as far as the Semiramis he said only, "Near

enough to know not to bring women there." He saw Maryam looking at the

dust and said, "A window, not blood."

She had not known until then that the mind had placed blood there so

readily.

At four a parish list began to circulate, hand-copied badly, corrected

in pencil, passed from gate to gate and then indoors as though paper

itself conferred legality upon grief. The vice-consul. Two Lorenzos. A

child. A woman from the Khoury relation still unconfirmed. Aunt Salma

injured. Nawal not yet marked, yet not absent either, because absence on

such lists did not acquit. It merely postponed.

Maryam read the list in the morning room and thought, with the oddly

meticulous cruelty grief uses before grief has formally arrived, of each

postponement in its own little clothes.

Sunday had not seemed like refusal. It had seemed like weather made

social. Her mother had supplied the excuse without quite meaning to:

hotels must be impossible today. Mrs Farah had completed the rest by

existing in the courtyard with her tone of neighbourly arrangement.

Maryam had let the whole quarter perform the refusal for her. The uglier

truth was that she had not wanted to sit under Nawal's intelligence on

that particular Sunday and have the slight inward alteration in herself

read aloud.

Then Tuesday — or what her mind now called Habib's day, though that was

unfair to Habib and too generous to herself. There had been papers,

rain, the jammed machine, the school circular, Tariq's usefulness. All

of that was true. Yet the day had also contained the fact, which only

now dared call itself by its plain name, that she had not wanted the

hour to end quickly. She had chosen no one. She had merely allowed

preference to collaborate with circumstance, which is how respectable

lives become morally deformed without ever acquiring the honesty of

vice.

Her mother dressed to call on a cousin of the Khourys living two streets

over, where women would gather because official knowledge remained late

and private endurance could not. Maryam said she would go with her. Her

mother refused at once.

"You are known to have been meant there already," she said. "Today your

face would ask for comfort when it ought to offer it."

To object would have been to make herself the subject outright.

After her mother had gone, the house thinned. Aunt Widad dozed sitting

up. Leila was sent upstairs. Amina lit the lamps one by one. Their light

made the windows into mirrors, and the mirrors doubled the room's

fatigue.

When the bell rang again she thought, absurdly, that at last it must be

final knowledge. But final knowledge rarely arrives at the dramatic

moment. It arrives tired, on the heels of too many lesser visits. This

time it was Mrs Farah herself, veiled in black, lips set to condolence

rather than curiosity.

"My dear," she said to Aunt Widad first, because Mrs Farah understood

precedence even when grief might have excused sloppiness. "I have come

from the Khoury cousin's house."

No one invited her to sit. She sat anyway, which under the circumstances

was mercy rather than presumption.

"Aunt Salma is alive," she said. "Her arm is broken and there is some

cut near the ear. She had gone downstairs for hot water, or so they

say."

Maryam felt the room tilt not from relief but from its immediate

companion, which is dread narrowed to target.

"And Nawal?" Aunt Widad asked.

Mrs Farah looked briefly at Maryam and then at the tablecloth. "They

have found her."

The grammar was enough. Still Maryam heard herself say, "Alive?"

"No."

The house received the word in layers. Aunt Widad crossed herself. Hanna

closed his notebook, which he had for some monstrous reason still been

holding. From upstairs came Leila's voice singing something to a doll in

the unpunctured world of children temporarily spared exact nouns. Amina,

from the dining-room doorway, remained entirely still for one breath and

then resumed carrying the tea things as though movement itself were the

only respect left available.

Nawal was dead.

What made the sentence so intolerable was not that she had feared it and

now had it confirmed. It was that the confirmation carried with it, in

the same breath, the entire ridiculous ordinary history of not going.

Leila's cough. The parish. The hotel corridor that would be crowded.

Sunday turning impossible in groups. Habib's machine. Tuesday becoming

Wednesday. Wednesday becoming another note. None of these things

disappeared because Nawal had died. They remained, each one still

defensible and all of them together obscene.

Her mother made a low sound and crossed herself. Aunt Widad said, "Poor

child," which was absurd because Nawal had been older than Maryam and

cleverer than most of them, and yet the phrase was not absurd either,

because death shrank the dead at once in the mouths of those left

speaking. Hanna said, "Who has her family?" which was the first

practical question and therefore the least false one.

Father Elias answered. A brother from farther off. The aunt conscious.

The church would coordinate. There would be more information by evening.

Maryam sat because she could not remain standing without either

performing control or losing it, and both felt vulgar. The cup Amina set

by her hand smelt not of comfort but of labour. Coffee was still being

made. Cups were still being washed. The quarter's catastrophe had

entered the room not by replacing domestic work but by requiring more of

it.

Aunt Widad turned first to linen. "Her aunt will need things," she said.

"If Aunt Salma has been taken elsewhere there will be no proper

nightdress, no comb, nothing but what she has on." Between them they

packed a bag of things women required when institutions took them over:

linen, soap, comb, hairpins, the little humiliating civilities that

allowed a body to remain a person when rooms and men had begun treating

it as a problem. The bag went out through Elias, then returned because

no one yet knew where it ought to be sent, then went out again with a

different address and the priest's name attached. The absurdity of this

— soap travelling in uncertain circles while the quarter still argued

over numbers — should perhaps have been comic. It was not. It was

exactly the shape of a day in which catastrophe had entered but had not

yet settled enough to be efficiently served.

When her mother returned from the Khoury cousin's, dusk had already

begun turning the windows into black mirrors. One saw immediately,

before she spoke, that the visit had taken something from her. Her hat

sat slightly wrong. The gloves had been removed without being properly

paired.

"It is confirmed," she said. "Aunt Salma is alive. Bruised and furious.

Nawal was in the room. There is no sense in repeating the rest."

Her mother very rarely granted silence the dignity of usefulness. That

she did so now gave the house a gravity it had not otherwise been able

to find.

Leila came down because children always hear the change in adult air

before they hear the words. She entered carrying the doll by one leg and

stopped at the door.

"Who is dead?" she asked.

It was Hanna who answered. "Mrs Khoury's niece. The lady who was at the

hotel."

"Nawal?"

"Yes."

Leila looked from one face to another, measuring whether the answer

required immediate tears. Not finding them already deployed, she adopted

the grave expression children use when offered an adult fact they cannot

yet sort into their own experience.

"Then you cannot visit tomorrow," she said to Maryam.

The sentence cut more cleanly than any lament. Her mother closed her

eyes for one second as if the child had placed a hand exactly on a

bruise no one else had yet located. Maryam felt not merely pain but

exposure. The whole mechanism of the day, all its concealed and

respectable little failures, had been reduced by a child to the bluntest

available arithmetic.

"No," Maryam said.

Leila considered. "That is bad."

"Yes," said Hanna, before anyone else could soften it. "It is."

Amina led the child away without adding a moral. Once Leila had gone,

the silence returned heavier because it had now acquired language.

Supper was produced all the same. Her mother took two spoonfuls of

lentil soup and then began giving instructions: black dress tomorrow,

proper calling card, Father Elias to be informed, Aunt Widad to find out

whether another tray would be useful. Management was the only shape her

care knew how to take once pain exceeded what polished speech could

carry.

Hanna ate in near silence. Only once did he speak directly to Maryam.

"You are not to go down alone tomorrow," he said.

"Why would I go alone?"

"Because guilt makes women stupid in particular ways and men polite

about it."

Her mother said, "That is a revolting sentence."

"It is still the sentence."

Maryam might ordinarily have answered with coldness. Instead she said,

"I know."

He looked up then, briefly. Between them passed something so stripped of

ornament it might almost have counted as companionship: not warmth, not

forgiveness, only the mutual admission that facts had now outrun the old

domestic fictions by which husband and wife could preserve themselves

from one another.

After supper Hanna returned to the drawing room and, after a time,

closed the bank file and left it shut. That, more than anything else,

demonstrated the day's real change. Paper, which until now had survived

everything — death, surveillance, weather, cousins in Beirut, school

warnings, the vote — had for one evening been defeated by a hotel.

Only later, in the morning room, did Maryam fully begin to grieve. She

went there with Nawal's two cards because she could no longer bear to

have them lying on the hall table beneath Nadia's letter and the bank

draft, as if they still belonged among errands. The room was cold.

Nawal's note about undrinkable tea looked suddenly less like wit than

like the preserved shell of a voice.

If Wednesday is impossible, come Monday after luncheon.

Impossible. The word had been there all along, harmless, social, useful.

She sat with the card in her hand and understood with a clarity almost

cold enough to be tidy that impossibility was often manufactured after

the fact by people who had preferred delay while delay still flattered

them.

There was a knock at the half-open door. Not Hanna. Amina.

She held out a handkerchief she had dampened with water. "You have

coffee on your cuff."

Maryam looked down. There was indeed a half-moon stain near the wrist.

Amina put the cloth on the little table. "If your mother sees it she

will ask whether you have no hands left."

"Let her."

Amina remained where she was. "The quarter is saying more tonight than

it knows. It will be worse tomorrow. You should sleep before it

worsens."

Maryam almost laughed at the practicality of it. But that was what

labour knew: tomorrow's suffering would still require the body that

suffered it to carry trays, dress children, hear names, answer knocks,

and not forget to send for bread.

"Did you know her?" Maryam asked.

"Mrs Khoury?"

"Nawal."

Amina considered. "I knew her hat."

"What hat?"

"The brown one with the pin she wore crooked. She always adjusted it

after she had gone through the gate, not before. Women who do that are

usually in a hurry or thinking."

"She was usually both."

Amina nodded once. "Then I knew the hat."

When she had gone, the sentence undid Maryam more thoroughly than the

official confirmation had because it made Nawal again a specific woman

in time rather than one more dead person in a hotel. The crooked hat,

adjusted after the gate. Thinking. In a hurry. Alive enough to do one

thing incorrectly because another in the mind mattered more.

Maryam bent forward and pressed the cloth against her eyes. Grief, when

it finally arrived, did so through tiny exactnesses one had not arranged

for.

Hanna found her there later. He did not come in at once. He stood in the

doorway, the mannerism of a man who never entered another person's state

quickly.

"I had the card," she said.

"Yes."

"I was going to go."

"Yes."

No sympathy in the word. No accusation either. Merely yes — the only

answer to a fact that could not be improved.

"I did not go."

"No."

She wanted, with a sudden absurd fury, for him to say something

consoling and false: that no one could have known, that Sunday had been

crowded, that Monday would not have saved anyone. Instead he remained

what he was — a man who did not mend tears by invalidating their cause.

After a moment he said, "The church ladies will come tomorrow whether

invited or not. If you do not wish to see them before noon, say so now."

"Before noon," she said.

"Very well."

He left, and she heard him in the passage already translating feeling

into household instruction.

She sat at the writing table and pulled towards her a sheet of

notepaper. She did not yet know for whom. Yet she uncapped the pen

because not writing felt too close to the pattern which had just killed

a visit.

My dear —

She stopped. The salutation itself had become unbearable. Dear belonged

to the living and to letters that expected answers. She crossed it out

so hard the nib tore the paper.

Amina found her there some time later with the black dress brushed and

hanging from one finger, the narrow gloves over her wrist, and the hat

box balanced against her hip.

"Your mother says the plain one," she said.

She set the dress over the back of the chair. On the table she saw the

torn sheet, the card, the open pen. Her eyes rested there no longer than

labour permitted. She gathered the spoiled paper, folded it once, and

asked, "Is this to be kept?"

"No."

Amina moved to the grate. The paper caught at once because the fire had

been banked but not killed.

"The little one is asleep," Amina said. "She asked whether ladies in

hotels go to heaven more quickly because they are already dressed."

Maryam gave a sound that might have become a laugh in another house and

another century. "And what did you tell her?"

"That heaven has no interest in hats."

This time the laugh did come, brief and disobedient. Amina did not smile

in response. She only adjusted the dress so the sleeve would not crease

and then, after the smallest pause, moved the black gloves from the

chair to the hall table beside the card.

The gesture was practical. Gloves belonged with card, hat, handkerchief,

not with wool and firelight. Yet once made, it rearranged the whole

little geography of objects. Nawal's invitation lay there still in its

decorative hand, no longer awaiting answer; above it now rested the

equipment of condolence.

"I will leave the lamp low," Amina said.

When she had gone, the house settled by degrees into the altered quiet

that follows the first day on which a neighbourhood understands that its

fear was not hysteria after all. Nadia's letter waited beneath the

gloves. Tariq's folded note lay to one side. Nawal's card showed by half

an inch.

Maryam did not move it.

She stood in the hall a long time, not weeping, only learning the new

weight that the simplest future tense could now carry. Tomorrow the

black dress. Tomorrow the call. Tomorrow the house of the Khourys.

Tomorrow the next school notice, the next bank signature, the next road

judged unsafe. None of those tomorrows would again belong to the old

category in which the word had been spacious.

At last she put out the lamp and went upstairs by memory.

In the dark, the hall table remained where it was, holding its small

archive of the day: invitation, warning, departure, mourning. But

something central had already been withdrawn from the neighbourhood

beyond the walls. Not hope. What had been withdrawn was the assumption

that delay was still a harmless form of good breeding.

The whole quarter had begun, overnight, to organise itself around the

knowledge that what one delayed on Monday might by Tuesday belong to the

dead.

CHAPTER X

After Semiramis

The day after Semiramis the house resumed itself in the wrong key.

Nothing in it had returned to its place, yet everything had resumed its

duty. Cups were washed and set to drain. The front shutters were opened,

though not fully. Amina swept the entrance hall with the severity of a

woman who knew dust did not mourn and therefore had to be made to leave

by hand. Bread was cut. Tea was made. Maryam's mother rose later than

usual and announced at once, before anyone else could ask, that she had

not slept because women of feeling rarely did after such a day. Aunt

Widad answered that women of feeling slept very well once given broth

and quiet, and that what had kept the house awake was not feeling but

telephones. Her mother called this unkind. Aunt Widad said it was an

account.

Under any other circumstances the exchange might have carried the

ordinary relief of familiar irritations. This morning it passed over

some other, less manageable air. Nobody raised a voice. Nobody said the

wrong name in the wrong tone. Yet the room had become more careful than

it had been before the explosion, and therefore less honest. People did

not now say that so-and-so would come after luncheon. They said, if they

were still on that side of town. They did not say the lower roads were

awkward. They said one was hearing things. The quarter, which had always

lived at least partly by assessment of one another's houses, habits, and

failings, was beginning to develop a second language beneath the first,

one in which information travelled wrapped in manners. Even the hotel

entered speech that way. No one spoke of accident. They spoke, more

quietly, of the sort of men who would do such a thing, and then stopped

before the sentence had to choose a name.

Between them her mother and Aunt Widad had already converted Nawal's

death into a problem of cloth, gloves, card stock, and the order in

which one called upon the Khoury relations. Their management was simply

the only form in which women of their generation permitted care to

appear once the event itself had exceeded what language could decently

hold.

On the sideboard lay the objects the previous night had arranged and

then failed to disperse: the black gloves, Nawal's card, the little

stack of calling cards, Tariq's folded warning note, Nadia's thin blue

letter from Beirut. Before Semiramis, the hall table had been an

instrument of postponement. One thing awaited answer, another signature,

another errand, all of them manageable so long as the household retained

its faith that time was broad and paper could hold it in place. Now each

object looked more like a witness than a task. Maryam put Nawal's card

into the pocket of her coat simply because she could not bear the sight

of it lying beneath gloves chosen for the call that should never have

had to be made.

Hanna had taken over the end of the dining table nearest the sideboard

and made, with envelopes, receipts, and two ledgers, a small

administrative country of his own. There was a new quality in the

movement now. The categories had become less archival and more

immediate. Things no longer lay in neat moral families — bank, cemetery,

tenant, office. They lay according to whether they might still be useful

if a bank remained open, if a clerk remained at his desk, if one could

still reach the municipal office after midday, if one had to send

anything by cousin rather than post. The papers were the same papers.

The time around them had changed.

One envelope was marked in his small, exact hand: Muna. Another: if

needed. Maryam looked at the second.

"What is in 'if needed'?" she asked.

"Cash," he said.

"For what?"

"For needing."

Aunt Widad said, "That is not a category. It is a superstition."

"It is a category if the bank shuts before one's turn."

Her mother closed her eyes. "Must everything at breakfast become an

omen?"

"It is not an omen," Hanna said. "It is an envelope."

Leila came down late and asked, before she had reached the table,

whether the hotel was still there.

"Part of it," said Hanna.

"Which part?"

"The part not blown up."

"That is not a proper answer."

"It is the answer I have."

Amina came in with the tea tray and, because her labour had become more

pressed since the explosion, no longer wasted time setting things down

gently. Cups met saucers with more force than civility preferred.

"I went by the lower market," she said as she poured. "Three shops were

still shut. At the butcher's they said a cousin's daughter is sleeping

in the back room because the family sent the girls away from Musrara for

a few nights. One hears the same quarter twice now."

"That has always been true," said Maryam's mother.

"Not like this."

Before he left, the telephone rang. It was his sister. Maryam knew at

once from the way he said only her name, not the affectionate title,

that it was family and not office. He took the receiver into the hall.

"No, do not come this minute," he said. "I said keep a case ready, not

drag the children through noon traffic for the pleasure of my staircase.

... Yes, I know what your landlord thinks. ... No. Not everything.

Papers, some linen, what the girls need, and the blue case if it is

still under the bed."

He listened for a while and then said more softly, "I know. That is why

I am saying it now and not tonight."

When he returned, Maryam pretended to be occupied with the sugar bowl

and knew he knew she was pretending.

"She is frightened," she said.

"She is practical enough to call frightened something else."

"And what are you calling it?"

"A blue case with papers in it."

At eleven they went to the Khoury cousin's house.

It stood only a little lower than theirs and yet felt, that morning, to

belong to a different jurisdiction of grief. At their own gate the

quarter still managed middle-class reticence: doors half-open, bells

rung properly, news carried in folded voices. At the Khourys' there was

no such illusion left. Men stood in the road not because they had

business there but because there was nowhere else for the agitation to

go. Inside came that compound sound by which mourning houses declared

themselves long before one crossed the threshold: the clink of cups, the

murmur of names, one woman weeping too rhythmically, another answering

her too efficiently.

Her mother went in first, card in glove, face set to the correct degree

of injured dignity. Aunt Widad followed with the little bag of linen and

soap she had assembled at dawn. Maryam came last and had the absurd

sensation that the house itself must recognise in her something other

than condolences. Houses knew nothing. But guilt disliked anonymity and

was always trying to make the world more perceptive than it was.

They were led through to the morning room one by one because the space

could not accommodate a whole houseful of care. Aunt Salma sat propped

upright on a chaise, one arm in a sling, a strip of white bandage

disappearing beneath the hair above one ear. On the small table beside

her stood a glass of water in which dust had settled despite the cloth

laid over it. That detail undid Maryam more quickly than the bandage.

Dust in water. The hotel had entered the room at the level of glass.

Aunt Salma received them with the offended endurance of women who

believe suffering is intolerable largely because it has been

administered so incompetently. "I look ridiculous," she said. "If one

must be blown through a corridor, the least heaven could do is improve

the result."

Her mother bent and kissed her. "You look alive."

The room wanted narrative; Aunt Salma would grant only fact. She had

gone downstairs because the room-service kettle had a temperament like

the British administration. Nawal had remained upstairs because she said

she would rather drink cold tea than wear the slippers on the corridor

tiles. No one spoke.

Then Aunt Salma looked at Maryam with eyes horribly lucid despite the

swelling and the sleeplessness. "You were to come," she said.

There was no accusation in the tone. That was what made it worse. She

spoke as one states an item not collected from the stationer or a dress

not fetched from the seamstress: an expectation interrupted by later

fact.

Maryam answered before she had formed the sentence. "I know."

Aunt Salma gave the smallest nod, as if acknowledging receipt of

information she already possessed, and then looked away. Whatever chance

there might have been to convert guilt into speech closed there. There

was no scene to be had. Only sequence again, monstrous in its

ordinariness.

When they rose to go, Aunt Salma opened her eyes again and said to

Maryam, "If I had known the hotel would make such a fuss, I should have

kept her at home."

Her mother answered for both of them. "It was not your keeping that

failed."

Outside, from one higher point Maryam could see, beyond roofs and walls

and trees unwilling to participate in history, a pale interruption in

the familiar line of the neighbourhood where the hotel had stood. Not

ruin exactly. Rather an error in the composition. She turned her head

away before her mother could tell her not to stare.

Mrs Farah was coming up the lane with another woman from the parish,

both in decent black. In previous weeks the sight of Mrs Farah would

have tightened something mean and anticipatory in Maryam. Now the older

woman's watchfulness seemed to have been partially nationalised by

catastrophe. Surveillance had merely found larger objects.

Mrs Farah pressed her lips to Maryam's mother's cheek and then said to

Maryam only, "You look tired, habibti. Go home before people start

explaining the city to you from the pavement."

It was almost mercy. That, too, felt unsettling.

At home the bank file sat where Hanna had left it in the morning, though

a fraction farther from the good lamp, as if even the sideboard had

accepted that paper must, for at least a day, show modesty. Leila had

been allowed bread and jam in the nursery because downstairs

conversations were judged not fit for children. Amina had changed the

cloth on the dining table. Someone had delivered a small basket of

oranges from an uncle in Baq'a because fruit was one of the few gifts

left to people once flowers had become competitive.

Nadia's letter still advised papers first and silver second. Unpleasant.

The word lay on the page like something upholstered. She folded the

letter back into its thin blue envelope and placed it beside Nawal's

card. For the first time the two pieces of paper seemed to belong to the

same universe. Before Semiramis, Beirut had been elsewhere and Nawal had

been here. After Semiramis, both had begun to occupy the same territory

of postponed life.

It was after luncheon, when her mother had at last submitted to a

half-hour's lying down, that Hanna returned and said there were still

two drawers in Yusef's desk that ought to be cleared before the damp

destroyed the rest. The upstairs tenant had left for relatives in

Bethlehem. The clerk wanted the French lease translated in full. And

Tariq had the duplicate key.

"He can meet there tomorrow at three if the roads remain open enough,"

Hanna said. "I will join later if I can."

Her mother said at once, "Then it can wait."

"Not indefinitely."

"Everything can wait one day more than you think."

Maryam almost laughed, because no sentence could have been less

appropriate to the week they had just endured.

At three the next day the lane to Yusef's building held more people than

it ought to have on a weekday afternoon, yet none of them moved quickly.

Speed in Jerusalem had become suspicious.

Maryam carried a shopping bag because errands required cover. Inside

were lamp wicks, an envelope to be posted, and the little list Aunt

Widad had written. Every object in the bag was real. None of it

cancelled the less respectable truth that she was going to the flat

because Tariq would be there.

The door was already unlocked. Tariq must have heard her on the landing

because he opened it before she knocked.

For one ridiculous second she thought only: he looks tired. There was no

visible nobility in it, no catastrophe written on the face, only

fatigue, as though sleep had visited him provisionally and left before

dawn finished its work.

"You came."

Even so, she heard behind it the other sentence, the one he did not say:

after all this, you came.

"So did you."

"I had the key."

"Useful men always do."

The room beyond seemed at first insufficiently altered. After a second

glance, what had shifted was plain. Fewer small things remained. The

framed photograph of Yusef's parents was gone. So was the little brass

ashtray shaped like a shell. A drawer in the side table had been removed

entirely and rested by the wall awaiting some future with fewer

contents. Emptiness had begun through the loss of trivial company rather

than grand subtraction.

On the round table he had already begun sorting. The categories from the

earlier visits had multiplied. Not only bank, church, tenant, and

municipal matters, but duplicated copies, things to be sent through

relatives, and a new envelope in his hand marked by upper way if needed.

Maryam noticed it before she intended to. The handwriting was smaller

than Hanna's and less forceful, but no less exact.

"What is in that one?" she asked.

"Copies of anything not worth losing to a road," Tariq said.

It was a practical answer. There was no reason she should have wanted

anything else.

She and Tariq worked without hurry. That was the first great change.

Before Semiramis, every hour with him had contained within it a second

invisible hour measuring its own scarcity. Now the hour moved

differently. Heavier. Each practical action

arrived contaminated by the knowledge that delay had already been proved

fatal elsewhere. They sorted nevertheless. One photograph into family.

Another into uncertain. A small key into impossible.

After several minutes Tariq said, without lifting his eyes from the

papers, "Khalil's brother lost two windows and says this now qualifies

him for political wisdom."

"That sounds like a Jerusalem rule."

"It is becoming a Palestinian one."

She almost said Nawal's name and did not. The unsaid sat between them

more densely than any spoken grief could have done. He reached for the

lower drawer, stopped, and looked at her instead.

"I was sorry about Mrs Khoury's niece."

It was the correct phrase and the wrong scale. That was why it worked.

He did not pretend to private claim over Nawal. He named relation and

loss in the smallest socially legitimate measure.

"She said I was to come," Maryam answered.

His hand tightened very slightly on the envelopes. "I know."

"How?"

"Because you told me once the invitation had acquired a second date and

then a third. Because after that one could infer."

"I did not go," she said.

"No."

There it was again, the terrible usefulness of yes and no between people

who had already learnt that explanation would cheapen fact.

He moved to the window and opened the upper half an inch. "After the

blast," he said, "everyone became very exact for six hours. Distances,

numbers, cousins, routes. Then by evening everyone began lying again

because precision was no longer enough to keep fear in order."

"Are you accusing me or the city?"

"The city. You would at least have chosen a better excuse."

She turned another photograph over. On the back Yusef had written only

June and an address in French. "I think," she said slowly, "that I

preferred thinking the city had done the refusing for me."

He shut the window. "Did it?"

"Yes."

"And?"

"And it turns out that still counts as refusal."

"I nearly wrote yesterday," he said.

It arrived not as confession but as fact placed among receipts.

"What stopped you?"

"You would not have needed one more piece of paper from me in a house

full of the wrong kind."

That answer was so exact it felt almost indecent. He had understood

precisely how his hand on a slip of paper would have entered the room at

the wrong scale, bending catastrophe inward towards the personal. She

disliked that he had understood. She disliked more that some part of

her, lower and less moral than grief, had wanted him to fail in

precisely that way.

"I kept your note," she said before prudence intervened.

He looked at her then, properly. "You should not have."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"Yes."

The room held. Nothing happened. Desire after Semiramis had ceased to

depend on event. The knowledge that she had kept a note she ought to

have discarded, and that he knew both the wrongness and the motive of

it, was sufficient to alter the air between desk and mantel.

Footsteps sounded on the landing. It was Hanna.

He entered with his hat in hand and said, "Good. You have not yet set

fire to the lease."

"Give us another quarter of an hour," said Tariq.

"You have twenty minutes."

Not because he had counted them, Maryam knew, but because that was how

his care arrived: in bounded extensions that acknowledged desire or

fatigue or human need without granting them authority to govern the

whole day.

"Can you still meet Khalil at the school before evening?" Hanna asked.

The question altered the room more than any private sentence could have

done. It introduced, with total innocence, a second life measured by

another man's timetable rather than by Maryam's nerves or the flat's

legitimacy.

Tariq answered at once. "I have to. He cannot stay late now. His mother

is alone with the younger ones until his sister returns."

"My mother also dislikes late roads," he added.

"Quite right," said Hanna.

There it was again: duty, distributed without rhetoric. Maryam had

known, of course, that Tariq possessed a family, a quarter, obligations

not waiting politely at the edge of her own narrative. Yet what had

passed between them had to date been made possible precisely by how

little those obligations had entered the room except as rumour or

margin. Now his mother existed not as biographical background but as a

fact controlling his hour. A mother ironing while deciding what to

carry. Hanna's sister with a blue case if needed. Girls sent to cousins.

The practical had ceased to be separate from the fatal.

Hanna began retying the packets while Tariq gathered his notebook and

the copied sheets that belonged to the school rather than to Yusef's

dead administration. The three of them stood for a moment in a small

ridiculous triangle: husband, wife, lover, all with paper in hand. But

there was no grand irony available to the room. Only work, roads, a

mother waiting in another quarter, a child at home, and the indecent

persistence of mutual recognition among all of it.

On the walk home the bag of lamp wicks seemed suddenly absurdly heavy

for its contents. From one gate came the sound of a radio kept low as if

volume itself might provoke further damage. At another, a woman was

telling someone over the telephone that her sister had gone to relatives

"for a short while," using exactly the tone of people describing an

absence already larger than their sentence.

At home Amina took the shopping bag and removed the lamp wicks, the

envelope, Aunt Widad's list, and finally the useless little key Maryam

had somehow brought back from Yusef's desk without deciding to. She held

it up between thumb and forefinger.

"Does it open anything?"

"No one knows."

Amina dropped it into the pin dish beside the hall tray. "Then it will

wait with the others."

Maryam stood in the hall looking at the pin dish. Upstairs Leila called

for water. In the drawing room her mother began explaining to Aunt Widad

why black ribbon had become impossible to buy in proper width.

She took Nawal's card from her pocket and, after a moment, did not put

it back on the hall table. Instead she placed it in the drawer of the

little escritoire in the morning room, among unanswered letters and

envelopes kept because the paper was still good. Removed from

circulation rather than hidden. When she closed the drawer she saw,

reflected faintly in the darkened window, not drama, not fate, not the

shape of a woman about to make a great decision, but something smaller

and therefore more dangerous: a woman still arranging objects correctly

while the order that had trained her to do so was beginning to fail in

earnest.

That evening, after Leila had finally slept and Hanna had come home

later than the soup forgave, Maryam stood for a minute at the nursery

door and listened to the child breathe. From the dining room came the

faint sound of her husband flattening one last paper with the side of

his hand before putting it away. From beyond the shutters came a city

learning, room by room, that afterward was no pause between one event

and the next. It was a new climate.

And they had entered it carrying, as people always did, the same small

domestic luggage with which they had meant to survive the old one.

CHAPTER XI

Tariq's Mother

By the time Tariq reached the school again the afternoon had already

developed that new bad habit by which hours no longer belonged wholly to

themselves. A day was no longer school, then home, then evening. It was

rumour distributed through sequence. A father arriving at the gate with

some piece of information that had improved while being carried. A clerk

refusing to stamp a paper because he had heard the municipality might

shut early, though no one could say on whose authority. A boy sent home

before the lesson finished because his mother had decided that a son

under a roof was safer than a son under grammar. Nothing ended when it

was supposed to end. Things merely changed jurisdiction.

Khalil had remained in the front office through what ought to have been

the last hour, his coat still on because taking it off would have

suggested confidence in the shape of the day. The room smelled of wet

wool, chalk, cheap ink, and the stale sugar from the tea they had both

neglected since noon. A new stack of notices waited to be copied because

one father had objected to the phrase routine until further notice on

the grounds that routine now constituted a political claim.

"What does he propose?" Tariq asked. "Disorder until further

refinement?"

"He proposes that his son be exempt from whatever sentence proves

inaccurate by next week."

"Then he should remove the boy from history."

"He has tried. The child keeps coming back through the gate."

Tariq corrected the English line for the third time. He could feel the drag

in his own head now, too slight to dignify as fatigue and too real to

ignore. The flat had altered him more than he liked. Maryam was in that,

yes, but not alone. The room at Yusef's had ceased to

be the quiet annex in which usefulness and concealment could still

pretend to belong to separate orders. After Semiramis, everything came

into the room carrying its proper weight. Mothers. Roads. Children.

Envelopes marked for need. The city had grown tired of letting people

visit compartments one by one.

Khalil watched him for a moment, then pushed the smaller of the paraffin

tins across the desk. "Take that and go to your mother before dark."

"I had a message at dawn from her neighbour. She asked if I was coming

today."

"And you are still here."

"I am here to strengthen the school's prose."

"The school can endure bad prose for one evening. Your mother cannot be

expected to reason with dusk."

"She reasons better with it than most men do with noon."

"That is not the point." Khalil looked at him directly. "She said

nothing useful. Which from mothers is never a good sign."

Tariq took the paraffin tin. Refusing practical help in the name of male pride was one of the more tiresome ways men disguised fear. As

he left, Khalil said, "Do not stop at the lower road if a crowd has

formed."

"I know how to recognise a crowd."

"You know how to recognise an argument," Khalil said. "These are no

longer always the same thing."

His mother's building had begun, like every building now, to declare its

own provisional status by small rearrangements. A folded blanket

occupied the cane chair by the window. One small case sat near it as

though at rest. On the sideboard lay a

parcel wrapped in newspaper and tied with shoe ribbon. When he set down

the paraffin and paper bag, his mother said at once, "That is not for

immediate alarm. It is merely the better preserves, because once one

begins thinking of where jars are kept, one realises how many idiotic

places one has trusted."

He took off his coat. "Have you eaten?"

"I am not an infant."

"That is not an answer."

"Lentils at noon. Bread at four. Tea was delayed because apparently the

nation now moves according to your timetable."

Only then did he see the cup on the table beside her. The old one. Thick

china once cream and now the resigned colour of repeated boiling. The

chip on the rim had grown broader at one edge and dark with tea where

the glaze had gone. He picked it up before sitting.

"This should have been thrown out months ago."

"It still holds tea."

"It also holds your blood if you forget the side."

"My mouth remembers where not to go."

"That is not a defence."

"It is a method. Sit down. You are standing as though you have brought

an inspection."

He did not sit at once. He moved first through the room with the

familiar irritation of a man who knew the objects too well to leave them

as they were and too well to believe that changing them constituted real

protection. He checked the window latch. He moved the chair away from

the draught. He set the paraffin in the corner where a leak could ruin

only one floorboard rather than all of them. This, he knew, soothed her

more than his sentences did. Practical action obeyed a grammar she

trusted.

Then he put the new cup, still wrapped, on the side table.

"What is that?"

"A replacement."

She narrowed her eyes. "For whom?"

"For the object whose retirement I am announcing tonight."

She opened the parcel at once because curiosity had always outranked

indignation in her, and produced a plain white cup with no beauty to it

whatsoever.

"It looks municipal," she said.

"It looks incapable of cutting you."

"So do some people. They still manage it."

He took the old mug from her hand. For a second his grip remained around

it and something older than annoyance moved through him. He remembered

it on his father's desk in the municipal office when he had once been

taken in as a boy to see where stamped paper went after leaving other

people's houses. Later, when the handle loosened, the mug had been

demoted to the house and then, by some family law no one had written, to

Tariq himself during his student years, when tea at midnight had counted

as method and deprivation as character. One did not think, in youth,

that objects remained because people could not quite spare the cost of

replacing them. One imagined continuity where there was often only

thrift.

But instead of discarding it he carried it to the kitchen sink and set

it by the basin.

On the kitchen table lay a saucepan, half a loaf, the sugar tin, and an

envelope weighted under the salt. He knew the hand before reading it.

His sister. He brought the envelope back unopened.

His mother opened the letter and read it with the moving lips she would

have denied possessing. While she read, he poured the tea and found

himself using the new cup for her and the old chipped mug for himself,

simply because the old one was there and because reform was usually

inflicted first upon the people one loved most.

"She says the girls are well," his mother said. "Her landlord is

becoming theatrical. She has packed one case and hidden it from the

younger one, who apparently believes trunks are invitations to climb."

"She should have packed two."

"She has not got two that shut."

"I can find one."

"Out of what? The generous ruins of your income?"

There it was again: the daily mathematics by which she defended herself

against dependence. One objected to the cost before accepting the help,

or else help began to look too much like power.

He went to the bedroom. The sensible coat had been left hanging with its

hem brushing the floor. On the dresser lay the small inventory of old

age performed without theatre: spectacles in the tin case, keys on black

ribbon, the handkerchief ironed into squares too exact for daily use,

the prayer book with the rent receipt serving as marker exactly where he

had expected to find it. He took the receipt out and held it up.

"It was in the prayer book."

"It was near me and therefore safe."

"It was near the Gospel of John and therefore disguised."

He checked the drawer of the little chest where she kept passport,

property copy, doctor's certificate, and the letters from his sister

tied separately as if offspring deserved their own archive. The passport

was there. The property copy was not.

He felt the first cold touch of true anger. "Where is the copy of the

deed?"

"With the priest," she said from the doorway behind him.

He turned too fast. "Why is the copy of the deed with a priest?"

"Because Father Boutros said the church safe was drier than my sideboard

and because respectable institutions are useful when one has paid

respectability for years."

"And you did not think to mention it?"

"You did not ask what I had sent to the church, only whether I had

eaten. A mother answers the question presented."

He closed his eyes for one second from the fatigue that stood where

shouting might otherwise have stood. When he looked again she had

already interpreted the silence correctly and moved half a step towards

him.

"It was not reckless," she said. "Three copies were made. One went with

Father Boutros, one is with your cousin's husband, and one is in the

sewing box because no thief respects darning."

For one instant he nearly laughed. Then the anger dissolved because,

absurdly, the arrangement was not wholly foolish. It was the city's

newest logic translated into maternal form: duplication dispersed

through trust rather than system. His mother packed as if survival were

an interruption. Hanna packed as if interruption itself had become

administration. She was no less serious for being less systematic.

"Tell me these things."

"I am telling you now."

"After the question."

"Yes," she said. "That is how questions function."

He opened the small case by the chair. Inside lay two blouses, one wool

shawl, the leather purse with the faulty clasp, a packet of letters tied

with blue thread, the little silver-backed brush that had belonged to

her own mother, and, to his weary admiration, a wrapped bundle of tea

reserved for Lent and good guests.

"No medicine," he said.

"I have medicine in the kitchen cupboard."

"Then you do not have medicine in the case."

He went to the cupboard himself, found the aspirin tin, the stomach

tablets, the vial for her cough, and put half in the case. She watched

in silence, which from her did not mean consent. It meant she was

judging whether opposition would cost more strength than it pleased her

to spend.

When he had finished, she said, "You are becoming like men who fold

disaster into corners before it has the decency to arrive."

He knew what she meant. Men like Hanna, though she would not have named

him. Men whose answer to uncertainty was envelope, list, key, duplicate,

timed return. It occurred to him, with a distaste he could not

immediately sort, that he had begun without noticing to resemble

precisely the species from which he had once differentiated himself by

language.

"I am becoming like someone who prefers corners to panic," he said.

"And what are you becoming besides practical?"

He disliked the question because mothers asked it without having to

declare whether they meant politics, love, fatigue, or age.

"Tired," he said.

"That is visible."

"So there is no need to discuss it."

"There is no need to discuss rainfall either. Yet one still prefers a

roof."

A knock sounded at the outer door. Not the bell. A knuckle knock, rapid

and neighbourly. It was Umm Nabil from the landing below, headscarf

crooked with speed and one hand still flour-white from dough.

"My brother is going by car tomorrow if God and the engine permit," she

said. "Only to Jericho for now. He says if there are letters for anyone

there or in Amman he can take them as far as the bridge."

"At present we are still local enough for the post to pretend to exist,"

his mother said.

"Yes," Umm Nabil answered, lowering her voice without reducing its

urgency. "But one likes alternatives."

When she had gone, his mother remained by the door a second longer than

necessary.

"Write your sister another note," he said.

"I wrote her on Monday."

"And now it is not Monday."

But she went to the writing table all the same. He trimmed the lamp

while she found paper, and the room settled into one of those domestic

conjunctions by which families preserve themselves without declaring

sentiment: the mother writing a note she would claim unnecessary, the

son holding the lamp globe up to the light to see where soot had

gathered, both pretending this was no more than evening.

She stopped writing and said, "How does one word 'reassure' without

sounding stupid?"

"One does not use the word. One says something ordinary."

"Ordinary is now indecently difficult."

He wrote two clean lines in the margin for her to scale herself against.

We are well. Do not act on rumours. If matters alter, you will hear

again. She read them and said, "That sounds exactly like you and not at

all like me."

"It sounds like safety."

"It sounds like a clerk with children."

The sentence settled where her best cruelties often settled: as

recognition rather than wound. Safety. Clerk. Children. Maryam with the

bag of lamp wicks. Hanna with the envelope marked if needed. Himself

measuring paraffin, sorting medicine into a case, correcting notices so

that panic might at least be bilingual. What, precisely, remained of the

man he had imagined when he first began mistaking moral clarity for a

future?

His mother saw something land and turned the subject by force. "Take the

old mug with you."

"Why would I take your old mug with me?"

"Because if you leave it here I shall continue to use it out of laziness

and you will continue to lecture me out of principle. Also, it was your

father's office mug before the handle went and then yours when you were

studying for examinations and believed tea itself conferred advancement.

You may as well take it back."

He wrapped it, because argument would have taken longer than newspaper,

and placed it in the satchel between the exercise books and the

foolscap.

She watched him do it and then said, with a sudden plainness stripped of

her usual defensive embroidery, "Do not stay on the road longer than

required just because you are not yet ready to arrive anywhere."

He looked at her at once.

She did not lower her eyes. "A mother need not know the name of a thing

to notice its method."

There were many answers available and all of them bad. He chose the only

one that was both true and useless.

"I have a great deal to arrive at, apparently."

"That is what worries me."

When he rose to leave, she let him button his coat before standing.

This, in her ceremonial system, was a sign of respect rather than

weakness: one did not embrace a man half dressed for the road. She

kissed his cheek once, dryly, and then adjusted the scarf at his throat

because maternal affection, like most durable affections, preferred

disguise.

On the stair he heard her bolt the door at once. That too comforted him

more than any spoken reassurance.

The street had thinned while he was upstairs. Not emptied. Merely

tightened. At the corner by the baker's, Khalil was waiting with that

particular stillness by which men announced they had not been waiting at

all.

"I told you to go home," Tariq said.

"I went home. Then I came out again because home had developed

opinions."

They walked together as far as the tram stop, though neither intended to

take the tram. Company after dark had become an argument one made with

the street.

"My brother has moved his wife and daughters to his uncle's for the

week," Khalil said.

"For the week."

"For the week," Khalil repeated, both men understanding the sentence's

species of dishonesty and the mercy it performed.

When Tariq reached his own room, he unpacked the satchel by habit.

Exercise books. Foolscap. Rolled notices. Yusef's copied lease. The

small parcel of tea his mother had slipped into the side pocket when he

was not looking. And finally the mug, wrapped in yesterday's newspaper

whose headlines already belonged to a previous register of alarm.

He set the mug on the washstand.

In that room, which held no inheritance and no child and no woman

obliged to his return, the chipped thing looked oddly authoritative, as

if it had come not from a kitchen but from a system of claims older than

the city's current violence. It was neither memory nor comfort, but

something more binding than either: evidence that he, too, belonged to

repetition, dependency, and the practical ridiculousness of carrying

damaged necessities forward because nobody had had the time, money, or

moral clarity to do otherwise.

He washed it out, though it was already clean, and placed it upside down

on the folded towel by the basin.

Then he sat at the table and drew the parent circular towards him, but

before reading the first line he took from his coat pocket the duplicate

key to Yusef's flat and set it beside the mug.

The two objects looked absurd together: one chipped cup, one correct

key. Yet together they seemed to state, more exactly than any sentence

he might have written, the new shape of his life. Not one room or one

duty, but several, all claiming urgency, none willing to declare itself

temporary, and all of them now travelling with him in the same small

bag.

He left them there while the lamp burned low.

Outside, somewhere in the quarter beyond his own, a wireless voice

entered another room and another and another, not announcing catastrophe

but teaching houses how to imagine it.

Inside, the mug dried by the basin and the key waited by the papers.

Neither explained anything. Both had become unavoidable.

CHAPTER XII

Thinning Rooms

The first room to go was the spare room.

Nobody announced it. In houses like theirs rooms did not disappear; they

were reclassified. A room ceased to be guest and became practical. A bed

ceased to be decorative and became available. A cupboard ceased to be

ornamental and became somewhere papers might be kept clear of damp, cousins,

and curiosity. Catastrophe, when it wanted entry into respectable

households, did not begin by carrying sofas into the street. It began by

asking whether one really needed so much air around a side table.

Maryam saw the change before breakfast because the door had been left

half open and Amina, coming up from the back passage with the coal

scuttle, nudged it wider with her foot. The room that had held the

better eiderdown, Aunt Widad's occasional indignation, and Leila's

proprietary claims upon rainy afternoons now contained Hanna's sister's

blue case, a folded camp bed, one basket tied with string, and three

bundles of their own linen stacked on the chair by the window. The

little escritoire had been moved out to the landing. A grey coat hung

over the bedpost. Ibrahim's satchel sat beneath it with one arithmetic

book half visible, as though childhood itself had arrived apologetically

and meant to take up no more room than necessary.

Maryam stood in the doorway fastening her cuff.

Amina said, from behind her, "Do not look at me as though I invited

them. I only made the bed."

"When did this happen?"

"Before six. Hanna Bey came with the case. The boy was asleep against

his shoulder like a sack with opinions. Your mother said not to wake the

whole house if practical misery could be carried quietly."

"Huda is staying?"

"For a few nights," Amina said in the tone of someone repeating a phrase

whose dishonesty she recognised and respected for trying. "The mason has

still not returned. Also the landlord has discovered that uncertainty

may be charged extra."

On the chair lay Huda's brown shawl, carefully darned at one corner, and

beside it the little tin in which she kept needles, buttons, black

thread, white thread, and the stoic debris of widowhood. The room had

altered species in a single morning.

Leila appeared on the landing with one shoe on and one in hand.

"Why is Ibrahim in my rainy room?"

"It is not your rainy room," said Amina.

"It is when it rains."

"It is now your cousin's room until his ceiling remembers Christianity."

Downstairs her mother was already at the breakfast table, properly

dressed not because callers were expected but because mornings no longer

belonged safely to the family alone. Aunt Widad had taken the marmalade

into custody. Hanna stood at the sideboard with his notebook open,

making two columns so narrow they looked less like sentences than

instructions issued to reluctant facts.

"So," said Aunt Widad when Maryam entered, "we have begun living by

annexation."

Her mother said, "We have begun living by family."

"That too. Though family is annexation conducted with soup."

Hanna looked up. "Huda came before dawn. The plaster in the back room is

worse, the landlord is pretending weather is a personal preference, and

the surveyor has still not returned."

Her mother said, "She could perfectly well have come at nine."

"At nine the street had already begun discussing itself. At six it still

had enough shame to mind its own staircases."

He said this without edge. That was almost always Hanna's advantage.

Even when he was right he refused the theatre of correctness.

Amina came in with the tea and said, "Civilisation now depends on who

still has dry walls."

At breakfast the house reduced itself in small humiliations. Huda had no

established place because no one had yet admitted she now required one.

Ibrahim's cup had been borrowed from the back shelf and did not match

the others. The bread basket had been moved nearer the middle because

more hands must now reach it. Nothing dramatic had happened. No cart had

unloaded mattresses at the gate. The table had begun to do arithmetic.

Huda came down last with the cheeks of a woman who had slept badly in

borrowed space. She had tied her hair with too much care, which meant

she was defending dignity through precision.

"You may stay the week," Maryam's mother said at once.

Huda answered at once too. "No. Only until the surveyor comes."

"Yes," said Aunt Widad. "Which means the damp has won and she knows it."

Hanna passed her the jam as if refusing both pity and embarrassment.

"Stay until the room is usable or the landlord acquires a conscience.

The second is unlikely, so let us proceed on the first assumption."

After breakfast Hanna gathered the bank file, two tied packets from

Uncle Yusef's case, and the list he had been compiling before tea.

"I am going to the flat after the office," he said. "The priest wants

the devotional books boxed. Elias says the cousin's man will come again

for the chest. Tariq is meeting me there."

Then he looked at Maryam. "If you can come after luncheon, come. I do

not want the wrong French letter packed with the right piety."

Her mother said, "Must that flat still be attended to as though your

uncle were merely late?"

"His papers still behave as though he were."

"It is not healthy."

"No," said Hanna. "It is administrative."

Huda, who had the tact of the newly dependent, said quietly, "You need

not bring anything back tonight. The house is already breathing through

one nostril."

Aunt Widad glanced towards the stairs. "That is because the other

nostril now belongs to family."

When the others had dispersed and the morning broke into its usual

smaller claims, Maryam stood in the hall and saw that the house had

already narrowed. Huda's blue case was farther in, but Ibrahim's shoes

remained by the umbrella stand as if announcing occupation in the least

ceremonial manner possible. The corridor no longer offered passage; it

negotiated it.

By noon the weather had chosen the meanest possible register: neither

rain nor light, only a colourless cold which made every interior look

temporary. On the road below the church Maryam passed a handcart piled

with middling suitcases and a birdcage wired shut with no bird in it —

not trunks, not exile made visible, only the sort of luggage bought by

families who still intended to return for the better things later. No

one stared. This was the new indecency: scenes that would once have

gathered commentary now passed as part of the road's furniture.

The sitting room of the flat no longer looked like Yusef's life

interrupted. It looked like Yusef's life translated into a smaller

language. Two bookcases were half stripped. The little side table under

the lamp held only one stack of municipal papers tied in ribbon. The

back-room chest was being manoeuvred through the inner doorway by Tariq

and Elias when Maryam stepped in.

"Higher," Elias said.

"I would if the laws of weight altered for Christians," Tariq answered.

Maryam moved aside and held the door. "Should I retreat and permit

theology to finish the task?"

Tariq looked up at once and the strain went out of his face without

leaving softness behind. "No. Just hold the frame before I take the

plaster with it."

The chest went through, leaving behind cedar, trapped dust, and the

stale smell of linen kept too long in closed drawers. Without the

armchair, without the chest, with half the shelves emptied, the flat had

lost a category of excuse. Before, one might still have pretended it

remained a dead man's administrative inconvenience. Now it was becoming

a room one entered knowingly.

On the window-sill stood a mug that did not belong to Yusef. It was

enamel once white and now undecided, chipped at the lip and carrying the

sort of ordinary authority only repeated use could confer.

"That is not my uncle's," Maryam said.

"No."

"You have brought your own mug to another man's flat?"

"There were only saucers left."

"That is not a defence. It is a confession of standards."

He shifted a row of books before answering. "The kitchen contained six

saucers, three plates, a teapot with political leanings, and one glass

too thick for self-respect. I chose continuity."

A mug meant repetition. It meant one had begun providing for a room's

deficiencies from one's own diminished store.

On the table lay Hanna's list: church books, account books, desk

drawers, linen, journals. Maryam removed her gloves and moved to the

lower shelf. "Which books to the church?"

"Everything devotional, anything in Arabic too damp to survive another

winter here, and the sermons with your uncle's marginal insults to the

Patriarch."

"That seems fair. The church ought to inherit what insulted it."

They began to sort. Prayer books to one chair. Journals and grammars to

another. For a few minutes the work itself protected them. That, too,

had altered since Semiramis. Before, labour in this room had served as

camouflage. Now it only kept their hands from saying too much.

On the mantel the missing ashtray had left a pale circle in the dust.

Rooms registered absence with too much patience. They held its outline

until someone wiped it away. Several volumes had been taken from the

lower shelf, leaving a gap too tidy to be accidental. The tram ticket

still marked Yusef's place in La Bruyère.

"You have not touched that shelf," she said.

"No."

"Why?"

"Because books give the impression of permanence while they are watching

everything else leave."

She took one volume out, dusted the top edge with her handkerchief, and

put it back. The action was pointless. She knew it while doing it.

From below came the cry of a paraffin seller, then another voice

answering from a window with the impatience of a woman who no longer

trusted any man to carry exactly what he had announced.

"And what do you object to?" she asked, not knowing entirely where the

question had come from.

He was silent a moment. One now heard the difference between answering

and choosing an answer.

"Waste," he said at last.

"In fathers?"

"In sentences. In routes. In the amount of life currently being spent

explaining obvious things to frightened people who would rather be

frightened elegantly."

She ought not to have smiled. It came anyway. He saw it and looked back

down at the papers as if courtesy required granting it privacy.

From below came the scrape and complaint that signalled the cousin's man

had arrived with a cart. By the time Hanna came in, carrying one

envelope and the office smell of cold air and bad wool, the chest had

gone and the back room looked one degree barer.

"The surveyor saw Huda's room," Hanna said at once. "Repairs can be

done, which is his way of charging hope. So she stays."

"For now," said Maryam.

There was the phrase again, as inevitable now as tea.

Hanna opened the desk drawer and found exactly what Yusef would have

hidden from order: theatre programmes, parish notices, one ribbon-tied

packet of letters, and loose paper that had outlived both relevance and

embarrassment. He turned the letters in his hand, then offered them

across to Maryam.

"These are probably for family rather than storage."

She took the letters and put them in her bag without opening them.

"The devotional books go to the church this evening," Hanna said. "The

ledger copies to my office tomorrow. Tariq, can you stay another half

hour and finish the journals if I go now?"

"Yes."

"Lock the outer door when you leave. Elias says the bolt holds. I prefer

proof."

Maryam said, "It is almost dark."

"Yes," he answered, hearing perhaps that she had meant more and

declining, as always, to assist the sentence into existence.

He left with the books and his correct office step, which made even

staircases sound procedural.

After he had gone, the room changed again. The legitimising presence had

left it, and every harmless object acquired a different surface. The tied letters

were in her bag. Tariq's mug stood on the sill. The back room had become

too visible through the open doorway — stripped of the chest, the rug

rolled aside, one pale square on the wall where something had hung for

years.

"We should finish," Tariq said.

So they returned to the journals, working faster not from impatience but

from the obscure propriety by which people under pressure quicken

harmless tasks rather than ask why harmless tasks have become difficult.

When the last journals had been stacked there was nowhere obvious left

to put them. The side table, the chair, the cleared shelf all looked

temporary in a way that made temporary arrangements feel dishonest.

Maryam moved to the back-room doorway before she had decided to. Without

the chest and with the rug rolled aside, the room showed its dimensions

too clearly. One could see the pale square on the wall. The wardrobe

door stood open over two hangers and a trapped smell of cedar. The room

no longer pretended to belong to an old bachelor and his paper

difficulties.

"Maryam," Tariq said.

He did not often use her name in rooms that could hear it.

She turned.

"We should go."

The sentence was right. It was also spoken a fraction later than

correctness demanded. He had understood the room too.

In the kitchen he made tea because departing too quickly would have made

haste itself into a confession. He brought back the chipped mug for

himself and one thick glass for her. The tea was too strong. On the

cleared corner of the table lay Yusef's French notebook, the parish

receipt, the key ring, and Tariq's mug. There was no impropriety in any

of it. The danger was that rules still held and meaning had moved.

At the door she checked the windows. On the landing the key turned too

easily.

"You are going by the convent side?" he asked.

"Yes."

"So am I."

That could still be said. That was perhaps the last innocence.

They walked as far as the corner by which routes honestly diverged. The

cold had sharpened. Houses showed their light reluctantly, as if

illumination itself had grown expensive.

"The room looks different every time," Maryam said.

"It is being reduced."

"At home the spare room has gone. At your mother's the front room is

occupied. At the flat even the teacups have left."

"The teacups left before the ethics."

She laughed despite herself, softly and only once. He did not look at

her while the laugh existed. That restraint made it worse.

At the next corner he said, "Do not come tomorrow if Hanna cannot stay."

"Why?"

"Because the room is now too honest."

Before she could answer he added, "And because rooms this empty

encourage people to misunderstand their architecture."

At her gate he inclined his head and went on without turning. Inside,

the hallway had narrowed again. Ibrahim's geography book lay open on the

landing chair, claiming the furniture with homework. In the dining room

Hanna was already back, copying from one ledger into another as though

the city's altered acoustics were merely another clerical nuisance.

"You are early," Maryam said.

"No," he answered without looking up. "You are late."

The words landed cleanly because they were true and because he said them

in the register of schedule rather than suspicion.

"I stayed to finish the journals."

"Yes. Tariq told me the cousin's man finally accepted the chest."

That small shock — that Tariq had spoken to him after she left, that the

two men still inhabited each other's practical world without ceremony —

made her set down her gloves more carefully than necessary.

At supper the house performed the arithmetic of reduced space. Ibrahim's

elbow and Leila's grievance competed over the same piece of table. Huda

apologised for existing by way of helping. Her mother spoke of routes

and prices and whose cousin had moved in with whom.

Leila said, "If Ibrahim stays in the rainy room, where shall my doll

sleep when it rains?"

"In your room," Maryam said.

"It does not like your room."

"Why?"

"There is too much marriage in it."

For one second nobody moved. Then Aunt Widad laughed so hard she had to

put down her spoon. Hanna went briefly still and then resumed slicing

bread with the patience of a man who had decided that childhood, like

weather, must be survived without rhetoric.

Later, when the children were at last asleep and the house entered the

uneasy quiet now called evening, Maryam went upstairs. The spare-room

door stood open. Huda had taken the narrow bed and given Ibrahim the

camp bed. The blue case was tucked under the window. The room already

looked as though it had been occupied for longer than a day, because

necessity settled faster than comfort ever did.

In her own room she saw another small reduction. Under the bed, beside

the hat boxes, stood a medium case her mother had evidently decided to

air and keep ready without yet announcing for what. Readiness had become

the household form of prayer. On the dressing table the jewellery drawer

no longer closed properly because a bundle of deeds in copied envelopes

had been slid beneath the tray. The wardrobe contained the same dresses,

the same coats, yet some hidden quota of space had been withdrawn from

it, as if every room in the house had been informed that appearance must

now make way for contingency.

She sat on the edge of the bed and took Nawal's card from the pocket of

the coat she had worn to the Khourys. She placed it in the drawer beside

the brush. Then, because the act felt like classification rather than

thought, she took it out again and left it on the dressing table. The

dead no longer stayed where one put them.

On the chair lay the shawl she had worn to the flat. It smelled faintly

of cold stair, strong tea, and dust. She thought of the flat one degree

barer than before: the absent chest, the cleared sill, the pale square

on the wall, the mug on the windowsill as if somebody had begun,

impermissibly, to supply the room from his own reduced life.

When Hanna came in he loosened his tie and asked only, "Did the journals

finish?"

"Yes."

"And the back room?"

"The chest is gone. The wardrobe Saturday."

He nodded, as though two facts properly entered might, for the moment,

be borne. Then he said, not looking at her, "I told Tariq not to remain

there tomorrow unless I could get there myself."

For one second she thought he had said more than he had. Then the

sentence arranged itself into its offered form: practical, correct,

about rooms and timing and no more.

"Yes," she said.

He set his cufflinks in the tray. "When rooms grow empty people begin to

behave as though emptiness were permission."

It was the sort of sentence he might have spoken about offices or

archives after luncheon. She could not tell whether he meant her, Tariq,

the flat, or simply rooms as a class of problem. That uncertainty was

perhaps his deepest gift to her, and one she could do nothing with.

"Hanna," she said, and then stopped.

He looked up.

Nothing usable followed. Truth now arrived divided by circumstance into

portions too ugly for speech.

"What?"

"Nothing."

He studied her one second too long for comfort and one second too

briefly for certainty. Then he turned down the lamp.

In the dark the house sounded thinner. The wrong people in the right

rooms, the right people in rooms no longer innocent, and every door

still closing in the old order while the uses on the other side had

already changed.

Maryam lay awake longer than the cold justified.

When she slept, she dreamt not of rubble or roads or hotels, but of

walking through a sequence of rooms in which each door opened not onto

another chamber but onto a narrower version of the one before.

CHAPTER XIII

The Half-Emptied Flat

By the following Thursday the flat had become a subject at breakfast in

the same way weather and illness had once been: not dramatic enough to

stop the meal, not minor enough to leave unmentioned. Huda and Ibrahim

were still in the spare room. Her mother had begun referring to this as

temporary with the fervour of a woman who knew that repetition was often

the only furniture available to dignity. Aunt Widad had brought string,

labels, and an opinion regarding trunks. In the middle of all this Hanna

said, as though reading out a matter no more morally charged than lamp

oil, that the wardrobe in Uncle Yusef's back room would finally be taken

that afternoon and the last of the church books had to be sorted before

Father Elias developed a doctrine concerning delay.

He looked at Maryam only after the sentence had made itself practical.

"The family letters are still in your bag, I think. Bring them. I do not

want grievance from Cairo packed with devotional material."

Her mother said at once, "Must there still be afternoons at that flat?"

"There must be one more," Hanna answered. "Perhaps two. The cousin's man

is coming for the wardrobe. The church porter is coming for the books.

The bank file must be copied again because the manager now finds

consolation in stamps. If there is anything left to sort after I leave,

Tariq can finish it."

The sentence might once have seemed harmless. It did not now. Her mother

buttered her bread with a steadier hand than the occasion deserved. "If

there is anything left," she said, "it can wait until daylight and

masculine supervision."

"It has already waited for both," said Aunt Widad. "That is why it still

exists."

Leila, who had been dipping crusts into coffee no child was supposed to

have, looked up and asked whether Uncle Yusef would know where his

shirts were once the wardrobe went. Amina, setting down the eggs, said

that if the dead knew anything they generally had the decency not to

complain. Aunt Widad replied that they complained through cupboards

because the living never put things back where they found them.

Maryam lowered her eyes to her plate because breakfast had already done

the day's first injury: it had made the flat ordinary again by assigning

it a time, a list, and a sequence. That was how this family survived

everything. One broke disaster into errands until it could sit beside

marmalade without causing scandal. Yet beneath that useful brutality

another truth had begun insisting on itself. The room had ceased to be

merely Yusef's administrative afterlife. By being emptied, it had become

too exposed.

After breakfast the house broke into its smaller states of occupation.

Maryam went upstairs for the packet of letters Hanna had mentioned and

found, beneath them in her handbag, two notes from Nawal she had not

answered.

The upper one had been written before Semiramis and carried the old firm

tone of women who believe affection entitles them to timetable other

lives: Come on Wednesday if you can. If you cannot, come Thursday. I

refuse to be postponed into abstraction. The second was shorter and more

ruinous now that its writer was dead. It had arrived the day before the

explosion, folded once, tucked among bills and circulars. I was unkind

on Sunday. Come and let me repair it. This quarter gives no notice

before it takes offence.

Maryam sat with the note open until the words ceased being language and

became only shape. It had happened so quickly that even the dead still

wrote in the grammar of next week. She put the paper away, took it out

again, then left it on the dressing table because classification had

become another form of evasion. Nawal had asked to be seen and now would

remain one of the things seen too late. Delay had already shown what it

cost in one direction and still had not cured her in the other.

On the bed lay the blue-grey dress she had worn to the Khourys, already

brushed once and needing it again because dust had become the city's

only reliable surplus. She did not mean to choose her afternoon clothes

with care. This too was one of the lies respectable women told

themselves. No woman who intended only to carry family papers, oversee a

wardrobe, and return before the light had reason to reject one dress,

then another, on grounds so petty they could not be admitted aloud. She

settled at last on a dark brown wool that made her look neither young

nor defeated.

At eleven Amina came up with the mending basket and paused in the

doorway. She saw the open handbag, the letters, the note on the dressing

table, and the brown dress laid out for town.

"You are wearing the dark wool again," she said. "Brush it well. That

hem shows everything."

"It only shows roads," said Maryam.

"In this city roads and rooms have stopped respecting the difference."

She said it while sorting thread, as if the remark belonged to buttons

rather than lives.

The road into town had grown busier without recovering any confidence.

Handcarts passed with loads too miscellaneous to signify anything good:

bedsteads, sacks of flour, boxes of files, once even a birdcage with no

bird in it. Nothing was forbidden yet. Everything was annotated. A woman

she knew slightly from church nodded and let her eyes fall at once to

the parcel in Maryam's hand, then away with the decent speed of a person

who had seen enough to feel both informed and innocent. Errands had

become the quarter's last permissible language for private motion. One

could still cross from one place to another respectably if carrying

paper, ribbon, or someone else's request. To walk for air or thought had

acquired something almost disreputable about it.

By the time she reached the flat the day had entered that grim

half-light winter afternoons in Jerusalem practised before admitting

that evening had already won. The sitting room had become larger by

subtraction. The bookcases were nearly bare. The rug had been rolled.

The side table had gone. In the back room the wardrobe still stood, but

only by temporary mercy.

Hanna took the parcel of labels from her without greeting because

greetings in this flat had long ago been demoted by work. Tariq emerged

from the back room carrying devotional books tied in one of Aunt Widad's

better lengths of string. He stopped when he saw her, and in that second

both of them measured the room against what it now knew.

"You brought the letters?" Hanna asked.

"Yes."

On the window-sill stood the chipped mug that did not belong to Yusef.

It had been there since before Semiramis and was by now the most

intimate object in the flat precisely because it was so ordinary. A coat

might be forgotten anywhere. A mug suggested habit. The first dangerous

thing in an affair was not touch. It was repetition.

For the next hour the room remained safely multiple. The cousin's man

and the porter succeeded in getting the wardrobe through the back-room

doorway, its departure revealing a pale square on the wall and a

quantity of dust which Aunt Widad would have taken as a personal insult.

Father Elias found school exercise books among the church material and

developed, briefly, a theory about the moral weakness of librarians.

Hanna revised lists, tied packets, and held practical misery together by

the force of handwriting.

On the little table by Yusef's chair the inventory list still lay where

Hanna and Tariq had left it the day before, Hanna's narrow columns

crossed now and then by Tariq's darker corrections. Hanna wrote to

control. Tariq to distinguish. On the page the two hands looked like

decent men disagreeing in a language paper respected more than

households did.

In the lower drawer, opened with the duplicate key, they found letters

Yusef had hidden from classification because classification would have

required feeling: a sheaf from Cairo concerning fish knives and dowry

silver, two unpaid subscriptions, and a thin packet of family notes tied

with ribbon that had once been blue.

She opened one just enough to see that it was from Yusef's sister-in-law

and chiefly concerned an argument about cutlery conducted with the

solemnity of treaty law.

"What is it?" Tariq asked.

"Apparently my uncle spent six months arguing by post over fish knives."

"That is how one knows a civilisation has once existed."

"No," she said. "That is how one knows a family has."

Tariq took the next letter from her hand, read the opening line, and

returned it at once because its French contained too much kinship to be

traversed by a man who was neither family nor priest. He knew the shape

of limits without requiring them to be explained in the vocabulary of

class or delicacy. The knowledge itself felt too close.

By half past five Father Elias had gone with the first stack of books,

the porter with him, and the cousin's man had made two journeys down the

stairs with wardrobe pieces and muttered theological pessimism on each

return. At last Hanna took up his coat and the bank file and said, "I

must see the surveyor and then the office. Box what remains. Lock the

desk. Do not stay later than you need."

He said it as any practical husband might. In that room the sentence

carried a second weight without his having to place it there. Maryam wanted him, for one irrational second, either to say

more or to say less. Instead he put on his coat and left in the correct,

efficient manner by which he always left spaces he believed managed.

When his tread had gone from the landing, the flat did not transform.

That would have been easier. It merely lost one species of permission

and left the others standing where they already were. When the door

closed behind him, both of them behaved for a minute as though his

absence might still prove temporary. Tariq moved the satchel farther

under the chair with his foot. From it protruded a child's exercise

book, a folded pharmacy packet, and a narrow strip of paper on which

someone — his mother, she guessed, from the patient angularity of the

hand — had written soap, paraffin, lentils, one candle. The list shocked

her more than a declaration might have done. Desire had not cleared his

world any more than it had cleared hers. It had entered among lentils,

school margins, the duplicate key, Huda's damp ceiling, and the dead

man's labels. Nothing had been simplified. The label pencil left a grey

stripe on her thumb. In the kitchen the kettle took too long to boil and

clicked once before settling. The mug left a brown ring on the table.

Maryam re-tied the ribbon around the family letters although it required

no help. Then rain began, not heavily, only with that mean winter

insistence which makes departure seem slightly more deliberate than

delay.

For a few minutes they worked harder than before. Speed, for a while,

made the room look less chosen. Maryam wrote FAMILY on one label,

PRIVATE on another, CHURCH on a third. Tariq retied the journals and

checked the insurance sheet against Hanna's notes. Dust rose each time a

box closed. In the back room the iron bedframe, relieved of the

wardrobe's company, had become visible as a fact rather than a piece of

furniture. The mattress remained on it only because no one had yet

agreed whose duty it was to move a dead bachelor's bed. Every object had

begun to look both too ordinary and too exposed.

Tariq went into the kitchen and found the good tea by instinct or

memory. He stood over the kettle with his sleeves rolled, watching the

water as if tea existed in certain rooms not as hospitality but as delay

made respectable.

Without looking at her he said, "There is one question left. If the

letters go now, they go as family. If they stay, they become archive."

She leaned against the doorframe, still holding the label pencil. "You

speak as though those are the only two conditions."

"There is also neglect."

"No," she said. "Neglect is family without self-knowledge."

He looked at her then. "That is not a third category."

"What is it, then?"

He turned off the flame under the kettle. "That is the first category in

disguise."

He poured the tea into his enamel mug and the thick glass he always gave

her when proper cups could not be found. They took both back into the

sitting room because the kitchen had grown too small for conversation.

On the cleared table lay Yusef's French notebook, the insurance sheet,

three labels waiting to be written, the key ring, and the old hotel tag.

The thick glass clouded in her hand before clearing.

"It looks worse in rain," she said.

"The room?"

"The whole thing. The boxes. The shelves. The fact of it."

He repeated the last phrase quietly, as if testing whether repetition

might improve it. It did not. She ought then to have said something

practical about the labels or the remaining books. Instead she said,

"When all this is gone there will be no reason to come here."

The line hung between them with the vulgar directness of something too

true to sound clever. He did not rescue her from it. Rain went on at the

window. Somewhere below, a door shut in the building with the labouring

finality of old wood. He set down the mug, not carelessly but with a

concentration so exact it announced that he had heard the sentence not

as speculation but as structure.

"There is already no reason," he said.

She did not know whether she moved first or only failed to move away in

time. Afterwards the distinction would seem heavier than it deserved. At

the time there was only the ordinariness of standing in a half-emptied

room while the sentence kept outside every other room finally entered.

He said her name once, not loudly, and she answered by looking at him as

one looks when the rest of one's life has supplied no usable reply. The

kiss, when it came, was recognised as a mistake even as it continued.

In the back room the bed had become, by failing to leave with the rest

of the furniture, the room's final indecency. The mattress was narrow,

the iron frame complaining under even the weight of a folded blanket.

There was a small washstand, a chair, the pale square where the wardrobe

had stood, and nothing else by which the room might pretend to belong to

any ordinary use. They still paused in the doorway like guilty visitors

to their own action. She had the absurd thought that Yusef would have

objected not to adultery but to the dust.

"We can still leave," he said.

It was the last honour left to them and therefore intolerable. She took

off her gloves because her hands could no longer bear their own

respectability. One glove slipped to the floor. Neither of them bent to

retrieve it.

What happened after that retained, even in memory, the material

awkwardness guilt later tried to smooth away. Her hat pin would not come

loose at first. His cuff caught in her sleeve. The bed protested its

years with one loud complaint which made them both stop, then laugh once

in a way too broken to count as laughter. The lamp in the sitting room

was left burning and sent a reduced rectangle of light through the

doorway, enough to keep everything from becoming romantic shadow. He

touched her as one touches something both needed and too easily damaged.

She did not become another woman upon being wanted. She remained exactly

herself: frightened, vain, hungry, ashamed, moved, half unwilling to see

what she herself had authorised. He paused twice, once to say her name

and once for nothing at all except to see whether she had changed her

mind while there was still time to possess one. The shock of his care

made the thing harder, not easier. A crack in the plaster above the

wardrobe. Someone shouting for a cart in the street below. The knowledge

that the room remained exactly itself — chipped jug, pale wall-square,

tied journals, letters on the shelf — while every future in it altered.

A thing deferred through papers, errands, weather, child, church, death,

road, and ordinary cowardice had become body.

When they lay down the mattress shifted under them and one spring made a

sound so indecorous that she covered her mouth against another laugh and

then, to her horror, felt tears there instead. He mistook them at first

for regret and moved back, the old discipline returning to his face with

such visible force that she caught his wrist before he could rise.

"No," she said, and then, because accuracy had been the language between

them from the beginning, "Not no to this. No to stopping and pretending

that improves anything."

The sentence was not beautiful. It was probably unwise. It was also

true. The iron frame complained. The blanket smelled faintly of cedar

and storage. Rain worked at the window. The dead man's flat remained the

dead man's flat. Nothing in the room gave way before it.

Afterwards the first sensation was not peace but exposure. The room had

not changed, yet every object now seemed to know the new arrangement

before they did. The chair held her dress and his coat with an intimacy

clothes should never acquire in borrowed places. Her hat lay where it

had fallen. The glove remained under the bed. He found it caught in the

iron seam and put it into her hand with such care that the smallness of

the action nearly undid her.

"I cannot go back to calling this work," he said after a silence. "Not

now."

"Then do not call it anything," she answered.

"That is what has brought us here."

There was no answer to that which did not sound like argument pretending

to be philosophy. She rose and crossed into the sitting room to pin up

her hair at the darkened window, using the glass as a mirror because the

mirror from the back room had already been wrapped for transport. Behind

her she heard him fold the blanket and set the pillow straight, as if

order might still be of use to someone.

They spent the next fifteen minutes committing the pathetic postscript

by which adults try to restore innocence to a room that has lost it. The

hat pin was found under the washstand. He rinsed the thick glass and his

mug in the kitchen and set them to dry as if tea had simply concluded.

She rewound the ribbon around the family letters and returned them to

her bag. Neither of them said anything about the absurdity of it.

On the landing they listened first for the building. No voices. Only

rain and the occasional cough of an engine lower down. At the bottom of

the stairs they separated without touching. The street had darkened into

one of those Jerusalem evenings in which every house seemed to be

husbanding its light. A cart passed between them and the lower road

carrying two rolls of carpet and a brass bed knob tied absurdly on top,

as if whatever household had given up the bed had still insisted on

keeping one emblem of it visible. He took the convent side because he

had said he would. She turned uphill. After ten steps she heard him

behind her say her name once, not loudly enough to summon, only loudly

enough to exist.

"Tomorrow?" he said.

The word held no romance. It meant the flat, the papers, the

intolerability of pretending nothing now required continuation. She

answered, after a pause long enough to disgrace them both, "No. Not

tomorrow."

He did not argue. "Very well," he said. "But not because nothing has

changed."

By the time she reached home the house had entered supper. This was

worse than if it had already finished. Completed domestic acts were at

least mercifully closed. Ongoing ones had to receive one. In the dining

room Ibrahim was reciting geography with martyrdom and error in equal

parts. Leila was objecting to lentils on constitutional grounds. Her

mother, still properly dressed because departure might yet call before

pudding, was explaining to Huda that no sensible woman left winter wool

in a trunk merely because leaving had become imaginable. Hanna sat at

the near end of the table with a sheet of copied figures propped against

the water jug, adding a column while eating in the efficient manner of

men who believed hunger and work could be solved simultaneously.

He looked up when she entered. "Did the wardrobe go?"

"Yes."

"And the journals?"

"Boxed."

He nodded and returned to his figures, the absence of scrutiny somehow

harder to bear than scrutiny would have been. Throughout the meal the

house continued its new arithmetic. Huda apologised for the extra

washing. Ibrahim offered to sleep in the corridor because his mother had

informed him that sacrifice must begin young. Leila declared that

sacrifice was easier for boys because they owned fewer ribbons. Her

mother asked whether Habib still had mourning envelopes or had now

surrendered to chaos. Maryam answered where required and heard her own

voice with the estrangement one feels after using it differently

elsewhere. Amina came from the sideboard with the soup tureen and, in

passing, took Maryam's coat from her arm without ceremony. Her fingers

paused once at the hem. Only once.

Later, in the pantry, she turned the coat to the back lamp and brushed

the wool with the palm of her hand.

"This will need a proper brush," she said. "The dust is from an inside

wall, not the road. And there is damp at the sleeve where it caught on

plaster."

The sentence contained no question. It did not even contain judgment. It

came from the republic of matter, where ash, flour, chalk, and cedar all

kept their separate citizenship. Maryam stood with one hand on the

shelf of preserves and could think of nothing to say that was not both

foolish and unworthy.

Amina reached into the pocket for the handkerchief before it creased.

Her fingers found the loose button and closed over it without surprise.

She placed it on the shelf between the soap and the folded napkins. "I

will sew that in the morning before anyone decides your clothes are

participating in politics." Then, after the slightest pause: "The little

one asked whether you were delayed by paper or by rain. I said both. It

seemed efficient."

"Amina—"

"No," she said, not sharply but with the composure of one refusing a

burden she had not consented to carry. "Not me. I am only telling you

that cedar dust shows on dark wool if one knows where to look. Also the

tea in the flat is stronger than ours. It stays in the cloth."

Upstairs the dressing table seemed indecently bright under the lamp. She

put Nawal's note into the drawer, took it out again, then left it

beneath the hairbrush because hiding and displaying now appeared equally

theatrical. On the chair lay the shawl she had worn. It smelled faintly

of paraffin, rain, and the back room's trapped cedar. She thought of the

flat stripped to its dimensions — the absent wardrobe, the pale square

on the wall, the blanket smelling of cedar and storage, the rain. These

would outlast any vocabulary she tried to lay over them. She washed her

hands twice because the second washing, like the first, served no useful

purpose. From the next room came Leila's sleeping breath. From below,

the sound of Hanna closing his ledger and setting down the pen in its

tray.

When Hanna came in he carried the bank affidavit and Huda's surveyor

note. He set a small box of family silver under the bed beside the

medium case her mother had aired days before and loosened his tie with

the absent precision of a man who had spent all daylight translating

contingency into lists.

"The room is almost finished, then?" he said.

"The wardrobe has gone. The books are nearly done."

"And the bed?"

For one sickening second she thought he knew everything and had decided

to phrase it as furniture. Then she understood that he meant only

whether the cousin intended to take it as well. "Still there," she said.

"It should go too. Empty rooms become foolish if one leaves them half

respectable."

He extinguished the lamp on his side before she could shape any answer.

In darkness his competence always became harder to read, not easier. "Do

not go tomorrow if I cannot be there," he said after a moment. "There is

no point now in encouraging unnecessary lingerings around a room nearly

finished."

The words were proper and ruinously apt. She said only, "No." In the

dark she could hear the house sounding thinner through all its correct

occupations: Huda coughing beyond the wall, Ibrahim turning in the camp

bed, Leila calling in sleep for a ribbon she had certainly lost herself,

the small metallic complaint of pipes cooling after Amina's wash-up.

CHAPTER XIV

Less Room Than Before

When Maryam woke the next morning the room looked ordinary first and

wrong only a second later. The curtain had not been drawn fully the

night before, and a strip of pale light lay across the chair where she

had left her dress. For a few seconds she lay still and felt only the

plain difference in her own body produced by the previous day. Altered,

that was all. Then the sheet

cooled against her skin, the room smelt of soap and ironed linen again,

and the ordinary discomforts returned one by one.

She sat up too quickly. The shawl from the flat still lay over the

chair-back where she had dropped it before undressing. Her first impulse

was to hide it at once, somewhere absurd. Her second was to leave it

where it was, because hiding it would admit an inspection no one had

performed. She did neither for a moment. She only sat with both feet on the rug, looking at it as though the fabric itself

had become indiscreet.

At last she rose, carried it to the wardrobe, and laid it on the lower

shelf beneath two cardigans she had not worn since Christmas. The

gesture satisfied nothing. When she turned back to the room she could

still remember the exact fold of it over the chair.

From below came the sound of Hanna speaking to Huda in the dining room,

his voice low and hers lower, and beneath both of them the small falling

note of a spoon against a cup. Huda and Ibrahim had been in the house

for three nights now. The extra camp bed in the spare room, the extra

bowl at breakfast, the extra satchel in the passage: each was a

manageable fact, and therefore more oppressive than any visible drama.

Hanna had brought them in with the quiet inevitability with which he

brought in everything he had already judged necessary. Huda had resisted

for half an hour and then submitted, which was her brother's usual

effect on weaker forms of resistance.

Maryam dressed without haste and went downstairs.

The dining room had altered again. Huda's travelling case was now under

the sideboard rather than in the hall, which meant she had stopped

believing she would leave the next morning. Ibrahim's copybook lay open

beside Leila's slate, the two children already fallen into the temporary

territorial arrangements by which children accepted upheaval without

ever dignifying it by explanation. Huda sat near the window in a dark

dress too fine for the business of sheltering with one's brother. Her

hands were small and restless; she had already folded and unfolded the

same handkerchief twice. Ibrahim was drawing a cart in the margin of his

arithmetic. Leila had decided his cart needed a horse and was improving

it without permission.

Amina came in carrying tea and looked once, not at Maryam's face but at

the empty chair where the shawl had been when she had brought hot water

the night before. If she noticed its absence, she gave no sign beyond

setting the tray down with unusual care. Then she said, "I took the

brush to your coat again. The damp brought the cedar up."

"I thought you had done it last night."

"I had. The sleeve wanted a second opinion." She poured without pausing.

"The lower button is secure now. It was never going to survive another

wall."

Her tone was level. She had repaired the evidence in the night and was

now giving it back in the form of clothing.

"You are late," said Maryam's mother from the head of the table.

"It is not yet eight."

"It feels later."

"Everything feels later," said Huda quietly.

No one answered.

Hanna came in from the hall carrying a folded paper and his hat, though

he had not yet put the hat on. "I will go first to the office and then

to the registry," he said. "If the clerk is there, we may have the

duplicate by noon. If he is not there, we will have his nephew and a

promise."

"Which paper?" Aunt Widad asked, appearing in the doorway with the

unerring sense of timing that allowed her to enter houses only when

decisions were already being made.

"The lease copy for Huda's landlord."

"Does he say he never received the original?"

"He says many things," Hanna answered. "Some are probably even true."

He sat. "And the flat. The bed men are coming tomorrow. Tariq can finish

the inventory there this morning. The books may wait."

The name entered the room with no more ceremony than ribbon or tea. Her

mother frowned only at the ribbon's width. Huda tore a piece of bread in

half for Ibrahim. But Maryam felt the small, immediate alteration a name

could bring to a sentence merely by being placed inside it.

Her mother said, "You are not going to the flat today."

It came as information, which made it harder to oppose.

Maryam lifted her cup. "Was I going?"

"No one needs to go every day merely because a room exists."

After breakfast Maryam carried spoons to the pantry and found Amina

there wrapping the better ones in newspaper with kitchen string.

"Your mother wants the good cups moved to the cabinet before the parish

women arrive," Amina said. "Also, if women are going to come and say

they are only passing, it is better the cups are not already on display.

Grief should not look prepared beyond what is tasteful."

Maryam picked up two cups. "I will take these."

"Take them where they belong, then."

That last word might have referred to the cups. It might not. Maryam

carried them out without asking.

No note came from Tariq. That should have been a relief. Instead it left

the morning with a shape missing from it.

Maryam spent part of the next hour helping Huda fold two more dresses

into the spare-room wardrobe and listening while Huda spoke in the

apologetic register of women who have accepted hospitality at exactly

the moment when hospitality is most expensive.

"You know I would not stay if there were another arrangement," Huda

said.

"I know."

"Hanna says the landlord only wants the registry copy and another week's

patience."

"Hanna always says what men want in a shorter sentence than they use

themselves."

Huda smiled faintly. "Father used to say it was because Hanna had no

vanity in practical matters. He never needed to make his own errand the

largest in the room."

"That is one of his gifts."

"It is also why people lean on him too hard."

The sentence sat between them. Maryam could not tell whether Huda meant

herself, the landlord, the family, the quarter, or Maryam. Perhaps she

meant all of them.

The bell rang. Two women from the parish stayed forty-five minutes and

drank one cup of tea each, long enough to offer concern, extract detail,

and leave before any room's real fatigue could inconvenience them. One

of them asked after Nawal not as though she expected comfort but as

though she expected sequence: had the family been informed, had the

church done this, had that cousin come? When they had gone, Huda carried

the cups to the sideboard and Maryam found herself watching the marks

they left: the slight turn of one chair, the napkin folded badly, the

faint lip trace on one saucer. Yesterday such marks had meant

condolence. Today they meant resumption.

Shortly before noon Elias's younger brother arrived with a folded note

from Habib. The corrected bank draft was ready. One page still required

Hanna's initials. Habib hoped the house would understand that shortages

of carbon paper were now a moral trial.

Her mother said at once, "You can send the boy back."

"He will fold the papers," Aunt Widad said. "Boys fold papers as though

making enemies."

"I will go," said Maryam.

Her mother's disapproval was visible before she spoke. "There is no

need."

"There is every need. Hanna will want the corrected draft this

afternoon."

Aunt Widad said, "Then take Huda."

Huda looked up from Ibrahim's cuff. "Why?"

"Because two women on an errand are an errand. One woman on an errand is

a narrative."

Maryam wanted to say the distinction was obscene. She also knew Aunt

Widad was right. Huda, who had too much gratitude in her to refuse

another burden, said only, "Then let us go before the queue forms."

They walked into town with one umbrella between them though it was not

raining, because neither wished to trust the sky's manners. Huda kept

her pace a fraction shorter than Maryam's, as though aware she was

walking on another household's rhythm. The streets felt busier than they

had any right to on an ordinary errand day. A cart of coal stood half

unloaded at the kerb. Three boys were arguing over a paper flag by the

tram stop. Outside the butcher's two men had ceased pretending they were

only discussing prices. A woman she knew slightly from church nodded and

let her eyes fall to the packet under Maryam's arm, then back to her

face, then away with the decent speed of a person who had seen enough to

feel both informed and innocent.

Habib's shop smelt of paper, oil, and damp wool. He emerged from the

back room drying his hands. "The corrected bank wording is better now.

Your schoolmaster friend has a decent ear."

Maryam said, before the word schoolmaster could settle too comfortably,

"Has he been here?"

"Half the quarter has been here. The machine now knows more family

history than the church." He handed her the packet. "One page needs the

husband's initials where the carbon slipped."

Huda paid. Maryam counted the pages there, as Hanna had instructed. In a

city like theirs, counting was the only remaining flattery businesses

trusted.

Outside, Huda stopped at the hardware man's window because her hooks had

suddenly become urgent. Maryam waited beside the wall with the packet

under her arm. She saw Tariq first in the reflection on the glass before

she saw him directly. He was coming down from the upper end of the

street with Khalil beside him, both carrying more paper than men ought

to carry on foot if paper still belonged to a sane order of things.

The reflection gave her just enough time to compose the first line of

her face and not enough to compose the second.

Khalil saw her almost at once and altered course with the public tact of

a man who understood visibility too well to be careless with it. "Mrs

Hanna," he said, inclining his head. "And Mrs Hanna's sister, I hope,

unless Jerusalem has begun multiplying women from the same family out of

administrative need."

"Huda," said Huda, emerging with her hooks wrapped in newspaper.

"Widowed, unfortunately, but still singular."

Khalil accepted this without embarrassment. Tariq had stopped by then,

though not in the manner of a man taking advantage of chance. He stood as one stood

when a public street had suddenly become more complicated than its width

suggested.

"You have been to Habib," he said, glancing once at the packet.

"For ribbon, hooks, and paper apparently heavy with morality."

"The paper is usually heavier after Habib has improved it."

The exchange was exact enough to pass for ordinary talk and too exact to

feel ordinary inside her. Huda asked Khalil whether the school had

reopened fully.

"Open and arguing," he said. "About flags, fathers, maps, and the

English wording for temporary closure. Next week perhaps grammar again,

if we are fortunate."

He said it with fatigue rather than wit. The parcel under his arm had

begun slipping. Tariq took one edge of it without looking and steadied

it.

Maryam said, "You look as though the school has moved into the street."

"For part of the day it has," Tariq answered. "The porter says men are

less likely to shout at us if they can see shops at either end of the

conversation."

A handcart passed between them. A driver at the mouth of the lane

shouted at another driver for stopping where stopping had never been

legal and always been common.

"The bed men will come tomorrow," Maryam said. She had not meant to tell

him. The words left her before she could shape them into anything safer.

Khalil turned slightly. "Then your afternoon is spoken for."

"Yes," said Tariq.

Then Khalil looked at Tariq more directly. "If your mother still means

to see the doctor at Bab al-Sahira, do not leave it past next week. The

tram men are already behaving as though timetable were a memory."

Tariq's face changed only by a degree. "She has not decided to go."

"Then help her decide before the road decides for her."

It stripped the street of any remaining comfort. Maryam heard

in it not merely Khalil's concern but the whole tightening city: routes

closing, trams unreliable, a mother's cough and a doctor farther away

each week.

They moved then, because streets required movement. But as Maryam

stepped away, Tariq said, low enough not to force the others to hear,

"If you come tomorrow, come before one."

She did not turn back. "Hanna is going."

"I know."

There was no pressure in the words yet. Only a stripping away of

pretence so slight anyone else might have missed it. Huda said nothing until they

had crossed. Then, with the restraint of women who know the uses of

restraint, she said, "The schoolmaster has less patience in his face

than before."

"The whole city has less," Maryam answered.

"That is not what I said."

"No."

"It may still be what I meant."

Maryam almost answered sharply and did not. Huda was not foolish, and

the kindness between sisters by marriage was often made of noticing

exactly how much one ought not to say.

When they reached the house, Hanna had not yet returned. The packet was

placed on the sideboard. The ribbon was judged satisfactory. Ibrahim had

broken the point of a pencil and was being judged for it by her mother

with more moral seriousness than the district committee now gave roads.

By the time Hanna came back, mud marked one hem and the registry copy sat in his inside pocket. He took the corrected packet, looked at

the altered paragraph, initialled the page, and said only, "Good."

Her mother asked whether the registry man had existed. Hanna said he

had. Aunt Widad announced that one must move before offices closed for

good. Huda put before her brother

the lentils Amina had kept warm in the oven. He thanked her in the

brief, unpatronising way that was his.

After three spoonfuls he said to Maryam, "Did Habib mention whether

Tariq corrected the English himself?"

"Only that the wording was better."

"It usually is after Tariq has touched it."

The sentence, perfectly practical, entered the room like something

lightly combustible. No one treated the name as private or charged. That

made it harder to bear.

After luncheon Hanna went out again to see Huda's landlord. The house

dropped into the suspended rhythm of early afternoon: too late for

callers, too early for lamps, too tired for useful conversation. Huda

slept in the spare room with one hand on Ibrahim's blanket as if

widowhood had turned even sleep into custody. Her mother lay down but

did not sleep. Aunt Widad went off to inspect a cousin's influenza and

be seen doing so. Maryam carried the corrected packet first to the

sideboard, then to the dining table, and finally upstairs to her room,

as though the proper resting place of paper might still matter. She set

it beside the brush where Nawal's note still lay half-hidden. The two

papers looked indecent together, one all practical correction, the other

invitation. She moved the note into the drawer at last and left the

packet out.

When she came down again, Amina was polishing one of the better cups

before returning it to the cabinet.

"You have used the wrong cloth," Maryam said, because one says something

when one enters a room and cannot say the thing one is thinking.

"Have I?" Amina changed cloths without offence. "The woman from Talbiya

will come tomorrow instead. Her brother says the road near the convent

is too lively today for condolences."

"Everyone is postponing."

Amina set the cup down and took up another. "Everyone is sorting. Some

people call it postponing if they dislike what falls to the bottom."

At four a note came from the flat. Not from Tariq. From Elias's younger

brother, sent by the bed men's foreman to say they would come the next

afternoon rather than the morning.

Her mother said at once, "Then someone must go."

"Not tonight," said Aunt Widad, reappearing as though contradiction

itself had summoned her.

Hanna came in almost at once and said, "Tomorrow after one. I will go."

Maryam said nothing. In its way that made more noise than speech.

He looked at her once, not long enough to be called a look if anyone

else had been watching. "You need not come."

It was meant kindly, or as kindly as his practical manners allowed. It

felt nevertheless like exclusion and reprieve together. She could not

have said which part of her resented which.

Near dusk she heard Hanna in the passage speaking to Huda with the door

not fully closed.

"Another week is possible," he was saying.

"You have your own household."

"I have rooms."

"That is not the same thing."

"At present it is near enough."

Huda was quiet. Then: "And if it becomes a month?"

He answered after a moment, not because he hesitated, but because he was

making the answer usable. "Then we will know more in a month than we

know now. There is no sense refusing a week because it may resemble

another week after it."

Maryam stood in the dining room with the empty water jug in her hand and

thought, not for the first time, that he dealt in the next manageable interval: rooms, a week, a

registry copy, hooks for a cupboard, a bed removed before strangers

handled the linen. It was perhaps the most practical form of tenderness

she had ever known, and because it arrived without heat she had spent

years mistaking it for method.

When he came back into the room and saw the empty water jug in her hand,

he said only, "The tap in the kitchen is running again," as if he had

caught her on an errand and not listening to his kindness through a

half-open door.

At supper he added, more quietly, "If things worsen and Huda needs to go

to our cousins in Beirut quickly, there may be a way as far as the road

south before the end of the month. Nothing comfortable. But a way."

The table fell quiet longer than soup required. Departure had been

discussed before, but always in the light joking register of cousins

elsewhere and temporary arrangements for other people. Tonight it had

entered in Hanna's tone: clean, practical, and therefore harder to

resist than alarm. Huda looked at her plate. Ibrahim, who understood

tone before he understood language, stopped eating and watched his

mother's hands. She put one of them over his without looking at him.

That night, after supper, after Huda and Ibrahim had gone into the spare

room, after Leila had finally surrendered to sleep and her mother had

retired with the ribbon she no longer needed, Maryam went upstairs by

herself. The house had narrowed after dark. Rooms held breath

differently when more lives had to fit inside them.

There was a knock at the half-open door.

Not Hanna. Amina.

She held Maryam's dark coat over one arm. "This was in the front

passage," she said. "If the rain comes properly, the hem will take all

of it."

Maryam took the coat. "Thank you."

Amina remained where she was. "The bed men will leave dust tomorrow. If

you are there, change your shoes before you come in."

"I said nothing about going."

"No."

"Then why say that?"

"Because I wash the stairs. Because cedar and mattress dust travel

farther than women think. Because children put their hands on hems." She

shifted the weight of the coat. "And because if there is to be more

carrying in and out, it is easier to clean for it in the right order."

There was nothing to answer. The sentence had been built entirely out of

household logic and yet carried more than household logic could honestly

contain.

Maryam said at last, "You always speak as if everything were a matter of

cleaning."

Amina looked beyond her into the room, at the brush, the packet, the

folded stockings, the order that might at any moment begin lying. "In

houses," she said, "most things are."

Then she went.

When Hanna came up later, he found her brushing the hem of the coat with

more care than the coat required.

"You need not do that tonight," he said.

"It is only dust."

"Yes."

He loosened his tie, set down his watch, and looked once at the coat,

once at her face, then away. "The bed men will come after one. I will go

from the office."

"I know."

"If you want to come, come before they arrive. Not while they are

carrying."

There was no reason to hear in the sentence anything except logistics.

So of course she heard more.

"I may not come at all."

He nodded as if that, too, were a practical possibility to be entered

beside registry copies and school fees. "Very well."

He lay down first. She remained sitting at the dressing table another

minute, looking at her own face in the glass. The glass offered no

verdict. What she felt was the new weight of plain objects: a coat, a

packet, a note in a drawer, a room to which a bed still belonged for one

more night.

When she finally came to bed, Hanna was awake. She could tell by the way

his breathing waited before settling.

"If Huda must stay another week," he said into the dark, "there is

room."

She had not expected him to speak of that. "Yes."

"Less room than before," he said after a moment. "But room."

He meant the house. He may have meant more than the house. Or he may

have meant only the house, which was its own difficulty. She was too

tired to know.

In the next room Leila turned in sleep and murmured something about

ribbon. Huda coughed once and quieted. The pipes gave their small

metallic complaint. Outside, the rain finally came properly, running

down the shutters and swallowing the last sounds from the road.

Maryam lay awake longer than she admitted to herself, listening to the

house hold more lives than it had been built to hold, and thinking of

the flat waiting with one less wardrobe, one almost-finished inventory,

and a bed that by tomorrow evening might be only boards, rope, and a

pale shape on the floor.

CHAPTER XV

The Demand

By breakfast the house had already divided itself into the day's smaller campaigns.

Huda needed a letter written to the cousin in Beirut who might, or might not, still have room. Ibrahim had lost the blue pencil he insisted was indispensable to arithmetic and turned out, after ten minutes of moral inquiry, to be sitting on it. Leila wanted to know whether men who removed beds ever removed dreams as well, and whether she ought to hide hers in the wardrobe in case they took the wrong one. Maryam's mother said children had no business discussing dreams before coffee and perhaps none afterwards. Aunt Widad, who had arrived before eight and spoken since, declared that people who moved furniture for money were usually more trustworthy than people who moved opinions for free. Hanna, sitting at the head of the table with his notebook open beside the bread, translated all of it into sequence.

"The bed men after one," he said. "Elias will have the key. I have the registry copy for Huda's landlord. I will go to the office first, then to the flat. If they are late, they are late. If they arrive before me, Elias is not to let them touch the journals or the letters. The bed only."

"The bed only," said Aunt Widad. "As if beds travelled without the dust under them."

"They do not," said Amina from the sideboard, "but dust has never once waited for permission."

Hanna looked up at Maryam. "You need not go."

He said it in the same tone in which he had said it the day before, and it carried the same double character: reprieve and exclusion, kindness and command. In another man

she might have heard only authority. In Hanna it remained what it often was: procedure trying, within its narrow means, to behave like care.

"I know," she said.

"Then let that be enough."

Leila, who had already dipped crust into jam and had red on her cuff because no prohibition ever reached her entirely in time, asked, "If the bed goes, where will the room sleep?"

"In the floorboards," said Amina.

"It cannot. Floorboards do not shut their eyes."

"Then perhaps rooms do not need sleep."

"That seems arrogant."

Ibrahim laughed, and the blue pencil fell from his lap onto the tiles, thereby proving that children and objects often disclosed the truth at the same moment. Huda stooped to pick it up before either child could. There was a new caution in her movements now, not frailty exactly, but the caution of a woman who had already moved once in dependence on another household and knew she might move again.

Hanna tore a page from the notebook and slid it across to Huda. "The cousin's address as I have it. If you mean to write, do it today. If it changes, it changes. If you wait for certainty, you will write to no one."

"That is a cheerful doctrine for breakfast," said Aunt Widad.

"It is a practical one."

Huda folded the paper without reading it. "I may write after luncheon."

"You may," said Hanna, in the tone of a man who heard the postponement and entered it into a mental ledger without protest because protest did not improve facts.

Maryam buttered bread she did not want and watched the table as one watched a railway platform on which several trains were somehow expected to depart from the same track. Huda's letter. Ibrahim's pencil. Leila's stockings. Aunt Widad's repeated question of whether the mattress ought to be turned before men carried it out because one never knew what stale shape a family bed might preserve for the street. Her mother's insistence that Huda's dark dress be brushed before noon because people in difficulty had a moral obligation not to resemble it. Hanna's notebook absorbing all of them without visible strain.

The bed men after one. Tariq had said, the previous day, if you come tomorrow, come before one.

He had said it low and without flourish, as a practical sentence requiring practical hearing. That had made it worse. A grander man would have weighted the line with feeling and therefore made it easier to resist. Tariq had left the sentence in the register of arrangement. Come before one. Hanna is going. I know.

When breakfast ended the household dispersed according to need and habit. Huda took Ibrahim upstairs to rewrite arithmetic that would have been perfectly legible to any teacher not himself. Leila was sent with Amina to find the second of the better dustcloths and came back carrying instead an old postcard and a dead moth, both of which she claimed might be useful later. Her mother retired not to rest, which she disapproved of on principle before noon, but to sit with the account book and a shawl across her knees in the room she insisted remained too bright for mourning even on days without sun.

Hanna stood in the passage fastening his cufflinks. "If the bed men ask for extra payment, tell Elias to wait for me."

"I am not going," said Maryam.

He glanced up. "No."

"Then why tell me?"

"Because you are standing there."

That answer, in another moment, might have made her laugh. Today she only said, "You have Huda's landlord as well."

"And the office."

"And the registry."

"Yes."

"You are overfilling the day."

"So is everyone."

He put on his hat. "If the Talbiya woman comes, ask Amina to check the silver she polished last week. The forks had spots."

In his world, nothing ceased to require attention when history behaved badly. Forks still spotted. Registry copies still needed stamps. Sisters still required landlords to be managed. Men still had to go where they had said they would go.

Before leaving he touched Leila's hair once, correcting the ribbon at the back, then looked at Maryam as if there were one more item to be named and decided against it. That too was one of the ways care failed in him: it reached the threshold of speech and then turned back into the list.

After he had gone the house seemed at once smaller and less organised, as though his departure had removed not authority but the illusion that sequence was in fact holding. The children's voices moved overhead. In the kitchen Amina instructed someone who was not there in tones of exhausted contempt. A cart went past outside, one

wheel sounding slightly wrong. The city had begun carrying wrong sounds more openly now: not yet disaster, but deviations from expected rhythm one felt before naming.

Maryam went upstairs with no real intention except the temporary decency of not remaining at the table after the man who had ordered the day had left it. In the bedroom the corrected packet lay where she had set it beside the brush and Nawal's note. She moved the note into the drawer. She took it out again. She set it beneath the packet. She lifted the packet and held it under her arm, then put it back because the gesture looked like a decision and she had not yet admitted to one.

There was a knock on the half-open door, and Amina came in carrying the mending basket and one of Leila's socks stretched over a small mushroom.

"The button is secure," she said of the coat. "The hem will not tell tales unless it meets another wall."

"It will meet only daylight."

"In this city daylight has become a busybody."

Maryam smiled despite herself and sat at the dressing table as if she meant to sort the tray. Amina crossed to the chair, set down the basket, and took up the coat once more to inspect the sleeve with the professional dissatisfaction of a woman who trusted no repair simply because it had already been made.

"The bed men are due after one?" she said.

"So I am told."

"Hanna will go."

"Yes."

Amina nodded as if that part had already been arranged in the household furniture and therefore did not interest her.

"Then either the room will be nearly finished tonight or the men will fail in some ordinary way and make more work tomorrow."

Maryam looked at her in the mirror. "Is that meant to comfort me?"

"It is meant to be a fact."

Amina reattached herself to the sock. "If you go out later, use the black shoes. The brown still carry dust at the seam."

"I said nothing about going out."

"No."

The one syllable held no insolence. It held only the sort of complete hearing labour sometimes forced on people. Maryam took up the hairbrush, put it down again, and said, "The city has made everyone suspicious."

"The city has made everyone observant. Suspicion is for people who have leisure."

There were some answers to which rank could object and some to which it could only remain still. Maryam said, after a moment, "And do you have leisure?"

Amina threaded the needle without looking down. "Not enough for suspicion."

From overhead came Leila's shout that Ibrahim had cheated at multiplication by using his finger where no finger should have been permitted. Huda called something too low to be heard distinctly, then coughed. The cough had improved a little after three nights in Hanna's house and then worsened again with the weather, as if the body itself had taken to imitating the city's indecision.

Maryam rose and crossed to the wardrobe. On the lower shelf, under two folded cardigans, lay the shawl from the flat. She did not touch it. Instead she took out the black

shoes, set them on the rug, and returned to the dressing table where the corrected packet still lay under the hairbrush.

Amina said, "Those, yes."

"What?"

"The black shoes. They tell less."

When Amina had gone Maryam stood in the middle of the room a full minute with the shoes at her feet and the packet in her hand. She told herself that staying at home was still possible. That Hanna had given her that possibility in the same tone in which he had assigned Elias the screws and Huda the cousin and the landlord the copy. That no one had required an answer by noon. That there was still the luncheon to consider and her mother's mood and Huda's letter and the Talbiya woman's forks and everything else with which respectable women peopled the day until desire had nowhere indecent to sit.

Then she wrapped the packet in plain paper, tied it, and went downstairs.

Amina was at the sideboard shaking crumbs from the breakfast cloth into yesterday's newspaper. She looked up once, saw the paper-wrapped packet under Maryam's arm, the black shoes, the coat she had brushed, and said only, "If anyone asks, you have gone to Habib's for the registry copies."

Maryam said, "Have I?"

"You may as well. Habib exists."

"Does that make it true?"

Amina folded the cloth. "It makes it serviceable."

Maryam left by the side door.

The quarter between late morning and luncheon had a false look of continuity. Women went out for bread or thread with baskets over their arms. Boys carried parcels and shouted after one another. A cart with paraffin tins rattled too fast round the corner and was cursed by three unrelated men as though that kept the road moral. But under the ordinary movement there was a second layer now, a notation laid over the day. People looked longer at loaded vehicles. Men paused at corners over folded papers. Women whose husbands had once conducted every errand themselves now carried lists in more public hands. Even the children seemed to understand, without understanding, that routes had become a subject for adults and that this made them, like all adult subjects, somehow more powerful than weather.

Habib's stationer's shop stood two streets over and nearer the tram road than her mother liked, which made it useful as an alibi because any errand that involved paper, copying, and a degree of inconvenience seemed automatically respectable. Habib himself was behind the counter arguing with a man over invoice books and scarcely looked at her when she entered.

"The copies?" he asked.

"They are not ready yet?"

"Nothing is ready until someone asks for it twice." He disappeared through the curtain to the back room. When he returned he handed her two folded sheets and said, "If anyone asks, these were difficult."

"I would never deprive a copy of its dignity."

"Good. Dignity is all that remains profitable."

He did not look at her a second time. That, too, made him useful.

The flat was as she had left it and not as she had left it. The bed remained, but the room knew it would not remain

long. The rolled carpet stood by the wall. The chair from the bedroom had already been moved to the sitting room because, Tariq had told her yesterday, it was easier to take objects in sequence than in memory. His satchel lay on the round table. The mug remained on the sill. The pile of notices Khalil had brought was larger.

Tariq looked up when she entered and for a second his face altered with a relief so slight it would have been invisible in another man. Then the expression was gone.

"You came."

"Yes."

He took the packet from her and set it beside the letters without unwrapping it at once. "Khalil may come."

"For papers?"

"For me."

He said it plainly, and that was enough to tighten the room.

She asked what had happened. He told her: the tram line to Bab al-Sahira was already less reliable than the men who sold tickets pretended; Khalil's friend's brother had found a cart on Thursday for his mother to see the doctor and perhaps stay a night or two with the sister near the gate; and the headmaster's brother knew of one room near the convent if a teacher needed to move his family nearer the route. He said all this in the tone of a man reading notices to himself and discovering they had become personal.

"My mother may have to move for a few days," he said. "Or not. I may have to move her myself. Or not. The school may need men nearer to it. Or not. Your husband is already finding ways south for your sister. The city is full of maybes pretending not to be decisions. I am tired of living in them as if they were weather."

Before Maryam could answer there was a step on the landing and Khalil entered carrying two notices and a rolled map. He stopped when he saw her, recalculated, and then decided courtesy was not worth delay.

"The cart on Thursday will not wait for principles," he said to Tariq. "If your mother means to see the doctor, tell me before dusk. Farid's brother will not hold the space because old women prefer their own kettles."

"My mother is not old."

"She is old enough for transport to have become political."

He set the map on the table. "And if the school needs two men nearer the gate by Friday, I need to know whether one of them is you or whether I am begging elsewhere."

Tariq said nothing.

Khalil looked at the stripped room. "You are not short of walls," he said. "You are short of time."

Then he glanced at Maryam with a courtesy sharpened rather than softened by fatigue, and left.

For several seconds the room contained only the old house sounds: a board settling, the distant cart on the street, the tap in the kitchen not fully tightened, the soft touch of newspaper under the mug on the sill.

Maryam said, because silence had become impossible, "He dislikes me."

"No," said Tariq. "He dislikes delay."

"And he thinks I am delay."

He did not answer at once. When he did, the answer was mild enough to wound more cleanly. "You have not been an acceleration."

She moved to the window because objects were easier to face than him. Outside, the lane looked no different from

any lane in which women went in and out carrying parcels and men watched lorries as if they might confess the future if looked at correctly enough.

"You need not speak to me at all," she said.

"That is the one thing that has stopped being possible."

When she turned, he was standing by the table, one hand flat on the notices Khalil had brought, the other hanging uselessly by his side as though it had once expected to hold something and now mistrusted itself.

"I need to know," he said, "whether I am arranging one life or another."

There it was. Not Choose me. Not even I love you, though that had long since ceased to require saying. The sentence was worse for being plain.

She felt, absurdly, not a rush of feeling but a rush of practical images: Leila's stockings. Huda's letter. The doctor at Bab al-Sahira. Hanna counting rooms. The blue mug on the sill. The bed men coming up the stairs. Every object in the last fortnight seemed suddenly to turn and look at her from its own use.

"You ask as if there were an arrangement to make," she said.

"There is always an arrangement to make. That is what your husband understands."

"Do not use him like that."

"I am not using him. I am saying what is visible."

"What is visible?" she said. "That he counts rooms? That he plans? That he does not wake in a room and find that yesterday has poisoned the handle of every door?"

"You think planning saves him from that?"

"I think nothing saves anyone from anything now."

"Then say that. But do not call it not choosing."

He had moved a little closer without either of them deciding to move. The notices under his hand had begun to crumple at the edge.

"I have a child," she said.

"Yes."

"I have a house."

"Yes."

"I have Huda in the spare room and Ibrahim on the camp bed and my mother counting teaspoons as if they were part of the frontier and a husband who may be impossible and yet is not wrong often enough to be dismissed. I have no sentence for what you are asking."

"Then say there is none."

"There is none."

"No," he said, and for the first time his voice sharpened in a way she had not heard from him before. "There is no clean one. That is different."

He mastered that sharpness almost at once, but not entirely. "If the answer is no, say no. If the answer is that I am to go on arranging papers and routes and visits while pretending the rest belongs to weather, say that. If I am moving my mother and perhaps taking a room near the convent and making myself absent from half the city for a fortnight, tell me whether I am doing that as one man or another."

She heard herself say, "You should do what you must for your mother."

He closed his eyes once. "That is not an answer."

"It is the only one I have."

"No," he said. "It is the one that leaves you blameless."

The room went very still.

She had not thought until that moment that anything he could say might truly injure her. He had been exact, dry, impatient perhaps. But this sentence reached the place in her she had most carefully translated into difficulty, duty, exhaustion, the city, Leila, Huda, rooms, roads — all the true things that had become shelter. Blameless.

She said, with more coldness than she felt and less than he deserved, "You become ugly when you are tired."

"And you become honest for half a second and then retreat into furniture."

Below them came the porter's boy's voice calling up that the bed men had arrived.

Neither moved at once.

Then Tariq took his hand from the notices, straightened them with two unnecessary motions, and said, in a tone so corrected it might have belonged to a stranger, "Tell Elias to bring them up."

The bed men entered with the professional indifference of people who had seen too many thresholds to imagine significance attached only to this one. One was older, with a dented cap and the patience of a man who expected furniture and families to resist with equal stupidity. The other was young enough to apologise whenever a bed leg struck plaster.

"The whole?" the older man asked.

"The whole," said Tariq.

"Mattress too?"

"Yes."

"Sheets?"

"They are gone."

Business. Rope. Turn. Lift. The bed became, again, a bed: iron, mattress, weight. The younger man apologised when one leg struck the wall and left a fresh mark above the pale rectangle where the wardrobe had stood. The older one told him apology did not lift corners and to mind the door more than the plaster. The mattress bent at the middle and released a puff of trapped dust and cold.

Then Elias said from the landing, "Khawaja Hanna is in the lane."

For one instant Maryam thought she might not be able to breathe. Not because there was anything to see. Because there was now too little and too much in the room.

Hanna appeared exactly as he always appeared in tight conditions: hat off, coat unbuttoned, fatigue arranged into usefulness. His eyes took in the bed half-turned, the mattress bent, the pale wall, Tariq by the table, Maryam by the bedroom threshold, Elias holding the door, and the older man asking where to put the screws so no child swallowed one later. It took him perhaps two seconds.

"Wrap them in paper and mark them," he said to the older man. To Elias: "Not on the sill. In the blue tin." To the younger one: "Lift from that side or you will take the door with you." To Maryam, and here his voice changed only by a grain: "You came."

"The packet—"

"Yes," he said, as if packet were answer enough and no dignity was gained by forcing her to enlarge it. Then to Tariq: "Did the registry copy satisfy the cousin's man?"

"He signed. The surveyor note is in the packet."

"Good."

No theatre in either man. That was perhaps why the room became more dangerous, not less. Each treated the other

exactly as the work required, and nothing in the work admitted what else now stood in it.

When the bed men had gone down with the mattress and frame and the bedroom showed floorboards where no one had seen floorboards in years, Hanna stood in the doorway wiping plaster dust from his cuff.

"It looks larger," he said.

"It looks ruder," said Aunt Widad from the landing, where she had apparently materialised from instinct for removal.

"No room was ever improved by becoming honest," said Hanna.

The line might once have belonged to Yusef. Coming from Hanna it sounded less like wit than a report entered under protest.

Hanna picked up his hat again. "I will go ahead to the house," he said to Maryam. "If you come now, we can still reach luncheon before the children overturn order entirely."

He did not ask whether she was coming. He assumed sequence.

At luncheon he spoke to Huda about the cousin's landlord, to her mother about the price of paraffin, to Aunt Widad about the cemetery receipt, and to Ibrahim about why a bed removed from a room did not thereby make the room available for marbles. He did not once speak to Maryam in a tone different from the one he would have used before breakfast. That proved nothing and made nothing easier.

Huda had written the Beirut letter after all. It lay by her plate, folded and refolded. After luncheon she handed it to Hanna.

"You know the better phrasing for men who think they are being generous," she said.

He read it at the table because she had asked him to. "The wording is fine," he said.

"That usually means it is not."

"It means only that if you ask to be taken in indefinitely, they will grow moral before they grow honest. Ask for ten days. Leave room for extension. People are more generous with increments than with lives."

Aunt Widad, still at the table because no household emergency had yet successfully excluded her, said, "That is true of money as well."

Huda looked down. "I do not wish to appear mercenary."

"You wish to appear temporary," said Hanna. "It is not the same thing."

"Is it still temporary?" she asked.

The table went still. Hanna set down the letter.

"We still have rooms," he said. "That is the only sentence I can guarantee today."

Her mother said, "Rooms are not plans."

"No. They are what make plans unnecessary for one more night."

After the meal Amina said to Maryam, without looking at her, "The black shoes are in the passage. I left the soles outward."

Maryam said, "I am not going out again today."

"Then the shoes will enjoy their certainty without you."

Later she sat upstairs, hearing Huda cough in the next room and Hanna close a drawer below, and thought of the room at Yusef's flat now containing no bed and therefore no last lie of ordinary life. There were people all over the city already arranging transport for mothers, rooms for

teachers, places in carts, copies of notices, spare corners in cousins' houses, ways south that were not comfortable but were still ways.

Only she, among them all, had replied to urgency with a sentence that allowed nothing to move.

By dusk there was another thin household sitting. Her mother drank tea and complained that the Talbiya woman had come only to say her brother's route was now impossible after dark, which proved that people no longer understood condolence. Aunt Widad said condolences now travelled like contraband and ought not to be judged by old standards. Huda had sealed the Beirut letter but not yet given it to the boy. She kept touching the flap as though it might still open by shame.

Hanna came in with two smaller sheets tucked into the registry copy and dust at one cuff where the bed had marked him. He washed his hands, came back, and wrote the cousin's street more clearly beneath Huda's hand.

"Samir's driver leaves before nine," he said. "If the road south remains open at all, it will be open then."

Then he took from his pocket a folded list and laid it beside the tea things. It contained, in his narrow hand, the names of those for whom there might be transport south if the month worsened: Huda and Ibrahim first; perhaps Aunt Widad if she ceased calling every contingency melodrama; one trunk only; linen reduced; papers in inner pocket; no silver unless sewn into hems by someone more patient than himself.

He did not read the list aloud. He only looked at it once, added a word, and folded it again. But Maryam saw it, and seeing it altered the room more than if he had announced it.

At dusk Amina brought up the brushed coat and set it over the chairback without comment. Then, as she turned to go,

she said, "If you leave shoes in the passage, leave the black ones. The brown still tell more."

"I know," said Maryam.

Amina rested one hand on the doorframe. "Knowing is usually the easier half."

Then she went downstairs.

Maryam stood looking at the coat, the dressing table, the packet on the chair, the room that had once been merely hers and now felt already as though it contained too many arrangements and not enough decisions. Outside, the quarter was entering evening with the attention of a place that expected interruption. Somewhere below a driver shouted about sacks. Somewhere farther off a wireless was being tuned badly.

Nothing had been settled. Beds were removed, rooms measured, notes written, places offered, routes discussed, mothers considered, cousins accommodated. Practical life had continued in full possession of its powers. Only the central question had remained where it was, neither answered nor refused, simply placed between two people and left there.

She remained where she was until Amina came up again with the lamp and said, as if remarking only on weather, "Your mother says if there is to be more writing to Beirut, it is better done before supper than after tears."

Maryam turned her head. "What tears?"

Amina set down the lamp. "The ones everybody is now arranging for later."

CHAPTER XVI

Narrowing Streets

The first thing Maryam registered on waking was not light but

occupation.

Somebody was in the passage outside her room, not trying to be quiet,

simply moving with the confidence of a person who had slept under

another roof and been told to make use of it. A basin touched a wall. A

child coughed. A door that was not hers opened and shut with the

irritated care of a house already full beyond the point at which doors

wished to close properly. For a moment she lay still, looking at the

chair where she had left her dress, and could not remember whether she

had slept or only lain in bed until noise folded itself over her.

Then she remembered at once: Huda and Ibrahim in the spare room, Aunt

Widad's insistence that a child should not sleep near a front window

now, Hanna carrying the camp bed through the corridor as though it were

only another piece of furniture and not an admission, the registry copy

under the sugar bowl because there had been nowhere safer to keep it,

Amina brushing her coat in the pantry without comment, and, behind all

of that, the flat and the room and the fact which sleep had not altered.

The room was colder than it had been a week earlier. February had

sharpened in the night. The window did not seal properly and the

curtains moved a little at the hem though the glass was shut. On the

table beside the bed lay the envelope Hanna had placed there himself:

baptism certificate, marriage certificate, Leila's birth record, two

bank papers, one parish note. Last week he would not have set family

documents beside a lamp and called that order.

In the corridor Leila was already quarrelling.

"Why is he in my place?"

"Because it is not your place this week," came Amina's answer.

"It was my place yesterday."

"Yesterday has gone."

Maryam opened the door before the quarrel could enlarge itself. The

corridor looked narrower than it ever had in daylight. Huda's travelling

case stood against the wall with Ibrahim's shoes beside it. A folded

blanket lay across the back of a chair because there was nowhere else to

put it and no one had yet had the courage to admit that the chair now

existed in order to hold blankets.

In the kitchen ordinary work had resumed in the wrong register. Amina

had lit both burners. The kettle steamed. A loaf stood open on the table

beside the sugar bowl beneath which Hanna's folded registry copy still

sat, too important to be left anywhere safer, too temporary to deserve a

drawer.

Hanna was already dressed. Not fully, but enough that the day had

plainly begun for him some time before she woke. He stood at the end of

the table with a cup in one hand and a sheet of paper in the other.

"You slept," he said when he saw her.

It was not a question.

"So did you, apparently."

"Enough."

He glanced at Huda and Ibrahim, then back at Maryam. "The lower road was

watched again at dawn. Amina had to come by the gardens."

Amina, slicing bread with more force than the loaf required, said, "By

the gardens, around the school, behind the chemist, through mud, past

two men who had decided the street belonged to them before breakfast,

and up the hill carrying your potatoes. But yes. By the gardens."

Huda said, "My cousin sent word at six that a family from Baq'a had

already moved their children to relatives farther in."

Aunt Widad, entering at exactly that moment with her hat not yet pinned

on but already disapproving of something, said, "People move children

every time a tyre bursts now. It is becoming a fashion."

"It may be a sensible fashion," Hanna said.

The quietness of the answer altered the room more than a louder one

would have done.

"I think one notes what people with good information begin doing before

they say why they have done it," he added.

Amina put the bread basket down hard enough to make Leila jump. "Then

note also that bakers are shortening their hours, which means fear and

bread have at least one thing in common: they arrive earlier now."

Leila said, "Morning has facts and potatoes."

"Then respect both," Amina told her.

For a while the day continued in the cramped wrong key of temporary

cohabitation. Huda folded and refolded the same three things. Aunt Widad

pinned her hat and unpinned it because the first attempt failed to look

mournful enough. Ibrahim asked whether he might take the smaller spoon

because it made less noise. Leila asked whether he meant to stay forever

and was instructed by everyone in the room to keep quiet, which

naturally convinced her the question had been excellent.

Before Father Elias arrived, Huda and Maryam spent ten minutes moving

linen from one cupboard to another for no reason either of them

respected. Huda said, "Your house still smells like itself."

"That is not always praise."

"No. But when one has left a house in the dark it begins to seem like a

luxury."

Maryam handed her another stack. Cedar and starch rose from it. "Will

you go back?" she asked.

"For what?"

"The rest of your things."

Huda smoothed the top sheet though it required no smoothing. "The rest

of my things are things. Ibrahim is already here."

At a quarter to noon Maryam took her coat from the peg. She had delayed

long enough to know the delay for what it was. Amina appeared with a

cloth parcel. "Bread, cheese, and two apples. If you stay longer than

you intend, you will become foolish and call it tiredness."

She walked to the flat by way of the longer road because the shorter one

had become, in the language people now used, not impossible but unwise.

A grocer stood outside his own shop door with his stock sheet in one

hand and his shop key in the other, as if uncertain which object now

mattered more. Two boys carried rolled mattresses between them as

solemnly as altar cloth. Qatamon was not emptying, not yet. It was

narrowing. Streets felt as if things were happening in them before one

arrived and would continue after one had passed.

At the flat the walnut chest had not yet been moved. Elias let her in

and said, "Mr al-Khatib is here."

The sitting room looked barer than it had two days earlier. On the wall

behind the chest there was a pale rectangle where the wood had protected

the plaster from light for years. Tariq was kneeling by the desk with

the ledger open across one knee. He stood when he saw her.

"The chest is still here," he said.

"Most old furniture behaves as if it has tenancy rights."

His coat was over the chair back. The patch at the inner wrist of his

shirt showed where the cuff had slipped. On the desk lay the municipal

papers, the bank letters, and a second pile of pages not Yusef's.

They worked with the door open because the men were in the stair and

because no one had to tell either of them that a shut door had become an

act. The remaining papers proved less important than the first piles had

promised: old parish circulars, an insurance form concerning water

damage, two account books, a packet of receipts that belonged to a man

dead ten years and had no business still being in Yusef's drawer.

He took one of the apples from the parcel without asking, cut it with

Yusef's paper knife into uneven pieces, and set two on a folded

newspaper between them.

"Have you eaten?" he asked.

"Enough."

"That is not what the parcel suggests."

In the stair the men moved the chest an inch and let it down again. The

floor trembled slightly under the weight.

"Will you go?" she asked, hearing too late how the sentence might sound.

He answered the safer version. "Back to the school? After this."

"No. I mean if the roads narrow further."

He laid the knife down. "The practical answer is that I will go if my

mother can be moved and if there is a road worth the risk. The other

answer is that people do not leave one thing only. They leave what still

clings to it."

When the men finally entered for the chest, the room surrendered itself

at once to their competence. Tariq held the door wider while they angled

the wood through it and one handle caught against the frame. Dust came

down from the upper moulding. Maryam coughed. The chest cleared by less

than an inch.

After they had gone, the room was not larger. It only looked as if

something had been removed that could not be replaced by size.

"You should go," Tariq said.

It was not dismissal. It was care badly disguised as timing.

He had drawn the school pages a little nearer her. Attendance lists,

though attendance had become the wrong word. Beside some names were

notes in his hand: gone to relatives in Jericho, mother asks for papers,

to be sent ahead if possible.

"They are leaving already," she said.

"They are being sent ahead," he said. "That is the respectable phrase."

"And the unrespectable one?"

"That people are beginning to count how much of a child can be moved in

advance of a household."

She put the pages down. When he spoke again the edge had left his voice,

which somehow made it worse.

"I asked you a practical question," he said. "I have not asked it again.

I am trying, for the present, to mistake that for patience."

Below them somebody shouted for a porter. The sound rose through the

window and fell away.

Maryam said, "There is no answer that does not destroy something."

"That was true last week."

"It is truer now."

"Yes." He put the satchel on the chair beside him. "Which is why I have

not asked the question again."

She wanted to say something that would alter the room irreparably.

Instead she said, "Do not leave the ledger in the little room. The dust

there gets into everything."

It was an absurd sentence and therefore the only one she could trust.

He answered in the same key. "Then perhaps that room is more honest than

the rest of the house."

When she left, Elias was helping guide the chest on to the cart. A woman

from the neighbouring building stood with a bowl in her hands and

watched as if furniture had become public information.

She did not take the same road back. A cart loaded with bedsteads had

jammed the turn by the school and a British lorry had chosen that exact

moment to assert a right of passage no one else was in a position to

refuse. She stood with three other women while the cart was angled and

re-angled and the driver of the lorry performed authority through his

teeth. One of the women held a birdcage under her shawl. Another had a

baby tied to her back and a saucepan in her free hand. No one addressed

the absurdity because absurdity had become expensive.

By the time she reached the grocer's corner the knot had dissolved into

smaller purposes. The birdcage went one way, the bedsteads another, the

lorry forward at last with its unnecessary certainty. What had changed

was not only traffic. Every small delay now seemed to threaten the next

three things in line behind it.

At home Amina opened the door with a button tin in one hand. "The chest

has gone and no one has died," she called towards the back room. Then,

more quietly: "Hanna has been home and out again. He left a note."

The note lay under the salt cellar. Hanna's hand, fast and clean: If I

am late, do not wait supper. Keep the envelope with the certificates in

your room tonight.

Not wait supper. Keep the envelope in your room. Everything was being

advanced a quarter-turn from ordinary. Not enough for proclamation.

Enough to make habit begin looking foolish.

In the passage Leila and Ibrahim had built a roadway marked out by books

and blocks along which Ibrahim's two tin cars could travel without

touching the floorboards.

"It is the long road," Leila explained. "The short road has bad men in

it."

"Who told you that?"

"No one. Ibrahim did."

Ibrahim, kneeling over the cars, said without looking up, "Everyone

knows."

That, Maryam thought, was how children were now being educated. Not by

schoolbooks alone but by the new geography of hearsay.

A little after one Father Elias sent himself, together with a young man

from the parish carrying a school exercise book. The young man asked how

many rooms could be closed off if needed, how many beds were in use, and

how many children were in the house.

"Two here now," Huda said. "One ours, one not."

Leila, listening from the doorway, said, "I am not not. I belong here."

Father Elias turned to her at once. "And therefore your place is the

stronger one," he said. "Which means you may help by not standing in

thresholds."

When the young man had finished counting and gone, Huda said, "It did

not make me feel safer. It made me feel included."

As the light began to fail, Amina came to the pantry door holding an old

pillowcase knotted at the top.

"I will leave this here tonight, if you please."

"What is in it?" Leila asked at once.

"A woman's future," Amina said. "Two aprons, one shawl, stockings, and

soap."

The name Deir Yassin entered the house not through the radio first but

through bread.

Amina came in one morning carrying two loaves under one arm and no

expression on her face at all, which in itself was an announcement. She

set the bread down, untied her scarf, and said, "The convent side is

full of people who are not going where they said."

"What does that mean?" her mother asked.

"It means women from outside the quarter are carrying children and not

stopping to greet. It means one cart had no bedding and three suitcases,

which is never a visit."

Aunt Widad arrived fifteen minutes later without hat pin, gloves

unmatched, and one button on her cuff unfastened. That was what passed

in their world for running.

"It is Deir Yassin," she said from the hall before anybody had formally

admitted her.

Her mother closed her eyes once. "Can one morning not arrive properly

through the door?"

"No," said Aunt Widad. "Mornings no longer trust doors."

Hanna stood. "Who told you?"

"Salma's neighbour's son, who heard it from a taxi driver, which under

better conditions would make the whole thing fiction. Under worse

conditions it makes it early."

Leila said, "Is it another hotel?"

"No," said Hanna. He hesitated, not from softness but from accuracy. "A

village."

"Not at table," her mother said.

"At table is precisely where it belongs," Aunt Widad answered.

"Everything belongs at table once it has begun entering houses."

From the school a note arrived in Tariq's hand: Do not send Leila by

carriage if the driver is from outside the quarter. Use the convent

road. Come early.

Hanna took it from Maryam's hand before she had decided whether that

movement would look guilty. He read it, gave it back, and said, "He is

right about the driver."

The room altered on its hinges. A man's rightness had become, by noon,

another household duty. Maryam folded the note once and placed it

beneath her saucer.

Hanna left with his hat still unbrushed. That detail, more than all the

names in circulation, frightened Maryam. Hanna did not neglect hats.

By afternoon Deir Yassin had stopped being merely a name and become a

method of speech. People no longer said, "Have you heard?" They said,

"If even that is possible..." and left the sentence open because

openness itself had begun doing more damage than completion.

That evening Amina failed to go home.

It happened not grandly but by accumulation. She had stayed later

because the milk boiled over, because Leila's ribbon had gone missing,

because a note for Hanna had arrived after dusk. By the time she tied

her scarf and reached the gate, the lower road had begun producing those

sharp running clusters of men who made even sensible people walk back

indoors pretending they had forgotten something.

She returned three minutes later and said, "I will sleep here."

Her mother looked up from the account book. "In the servants' room?"

"Where else?"

"There is no need to make announcements."

"There is if someone will otherwise bolt the side door."

That silenced the room in a new way. Not because Amina had been

insolent. Because she had stated, in the plain grammar of labour, that a

route had failed.

Aunt Widad set down her cup. "Then take the side room. Not the bench."

Later that night Maryam found Hanna in their bedroom with the wardrobe

doors open. He was not rummaging. He was selecting.

Two changes of linen. One warm cardigan for Leila — the thicker one she

disliked because it scratched her neck. One of Maryam's darker dresses

folded without tenderness. The envelope of certificates. Stockings,

rolled. Her small jewellery case, not the larger box.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

"Choosing the things one would not wish to choose quickly."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the whole answer."

"We are not leaving tonight," Maryam said.

"No."

"Or tomorrow."

"I have not said tomorrow."

"You have said shoes by beds and papers by lamps and now this."

He set the little case on the chair. "So that if I say we should move

for two days, I do not have to stand here while you argue with me about

stockings."

"Two days."

"Yes."

"And if two becomes five?"

"Then five becomes five."

She turned away because there was nowhere in the room to direct her

anger that did not make it childish.

"I am not asking you to like this," he said. "Only not to leave it until

liking is no longer one of the options."

Then, because he was tired and too near the truth, he added, "I think

you would still be choosing a coat that made it look as if you were

returning."

The accuracy of it shocked them both.

"I should not have said that," he said at once.

"No," she answered. "You should not."

But the wound lay there because it was near enough to truth to have

blood in it.

He lifted the case from the bed and set it on the chair. It was not

large. That was the last insult. Its size told the truth about every

sentimental instinct she had not yet had time to examine: that what

could be moved might not be what she thought most necessary, and what

she could not imagine leaving might be asked of her without ceremony.

After supper the house narrowed again, though no one had arrived and no

piece of furniture had left. Shoes now meant departure. An envelope

meant proof. A pillowcase knotted at the top meant a woman whose route

home had failed. A child's road of books in the passage meant that even

play had accepted the map of danger.

In the little room off the kitchen the spare mattress creaked once as

Amina lay down in a house not her own because the streets between houses

had begun behaving like arguments. Upstairs Leila turned in sleep. From

somewhere beyond the shutters came a burst of sound too sustained to

mistake and too far to fix precisely. Not thunder. Not boys. Not

anything houses built for correctness could comfortably classify.

Maryam stood with one hand on the hall table. On it lay the folded list,

the registry copy, the pin dish, and one of Leila's blue pencils with

the point bitten off. No single object had changed. Together they had

begun to look like preparation.

Hanna came out behind her, removing his cufflinks one by one.

"The lower road is finished after dusk," he said.

"For tonight?"

"For now."

He set the cufflinks in the dish beside the pencil. "Tomorrow I will

fetch the last of Yusef's papers before noon. After that I am not

certain the flat should remain one of our habits."

He said it as he said everything difficult: not to wound, not to reveal,

but to place the next usable fact in front of whoever had to live with

it.

Maryam looked at the table. "Nothing remains one of our habits."

"No," he said.

From the next room came Leila's sleeping breath. From the side room

Amina's silence. From outside, men calling to one another in the short,

unmusical tones that meant carrying, not conversation.

Tomorrow would arrive early again.

CHAPTER XVII

The Third Letter

The third letter arrived folded into itself so many times that the outer

sheet had gone soft at the creases.

Maryam found it on the hall table beneath the saucer where Hanna now

kept loose keys and under the school circular Leila had brought home the

day before with jam on one corner. The address had been crossed out

twice. The first hand was Nadia's, the second not. A redirection in

another hand had been squeezed along the margin so tightly that the

final word bent into the stamp.

She stood with her gloves still on and looked at the envelope before she

opened it. For a moment she thought absurdly that if she left it shut

she might preserve the version of Nadia that still wrote as if Beirut

were a temporary inconvenience arranged by cousins. Then Leila came

running from the passage with only one stocking on and said, "Amina says

there is no hot water because someone forgot there was a fire," and the

envelope became another object that had to be dealt with.

In the kitchen Huda was already dressed to go out, Ibrahim still in his

undershirt and cross because he had lost one of his school books beneath

the camp bed. The side room smelled of damp blanket and yesterday's

coal. Amina, who had now slept two nights in the side room because the lower road had not improved either morning, stood at the stove with her scarf tied badly and a spoon in one hand.

"No hot water because the kettle was put on the small burner and then

your daughter asked me where her blue ribbon was and your aunt asked

whether rice had become more expensive since last week and Huda wanted

pins," she said, before Maryam could speak. "So now there will be hot

water in five minutes if nobody asks anything else of me."

Leila said, "Where is my blue ribbon?"

Amina closed her eyes briefly. "Exactly so."

Huda turned from the table, fastening one cuff. "I can take Ibrahim to

his cousin and come back before luncheon. That would help."

"It would help if you came back," Amina said. "Going out is always

generous. Returning is the useful part."

Huda laughed because she had not yet been in the house long enough to

know when Amina’s remarks were jokes and when they were inventory.

Maryam took the letter to the window and opened it with the bread knife

because no one had put the paper knife back in the drawer after Yusef’s

things were sorted into smaller and smaller categories. Nadia’s hand was

the same and not the same. It slanted a little more now and crowded the

margin less because the sheet itself had become shorter. There was no

opening fuss, no report of weather, no mention of which cousin had lent

which room. The first sentence was practical.

Bring papers first. Bring only what can be carried without discussion.

Then came the list that was not a list and therefore harder to bear.

Milk uncertain. Two children with coughs. Too many shoes in one passage.

A woman from Haifa sleeping in the dining room and apologising for her

dreams. The landlord patient for now. Another address may follow. Do not

wait for everything to become clear, because clarity is now what people

ask for after it has become useless.

At the end Nadia had written, more tightly as if the line had been added

with the sheet already folded once, I am telling you this without drama

because there is enough of that elsewhere. Come before your reasons

begin sounding respectable to you.

Maryam read the last sentence again.

“A bad one?” Huda asked.

Maryam looked up. “A practical one.”

Huda gave the small nod of someone who had begun to understand that

practical letters were now the worst kind. She tied her hat ribbon

beneath her chin and said to Ibrahim, “Shoes.”

“I have them on.”

“Then try not to look as if you are being deported to school.”

“School is worse than being deported.”

No one contradicted him. That, more than the child’s words, altered the

morning.

Maryam folded the letter once and put it into her pocket. She thought

she would answer it at once, before breakfast, before Aunt Widad

arrived, before Hanna came back from the parish office, before the house

resumed its bad imitation of sequence. Instead she spent ten minutes

finding Leila's second shoe, seven more locating the blue ribbon in the

drawer where Leila herself had hidden it, and another fifteen looking

for the small bottle of stomach drops her mother declared had vanished

because people no longer respected drawers.

By the time she sat at the dining table with paper before her, the

kitchen had become too loud and the hall too narrow for thought. Huda

and Ibrahim had gone. Amina was rinsing the same pan for the third time

because each interruption had added something else to it. Her mother was

in the drawing room telling Aunt Widad, who had arrived without

knocking, that the house no longer ran on hours but on incursions.

Maryam wrote, My dearest Nadia, and stopped.

The form of the sentence looked false at once. Not false in affection.

Nadia was dear to her, had always been dearer than the cousins who took

offence as a hobby and charity as rank. False in tone. Dearest belonged

to a letter that still had room for weather and visits and the size of a

child’s appetite. She drew a line through it and began again.

Nadia,

That looked worse.

She sat with the pen lifted and listened to the house.

Aunt Widad in the next room saying that one could not expect servants to

sleep in and out of a house indefinitely without confusion entering

every shelf. Her mother answering that confusion had entered long before

the servant stayed. Amina setting down crockery with the degree of care

that meant her temper was at work beneath it. From upstairs the noise of

Leila singing to herself and missing the tune by confidence rather than

error.

Maryam wrote, We received your letter this morning and were grateful for

it.

This was true and dead.

She looked at the line until the ink dried. Then she folded the paper

once without tearing it, put it beneath Nadia’s letter, and slid both

under the account book at the end of the table. She told herself she

would answer after luncheon, when the house had thinned. She did not

quite believe herself, which made the gesture cleaner and uglier at

once.

Hanna came in at eleven carrying a smaller bundle of Yusef’s papers

under one arm and two loaves of bread under the other. The papers were

tied with blue string. The bread had flour on the crust from a hand not

yet washed.

“The parish copy is missing,” he said by way of greeting.

Aunt Widad said, “Missing or misfiled?”

“In a church office those are often theological variations on the same

condition.”

He set the loaves down, then the papers. “Father Elias believes he can

find the burial notation if the younger clerk has not put April into

March again.”

Maryam said, “Did you go to the flat?”

“No. There is nothing left worth a journey except the parish ledger, and I did not want to stand in that room while being told a porter might be

available in the afternoon or next week.”

Aunt Widad said, “Then the room is nearly finished.”

“Nearly is what everything is now,” Hanna said.

Hanna untied the string and began removing the papers with the

expression of a man who had already accepted that every useful object in

the house would now need to coexist on tables with every object not

meant for tables at all.

There was a map among Yusef’s things. Not a military map, not even a

current one, but a school map of Jerusalem mounted on linen with the

edges cracked. Hanna spread it beside the bread knife and weighted one

corner with the sugar bowl.

“What is that doing there?” Maryam asked.

“Being useful.”

“For what?”

“For seeing which roads are now stories and which are still roads.”

He spoke without flourish. That was his way. A more expressive man would

have turned the sentence into warning. Hanna laid it flat between loaf,

sugar, and unpaid bill, and it became part of breakfast.

He marked nothing on it. He only looked. The lower road. The road by the

gardens. The line towards the parish. The turn near the school. Later,

she saw, the map would become the kind of object people began glancing

at without admitting they were doing it.

At luncheon Amina failed to appear with the rice.

This would once have meant little: a pan late on the stove, a servant

distracted, an aunt making remarks about standards. Now it altered the

room at once. Huda was not back yet, Ibrahim with her, Leila whining

because the lentils were touching the spoon, Maryam's mother speaking

about weakness in the tones of someone accusing fatigue of bad breeding.

When Amina finally came in she had flour on one sleeve and a rip in the

edge of her apron.

"What happened?" Maryam asked.

"The baker had shut," Amina said. "Then he had opened again. Then his

wife decided one must pay now and not tomorrow because tomorrow had

begun speaking too loudly for her liking. Then the neighbour wanted the

old jar back and could not remember which old jar she meant.”

She set down the rice. “I am telling you the whole story because I know

if I say only that the baker delayed, your aunt will conclude bread has

become a form of indiscipline.”

Aunt Widad said, “I am sitting here.”

“I have never relied on invisibility where you are concerned.”

Hanna, who had been dividing the smaller loaf as if bread too must now

be portioned with foresight, said, “Sit down and eat.”

“I still have to go home.”

“You may not manage both.”

Amina looked at him. “I know.”

The admission passed across the table like another dish, one no one

wished to be handed but each understood was there.

She did not sit long. Before the plates were cleared she had rinsed her

hands, changed the torn apron for the older dark one, and tied on her

scarf. From the side room she took the knotted pillowcase she had begun

leaving by the door as if it were both luggage and proof.

“If the lower road is watched,” Hanna said, “go by your sister’s and

send word if you can.”

“I know where my sister lives.”

“That is not the doubtful part.”

Amina tucked the pillowcase beneath her arm. “If I do not return, you

will notice. That is enough system for one day.”

She went out by the upper road without further ceremony. Maryam watched

from the window until the scarf disappeared beyond the Abu-Rashids’

wall. What unsettled her was not that Amina had gone but how quickly the

house rearranged itself around the fact. The side room door remained

half open. The folded blanket stayed where it had been. No one said

whether that counted as prudence or expectation.

After luncheon Huda returned with Ibrahim and a paper parcel of thread

she claimed to have found only because one shopkeeper had not yet learnt

to look frightened before noon. Ibrahim brought back school copybooks

and a story about two boys fighting over a map. Leila demanded to know

who won. He answered, “The teacher,” which was not the sort of answer

children expected and therefore impressed her.

The day then broke into the kind of bad pieces that only a house under

pressure can produce. The milk turned. A button came off Ibrahim's coat.

Huda had to go back out because she had left the cousin's house key in

the cousin's passage and the cousin had gone to visit an aunt with weak

lungs. Father Elias called and asked whether Hanna still had the older

receipt book because a young man from the office had made a face at him

when asked to look for the register. Maryam found herself boiling a

kettle herself because no one else had the right instinct for which pot

belonged on which flame once the kitchen lost the person who usually

thought three movements ahead.

At half past two the chemist's delivery boy knocked for payment on a

bottle her mother had ordered three days earlier and only now received.

He could not have been more than twelve. His ears stuck out from his cap

and his bicycle leaned against the wall with an optimism the bicycle did

not deserve. Hanna, who had returned briefly for the parish receipt,

asked the boy which route he meant to take back.

“Upper road first,” the boy said. “Then whichever one still belongs to

God.”

Hanna took the grocer’s circular from the sideboard, turned it over, and

wrote standing up:

If the lower road is watched, do not attempt it. Go to your sister’s if

safer and send word by the boy. Come tomorrow by the upper way only if

passable.

He folded the paper twice and gave it to the boy with the chemist’s

coins. “The woman who works here,” he said. “Near the lower road beyond

the gardens.”

The boy nodded and went off up the road with the medicine parcel bumping

against the carrier. Maryam watched from the window and thought, not for

the first time, that the household’s correspondence had begun requiring

boys on bicycles and the backs of grocers’ circulars because the

ordinary means of reaching even one’s own servant had ceased to be

ordinary.

Towards four the boy returned. On the back of Hanna’s note, in a square

hand none of them knew, someone had written:

She is with her sister. Lower road bad after noon. She will try

tomorrow by the upper way if possible. Do not send after dark.

Hanna read it once, then placed the paper under the salt cellar. “Then

that is that for today,” he said.

He did not remove the blanket from the side room. Instead he told

Ibrahim not to stack his copybooks on the bench there and asked Huda to

leave the small lamp in place.

By four o’clock the unsent letter still lay beneath the account book.

Maryam took it out and went upstairs with it, not because there was more

room in the bedroom but because there was less witness. The house could

hear paper downstairs. Upstairs it heard only footsteps.

She sat on the bed with Nadia’s letter open beside her and tried again.

We are managing.

She crossed that out at once. It was the sort of phrase one used when

one wished not to be contradicted by fact.

The city is altered daily, though this may no longer distinguish us from

anyone else.

That stayed for perhaps three seconds.

Hanna is making arrangements for eventualities that refuse to name

themselves.

She stared at that until she laughed once, without amusement. It sounded

like someone else.

From the window she could see the upper part of the Abu-Rashids' wall

and the top of a ladder propped against it for some repair that had not

progressed in two days. A dog barked below street level. Somewhere

farther off a man shouted and was answered by no one she could hear.

She wrote nothing further. At last she folded the half-page, put it into

the envelope without sealing it, and slid the whole thing between two

books on the bedside shelf. Not hidden. Deferred. That was worse.

When she came downstairs again, the house had already changed

arrangement without consulting her. Huda was winding thread on a card.

Ibrahim had fallen asleep in the chair nearest the door with one shoe

off. Leila was on the floor playing with the blue pencil Hanna had left

by the map and was using the streets of Jerusalem as roads for a button

she had declared was now a bus.

“Not on that,” Hanna said.

She looked up. “Why?”

“Because it is not a toy.”

“What is it then?”

He glanced at the map and then at Maryam, as if answering the child

might commit him to a sentence he was not yet prepared to hear spoken by

adults. “A record,” he said.

Leila considered the word, then moved the button onto the edge of the

chair instead. This was perhaps the greatest concession anyone had made

all day.

The evening meal was later than usual and smaller. Bread, olives,

lentils reheated, some white cheese Huda had brought wrapped in paper

from the cousin’s house. Her mother ate more than she had done the week

before and then complained that no one had noticed her appetite

returning. Aunt Widad, not present for once, was represented by a jar

she had sent and a note reminding Hanna that clerks often lost things

more completely when pressed to find them. Hanna read the note, folded

it, and put it under the sugar bowl with the map.

Only after Leila had been got upstairs, after Ibrahim had been shaken

awake and pointed at the correct room, after Huda had located her comb

and her cousin’s key and her own temper, did the house briefly quiet.

Maryam found herself alone in the dining room with the lamp lowered and

the map still on the table. Nadia’s letter was in her pocket again,

carried there all day like a proof she had not yet answered. The

string-tied packet from Yusef’s flat lay beside the salt cellar. No

object in the room had been born to live with any other, yet none of

them looked temporary any longer.

She could hear Hanna in the passage moving one of the chairs a few

inches from the wall and then back again, because sometimes that was how his

worry travelled: through furniture corrected by fractions. Upstairs Leila called once in sleep for water, then resettled herself without waking

enough to want it.

Maryam took Nadia's letter from her pocket and laid it on the table

beside the map. For a moment she imagined laying her unfinished answer

beside it too, weighting both down with the sugar bowl, and leaving them

in the open where the entire household might be forced to admit what

every sheet of paper now wanted from them. Instead she opened the drawer

of the little sideboard, took out Hanna's good envelopes, looked at

them, and put them back. Good paper had become insulting.

In the morning room the escritoire still held Nawal's card where she had

put it after Semiramis. She went to it, drew the card out, read only the

hotel name and not the hand beneath it, and then returned it to the

drawer without reordering the other letters there. She could not have

said when the house had stopped keeping its own order. Not in broken

objects. In the small failures of previous exactness.

She went upstairs with the answer to Nadia still unwritten and the

letter still in her pocket. On the bedside shelf lay the half-page she

had folded that afternoon, slid between two books. Not hidden. Deferred.

She did not take it out.

From the next room came Huda's cough and then Ibrahim turning over. From

below, Hanna closing a drawer. The house held more lives than it had

been built to hold, and every one of them was waiting for a sentence

someone else would have to speak first.

CHAPTER XVIII

The Note

The house had begun shutting itself without anyone quite admitting that this was what it was doing.

Not all at once. The front windows were left only partly open because Aunt Widad said the morning looked indecent when one could not trust a road. The back door was bolted after each errand instead of left on the latch. The map stayed on the dining table because Hanna had not rolled it up the night before and no one now wished to touch it first. Amina's blanket was still over the chair in the side room, but the lamp had been moved to the mantel as if the house could not decide whether her absence meant interruption or departure.

Maryam came downstairs to find Huda doing three things badly in the kitchen and Leila missing a stocking. Her mother had not yet emerged. Without Amina the house had changed key. Things still happened, but they happened without the confidence that someone else would notice first.

When Hanna came in he had two loaves under one arm and the look he wore when private choice had become sequence. He set the bread down, took off his hat, and said, "The rooms are open."

The schoolrooms off the parish yard. Women and children from farther west already put there. The lower road closed twice before dawn. Father Elias with keys to the two rooms at the end. They were going after luncheon. When her mother said nothing had happened, Hanna laid his folded paper beside the map and answered that he was putting women and children in rooms with a latch and water.

Leila, eating toast too slowly, said, "Is delay dearer than bread?"

That was the morning: a household being told it would move, and the household resisting in every way available to it except the one that would have required someone to say no and mean it. Hanna left to confirm the rooms. Huda took Ibrahim to the cousin's. Her mother went back to the drawing room, where napkins were being sorted not by colour but by durability for travel she still insisted on calling hypothetical. Aunt Widad asked whether the better blankets should be taken or saved for when things became worse. Her mother answered that one never met decline with one's worst linen if there was any alternative.

Upstairs Maryam stood at the wardrobe with Hanna's list in one hand and the smaller case open on the bed. Leila packed by an entirely different method. She wanted the doll, the cards, both storybooks, the blue ribbon, and the brush with the silver back.

"You may take the doll and one book," Maryam said.

"And the cards."

"No."

"The cards are for waiting."

"We are not going to wait. We are spending one night elsewhere."

"That is waiting."

Huda came to the doorway and looked at the case. "Take the smaller one," she said.

"I am taking the small one."

"No. The smaller one." She pointed to the narrow brown case under the bed. "That one says one night. This one says your husband is right."

Maryam nearly told her not to be insolent, then laughed instead because Huda had said the cruelest true thing in reach.

Tariq, across the quarter, had not slept well.

He had lain awake past two listening to the building settle around him and to the small, unmusical sounds from the road that had lately replaced the old ones. A cart too early. Voices too sharp for neighbours. Once, something heavier — not an explosion, not close enough, but a weight of sound the walls transmitted before the air outside had finished carrying it. By dawn he had given up pretending the night still belonged to rest and sat at his table with the school ledger open and the ink not yet uncapped, looking at the list of names he had been keeping since the week the roads changed.

Names crossed out. Names with notes in the margin: gone to Jericho, gone to the aunt in Ramallah, sent ahead. One name with a question mark because the family had simply ceased to answer and no one yet knew whether that meant departure or something the ledger could not classify.

He had written to Khalil the previous evening. The letter was practical and too short, which was how he wrote when feeling pressed into a shape language could not honestly occupy. He had told Khalil that his mother was with the sister and the sister's husband near the gate, that the school could not rely on him past Friday, that the convent road was the only route he trusted before noon. He had not told Khalil anything else. What else there was did not belong in a letter a colleague might reasonably expect to understand.

The note to Maryam he wrote at a quarter past eleven, standing at the table because sitting would have made the act feel considered rather than necessary.

Today. Four o'clock. The flat.

If you can come, come. I will be there until dark.

T.

He looked at it. The handwriting was exact, upright, not trying to be beautiful. The message was as short as he could make it without making shortness itself a reproach. He folded the paper twice, put it into an envelope he did not seal because the boy would need to see the address, and wrote her name on the front in the hand he used for school correspondence because any other hand would have been a confession the envelope could not afford.

The boy was the same one who had carried notices before — thin, reliable, twelve years old, with ears that stuck out from his cap and a bicycle that leaned against walls with more optimism than the bicycle deserved. Tariq gave him the envelope and a coin and said, "The house near the upper gardens. You know it."

"Hanna Bey's house," the boy said.

"Yes. If someone is there, wait for an answer. If no one answers, bring it back."

The boy put the envelope in his satchel and went off up the road with the cap pushed back because speed and hats disagreed.

Tariq watched him go and then closed the school ledger because there was nothing left in it that required his hand before afternoon.

He reached the flat at ten minutes before four.

The room had already been stripped to the things no one had found a reason to move. The chipped mug stood on the sill, rinsed and turned upright beside a folded newspaper. One chair remained by the table and another nearer the wall. The air held dust, old plaster, and that stale honesty rooms acquire when they have ceased pretending to belong permanently to anyone. On the desk lay the blotter and one pen. The door to the little room stood open, offering nothing beyond a swept floor and the smell of plaster old enough to have forgotten its own colour.

He set his coat over the chair and sat where he could see the landing through the open door. That was the only preparation he allowed himself.

At first the waiting was almost ordinary. There were footsteps on the stair. Elias brought up two chairs to carry down. Someone in the yard below argued about rope. The newspaper on the sill moved slightly in the draught from the back shutter, which had not been fastened properly since before the week began. He did not read. Reading would have turned the waiting into a performance.

At half past four he heard steps on the stair and thought, not hopefully but bodily, there. It was only Elias with a coil of rope over one shoulder.

"No one yet?" Elias asked.

"No."

"Should I shut the back shutter? It rattles."

"Leave it."

The priest left it. The shutter went on rattling with the persistent complaint of something no one had bothered to mend because mending had begun to seem presumptuous.

By five the room had changed relation to him. The chair opposite was still empty. The mug on the sill had become too intimate. Footsteps on the stair no longer sharpened into possibility; they only proved that other lives in the building still knew where they were going. Once he went to the window and looked down into the yard, then back at once because visibility was not the same thing as information and the yard offered only the two customary humiliations: other people's purposes and one's own lack of them.

When Elias came up again he was carrying a small crate of account books and had the tired face of a man who had

started the day as a parish priest and somehow become a porter by afternoon.

"You need not wait if the roads are bad," he said.

Tariq answered only, "I know."

Elias shifted the crate in his arms. "Do you?"

The question might have been insolent in another man. In Elias it sounded merely exhausted. Tariq did not answer it. After a moment the priest went on.

The light thinned. The back shutter went on rattling. He sat in the chair he had avoided all afternoon and looked at the pale rectangle on the wall where the wardrobe had stood. The desk with its blotter and pen. The empty shelf. The flat had been a room in which two people had been most nearly themselves. Now it was becoming a room in which one person waited for the other to prove that the first condition had ever been true.

When the boy finally came back he was on foot, not on the bicycle. His cap was gone. He stood in the doorway breathing hard, one knee of his trousers dark with mud, and held out the envelope.

It was unopened.

"I went first to the house," he said. "The upper road was watched past the gardens. I waited by the grocer until the men moved on. When I got through, the shutters at the front were half drawn and I could not tell if anyone was inside. I knocked. I knocked again. The porter from the building next door came out and said he did not know who was home and who was not, and I should not stand at doors in the afternoon."

He wiped his nose with the back of his hand. "I tried the side door as well. It was bolted. I went round to the back. Nobody answered. Then I came back because you said bring it back if no one answers."

The envelope lay on the table between them. Tariq picked it up, felt its weight — too light for what it had been asked to carry — and put it down again.

"You did right," he said.

The boy remained where he was. "I am sorry."

"Yes," said Tariq. Then, because the boy was twelve and should not be left carrying a man's failed errand as if it were his own, he added, "It is not your fault."

When the boy had gone, Tariq remained in the chair. The room was darker now. The back shutter rattled. Somewhere below someone dropped a crate and swore with convincing fatigue. He picked up the envelope, turned it over once in his hands, and put it under the mug on the sill.

He did not know whether the house had been empty or only shut against the afternoon. He did not know whether she had already gone or had chosen not to answer. The city had placed itself between the note and its reader, and the city did not distinguish between circumstance and decision.

He sat a while longer. Then he took his coat from the chair, put it on, and left the flat without closing the shutter or moving the mug or asking Elias, when the priest appeared once more in the stair with a lamp in one hand, whether anyone had come or gone or sent word. There was no word to send. The note was under the mug. The mug was on the sill. The room held the rest.

CHAPTER XIX

Five More Minutes

After breakfast Maryam packed her mother's case with the sensation of committing small thefts.

Her mother stood by the bed not helping and not quite hindering, which was the more difficult posture to work against. The room still held its old arrangement with offensive persistence: the lace cover on the dressing table, the framed photograph of Maryam's father in his dark suit, the bottle of scent kept always on the tray though used only on feast days and after visits from people her mother wished to remember her by. One could, Maryam saw, lose a house more quickly than one lost the habits by which one moved around it.

"Not that shawl," her mother said as Maryam lifted the brown wool one first to hand. "The grey. The brown makes me look as if I have already become somebody's aunt."

"You are somebody's aunt."

"Not in cloth."

Maryam put the brown shawl back and took the grey. Her mother objected to the second pair of shoes because they were not decent enough, to the first because they were too good to travel badly, to the black hat because it would be crushed, and to leaving it because one could not be expected to appear before priests bareheaded merely because the city had taken leave of order.

At last Maryam said, "Then choose one thing and let the rest suffer."

Her mother looked at her. "Do not speak to me as if I were being difficult for sport."

Maryam said nothing to that because the answer, though available, would have done no good. Instead she folded the grey shawl smaller and laid it over the nightdress and stockings already in the case. Her mother saw at once what was missing.

"You are not taking the icon."

"The small silver one?"

"Of course the small silver one. I am not an Armenian widow moving through a mountain pass."

"There is no room."

"There is room if the lavender sachets are removed. And that bottle of cough mixture no one will use."

"Leila may."

"Then let Leila cough piously."

The sentence was ridiculous and heartless and exhausted in exactly the right proportions to be her mother's own. For one instant Maryam loved her, or loved what the sentence preserved of ordinary pettiness in a room where ordinary pettiness ought already to have been extinguished. Then the moment passed.

"The icon can go in your handbag," she said.

"My handbag is for money and papers."

"There will be less money than usual and more papers than usual. They may coexist."

That, from her mother, counted almost as a concession.

Hanna appeared in the doorway with the folded list in one hand. "Two questions. Do you still have your father's insurance papers among your things, and where is the smaller enamel basin?"

Her mother said at once, "The basin cracked in 1939 and your memory is theatrical."

"It was used after Leila's fever."

"That was the larger one."

"It was not."

Maryam said, "The basin is in the upper cupboard with the travel blankets."

He nodded once. "And the papers?"

Her mother looked at him with active injury. "If we are moving for one night, why are my father's insurance papers relevant?"

"Because if we are moving for one night they are irrelevant and harmless, and if we are moving for longer they cease to be irrelevant."

He left before she could answer him. His strength had always lain partly in this: saying the thing and moving on before anyone could sentimentalise it into a quarrel.

Just before noon Father Elias came himself, collar slightly askew and dust on one sleeve, younger for the disorder and less priestly than burdened. "The driver says four," he told Hanna. "Not later. If the convent road begins misbehaving again, he will not come up twice."

"Four is manageable," Hanna said.

"Manageable is what people say now when they mean bad but not yet impossible."

At one the bed men came.

They were not bed men in any dignified trade sense. One was a porter from the Greek club with shoulders too narrow for the work and the look of a man who had lately discovered that other people now cried in front of him as if he were furniture. The other was older and treated

screws, slats, and rolled mattresses with the practical indifference of someone who had dismantled half the quarter already and seen every possible variation on reluctance. They took off their shoes in the hall because Amina told them to and because she looked exactly like the sort of woman from whom even men carrying iron bedsteads accepted instruction.

The first guest-room frame came apart badly. One screw had rusted into righteousness and would not yield either to the younger porter's narrow shoulders or to the older man's screwdriver. Hanna fetched oil from the kitchen. Amina returned with a rag. The older man knelt on the floor, one knee in the dust and one hand steadying the iron upright while the younger tried not to look defeated by furniture. Leila, who had been told twice to stand clear and therefore remained exactly at the edge of possible injury, watched as though the bed were a person undergoing treatment.

"Will it break?" she asked.

"No," said Hanna.

"It already sounds broken."

"It sounds resisted."

The older porter gave a short laugh through his teeth without lifting his head. At last the screw turned with a noise at once vulgar and intimate, the sort of sound houses usually kept to themselves. The frame loosened. One side dipped. The mattress, already rolled and bound with rope, leaned more heavily into the passage wall. For the first time that day the house ceased merely to look preparatory. It began to look dismantled.

When the second frame was lifted from the spare room the marks beneath it showed pale on the carpet where the sun had not reached in years. Huda stood in the doorway with

the folded blanket from the camp bed and stared at the white rectangle.

"It looks indecent," she said.

"It looks dusty," said Amina.

"It looks as if the bed has been lying about us."

"Everything in this house has been lying about us," said Aunt Widad.

By half past one the guest room had become recognisable only by its wallpaper. The rolled mattress leaned in the hall. The beds of a house looked ridiculous once upright against walls, like arguments no longer able to lie down.

Amina took Maryam's black coat out to the back steps and brushed it with a violence just short of anger. When Maryam went to take it from her she saw, near the shoulder seam, a thin line of white dust.

"From the frame," Amina said. "Stand still."

"It does not matter."

"Everything matters once it is visible."

She brushed again, then again. "There," she said. "Now it looks as if you still belong to your own coat."

At three the parish truck still had not come. At ten past three, when Hanna was already in the yard with the porter and the mattress ropes and Aunt Widad had begun saying this was what came of trusting institutions with wheels, the driver appeared at last in a vehicle that was not a lorry and also not a carriage and therefore offended everyone equally. It had benches at the sides and a tarpaulin rolled back for loading. Father Elias sat beside the driver as though to certify the truck's moral purpose by his mere presence.

"I told you four," the priest said apologetically, which was how they knew the matter was worse than delay. "We had to drop a widow with two grandchildren at the convent first."

"Then we are still in credit," said Hanna.

Loading the truck took less time than protesting it. Her mother's case went first, then Leila's, then the rolled blankets Aunt Widad had declared non-negotiable and Hanna had called excessive until the priest quietly said the rooms behind the school held their cold without argument. Huda and Ibrahim were sent ahead on foot with the cousin's boy. Aunt Widad insisted she would follow in half an hour after seeing whether the lower kitchen window had been properly barred, as though barring a window after beds had been taken out of a house remained a measurable contribution to order.

Through all this Maryam moved as instructed. The child's satchel. The enamel mug for cough mixture. The bottle wrapped in paper. Her mother's shawl. A packet of needles Amina thrust into her hand because there was no knowing what rooms forgot to contain. She performed each act without yet feeling departure in full. The body could do this for some time: obey movement before the mind admitted what movement was for.

It came at last not in the truck, not in the hall, not with the blankets, but in the bedroom.

She had gone upstairs only to fetch Leila's second shoe because the first had somehow reached the truck and the second had not. The room stood open, diminished by its own emptied surfaces. The wardrobe doors were open again. One drawer hung half-pulled. On the chair where the case had stood there was now only the indent in the cane seat. On the washstand stood the glass her mother used for teeth. Beside it, because no one had thought to move it, lay the key to Uncle Yusef's flat.

Maryam picked it up and then did not move.

There were no speeches in her head. Only the absurdity that this piece of metal, which opened a dead man's room containing less and less, should now feel heavier than the packed case, the child, the mattresses, the map, or the road.

From below came the sounds of departure rendered practical: the driver coughing once, Father Elias asking whether there was one more case, Leila saying she did not wish to sit on the left because the left had no window, Amina telling someone not to lift by the handle because the handle was decorative and decorative things lied.

Then Hanna was in the doorway.

He did not ask what she was doing. He looked once at her hand, once at the washstand, once at the bed with the coverlet turned back from the morning and never straightened, and said in the same even voice with which he might have announced the bread man's arrival, "I have given you five more minutes."

It took her a second to understand the grammar of it. Not take what you need. Not make it quick. Not we have no time. I have given you five more minutes.

As if time were not hers in that room any longer and never had been; as if what he could offer was not understanding but measure; as if mercy itself, in him, could only arrive through allocation.

She said nothing.

He nodded once, not to hurry her but to mark the terms, and went away again.

The house below did not grow still for her. That was the other part of the gift. It continued. The men lifted. Leila complained. The priest coughed. A pan was set down in the kitchen. Amina said, "Not that one, the other rope." All of

it went on. She had not been granted a private suspension of the day. She had been granted five minutes within it.

She put the key into her coat pocket and then took it out again because keys in pockets made a visible line and she did not want anything visible. She looked once around the room as if some other object might ask to be chosen instead. The brush. The mirror. One glove left in the drawer. The folded church bulletin on the mantel. All at once she saw with complete clarity that selection did not honour things. It merely created one more injury for what was not taken.

When Hanna came back he did not come faster. He came at the same pace and stopped in the same doorway.

"Come," he said.

She put the key into her handbag because bags were already guilty and could absorb another form of it. Then she turned and went with him.

At the front door her mother was already seated in the truck with the shawl up around her throat and an expression of such stern insult that, had anyone not known better, they might have taken her for a judge compelled to ride with petitioners. Leila sat beside Father Elias and was at once fascinated and offended by the truck's springs. Aunt Widad stood in the yard giving instructions to Huda though Huda was no longer within hearing distance. Ibrahim had gone ahead. Amina was in the passage with the kitchen key in one hand and a wrapped parcel in the other.

"What are you doing?" Maryam asked her.

"Shutting the stove. Barring the back door. Taking the pan your aunt forgot she wanted. Then going by the upper way before dark becomes proud of itself."

She held out the parcel. "Bread. Cheese. The smaller knife."

Maryam took it. "For how long?"

Amina's face altered by less than a degree. "Until there is a table again."

Then, because the answer had gone further than either wanted, she added, "Or until the child begins crying from hunger and your mother calls that weakness."

Hanna came out of the house carrying the last packet of papers under one arm and the rolled map under the other. He handed the map to Father Elias, passed the papers to Maryam, then went back once more inside. When he came out the second time there was nothing in his hands but the key-ring.

He shut the front door and turned the key.

The sound was not large. Metal, wood, a resistance overcome. Yet because the house had been full of smaller sounds all day — rope over bedsteads, drawers, shoes, cups, stove door, cart wheel — the lock sounded almost ceremonial by contrast. Hanna did not linger. He only checked once that it had taken, then put the key into his pocket.

They jolted into the road.

Jerusalem moved past in the wrong register. It was still afternoon. There was still bread in some shops, shouting at corners, boys sent on errands, one man mending a bicycle against a wall as if all weeks retained the right to require mended bicycles. Yet the city had also begun exhibiting itself in sections like a house under partial clearing: a rolled carpet against a railing, a stack of chairs in a yard, women carrying not baskets but bundles tied in pillowcases, one mattress on a cart with the brass knobs still attached.

"Are we going very far?" Leila asked.

"No," said Hanna.

"Then why did we need blankets?"

"Because near is not the same as warm."

When they turned by the convent road Maryam looked back without meaning to. The house was already gone from sight. Not the memory of it. Only the visible arrangement of stone and shutters and wrong curtain. The bend in the road had taken it. She faced forward again before Leila could ask what she had looked at.

The rooms behind the school took possession of them at once by refusing familiarity.

The first held two narrow beds with iron rails painted a green that had once intended cheerfulness and now looked only hygienic. The second held one wider bed, two rush chairs, a washstand with a cracked basin, and a stove whose black iron had been polished by generations of reluctant temporary guests. The window looked not onto any view a person could wish to claim but onto the upper wall of the school yard, the head of a cypress, and a strip of sky cut thin enough to look rationed.

Her mother entered first and stopped just beyond the threshold.

"There is nowhere to put flowers," she said.

Father Elias, carrying the rolled blanket and map because priests had lately become beasts of burden by default, answered, "That is one of the room's strengths."

Her mother looked at him as if deciding whether piety excused wit. Then she sat on the nearest bed and put one hand on the counterpane as though to establish legal possession.

Hanna stayed long enough to test the latch, the lamp, and the water. Then he said he must go back.

"To what?" said her mother.

"To the house."

"What remains there worth a man's return?"

He looked at her with almost perfect patience. "You. The rest of you is still there."

Maryam followed him into the passage before she had decided to. The plaster wall held the day's cold. From the next room came voices through the boards in that muted communal way they had in hospitals and schools.

"When will you come back?" she asked.

"Before dark if the roads allow it."

He looked tired enough that the skin beneath his eyes had gone almost translucent. She could smell outside air and bread flour on his coat.

"Keep the door latched after dusk," he said. Then, because he knew that was insufficient even by his own measure, he added, "If I am delayed, it will be delay."

He nodded once and went. She stood in the passage until she heard the truck start, then die, then start again.

The room grew smaller after he left. Huda opened the case and took out what was needed. Her mother chose the mattress farthest from the window because draughts, she said, were the one political force she had never trusted. Leila lay under the desk making a house out of one blanket and the doll. The place was becoming whatever the quarter asked of it five minutes after insisting it would ask nothing.

Later, when the lamp had been turned low and Leila's back was warm against her, Maryam lay still and listened to the passage settle. In her handbag lay Yusef's key. In her pocket lay Nadia's third letter. On the shelf at home, in a drawer no one would open tonight, lay Nawal's card.

Somewhere across the quarter, in a room she could not reach and did not know was waiting for her, the back

shutter was still rattling and a mug stood on a sill beside a folded newspaper. She did not know this. She did not know that a note had been written, sent, carried through watched roads, returned unopened, and placed under the mug by a hand that had then left the room without closing the shutter or the door. She knew only that the ceiling above her was not hers, that the child beside her breathed as if breath were the last ordinary thing still functioning, and that somewhere in the city a man she could not answer had asked a question the day itself had made unanswerable.

The room held its cold. The passage held its quiet. Outside, the quarter went on narrowing without asking permission from anyone still inside it.

CHAPTER XX

The Key

By morning the room no longer looked borrowed. It looked used, which was

worse.

A strip of chalk still lay in the tray beneath the blackboard, as if a

teacher had left in the middle of a sum and meant to return after

luncheon. Two of Leila's stockings hung from the back of a chair because

they had been washed in the basin and had not yet decided whether to

dry. Her mother's shawl lay folded over the desk nearest the door, too

carefully placed to count as untidiness and too out of place to look

like anything else. Along the wall, where the camp mattresses had been

laid side by side the night before, the blankets had already taken on

the shape of those who had slept badly beneath them.

Maryam had not expected sleep to come. It had. That was the first

betrayal. Not deep sleep, and not the sort from which one woke restored,

but broken pockets of forgetfulness long enough to make waking feel like

being handed back a parcel one had hoped, without honour, to misplace.

Each time she woke she had to remember where the room ended, which

breathing belonged to whom, and why the blackboard stood where the

wardrobe ought to have been. By the fourth waking she stopped asking

herself whether morning would improve anything and began merely waiting

for it to arrive and take over.

Now the room held that grey hour in which faces were still half with

sleep and objects had not yet resumed their claims. Huda sat on her

mattress with her hair unpinned, sewing a button back on to Ibrahim's

shirt because, she said, the previous day had removed his buttons with

the enthusiasm of a customs officer. Ibrahim still slept, one hand above

his head, younger in sleep than he ever looked when dressed and

defensive. Aunt Widad, who had declared the night before that she could

sleep anywhere if the linen were decent, was already upright on the edge

of her mattress with both hands on her knees and the expression of a

woman who had been made to camp by history and would not permit history

to see her untidy. Her hat stood on the desk beside her like evidence

from a better room.

From the passage came the sound of water being poured from one enamel

jug to another, then Amina's voice, flat with exhaustion rather than

temper.

"If you wash all four faces in one basin, I shall stop recognising any

of you out of self-defence."

Leila laughed. That laugh, which the day before had seemed impossible,

struck Maryam with a small pain of gratitude.

Her mother, beneath the blanket nearest the inner wall, said, "If there

had been proper hot water when requested, none of this communal

barbarism would be necessary."

No one answered. Even Aunt Widad had learnt that some remarks, repeated

often enough, no longer deserved contradiction because contradiction

implied novelty.

Maryam pushed herself upright. Her neck ached from having slept with

Leila’s heels against her ribs for part of the night. Her shoes were

where she had left them, one upright, one on its side, as though even

they had not agreed whether the room ought to be treated as temporary or

endured as fact. She bent to right the fallen one and reached for the

handbag under the chair. The key was there at once beneath her fingers,

lying sideways against the purse. She had forgotten it only because

forgetting had briefly become useful.

The key.

Not their house key. Not one of Hanna’s office keys. Uncle Yusef’s flat

key, taken up from the washstand because it had lain there too lightly

and too far behind all afternoon, then put somewhere and not put away.

Her fingers closed round it by instinct, as though the room were asking

her to account for every hard object she still possessed.

She left it where it was and rose.

In the passage Amina stood by the basin in her blouse and underskirt,

sleeves rolled, hair twisted and pinned with less care than usual. In

their own house she would already have restored herself to full

propriety before the first kettle boiled. Here necessity had outrun

form.

“Do not use the smaller jug,” Amina said as Maryam came out. “It pours

on your shoes instead of your face.”

“Who has had the hot water?”

“Your mother, who announced last night that she would not wake into

history without tea and hot water and then woke into both before I had

lit anything.”

“I heard that,” her mother said from within.

Amina did not raise her voice. “You were meant to.”

On the desk near the door lay the school circular from the day before,

folded under a spoon against the draft, and beside it a loaf with one

end already cut. Hanna had gone out before dawn, as he had the habit of

doing now. His absence had the feel of a profession with him rather than

an injury. He left when sequence required it and came back carrying the

next necessary fact, however unwelcome. The room, in his absence, held

itself more poorly but not less honestly.

“What time is it?” Maryam asked.

“Past seven,” said Aunt Widad. “Which in these rooms means one has risen

too late to do anything elegantly and too early to excuse it.”

Huda looked up from the shirt. “The widow with the grandchildren is

still in the smaller room. The little one coughed all night.”

Her mother said, “That coughing came through the wall.”

“That is what walls do in schoolrooms,” Aunt Widad said. “They educate.”

Leila emerged at last with one cheek wet and the other still marked by

sleep. “The basin tastes of iron,” she said.

“You are not meant to drink the basin,” Amina answered.

“How do you know I did?”

“Because children only complain in such detail about their own

experiments.”

Maryam took the towel from the peg and rubbed at Leila’s hair where the

water had not reached properly. The child endured this with the tragic

patience of the mildly inconvenienced.

“Will we go home after breakfast?” she asked.

No one answered at once. It was Aunt Widad who spoke, and for once she

chose not severity but usefulness.

“We will go somewhere after breakfast. That is enough for now.”

“Home is a somewhere.”

“Yes,” said Aunt Widad. “It is.”

From beyond the shutters came the thin uncertain sounds of the quarter

beginning a day it no longer trusted: a cart wheel striking a stone, the

call of a bread seller, a burst of speech cut short rather than

concluded. The school itself was not in session, yet the rooms retained

enough of the old habit of instruction to make everything done inside

them seem provisional, as though at any moment someone might enter,

dismiss the families, and demand copybooks.

A knock at the outer door made every head lift. Not sharply, not like

people in a novel, but with the same weary quickness that had entered

all their movements. Amina set down the jug and went to the door because

she still moved first in any room where labour and interruption met.

It was Father Elias, carrying two small loaves tucked under one arm and

a packet wrapped in old newspaper beneath the other. His collar sat

slightly askew and his shoes wore the damp of the streets.

“Only bread,” he said at once. “Nothing saintly about it. The convent

had more than they required this morning.”

“That means they expect more later,” Aunt Widad said.

“At my age,” the priest answered, “one cannot bring bread into a room

without it becoming prophecy.”

He set the loaves on the desk and looked around with a professional

discretion that did not quite hide pity. He had seen too many temporary

arrangements to be impressed by any one of them. Priests learned how

much human dignity could be preserved between a camp bed and a wall hook

and did not insult people by pretending it was more.

“Hanna?” he asked.

“Out,” said Amina.

“Doing what?”

“What he always does when the rest of us would rather he sat down.”

Father Elias nodded once. “He stopped at the parish house first and then

the office. There is talk of moving the records again if the lower

windows are as exposed as they seem. He said he would return before

nine.”

Maryam said only, “Thank you.”

He laid the newspaper packet beside the bread. “Cheese. Unimpressive,

but easier to distribute than comfort.”

Her mother, drawing the blanket more tightly round herself, said, “I

have never known cheese to arrive without conditions.”

“In the convent,” said Father Elias, “everything arrives with

conditions.”

Leila was already at the desk. “Will we stay here tonight?”

The priest’s eyes moved over the room and rested briefly on Maryam, on

the blankets, on the children’s shoes lined beneath the desk, on Amina

folding a towel that did not belong to her. He looked not saintly, not

sorrowful, only accurate.

“You may remain another night,” he said. “After that I would prefer not

to promise.”

“To whom?” Aunt Widad asked.

“To anyone,” he said.

After he had gone, Maryam took the key from her bag and held it openly

in her hand. It looked smaller now and more useless. A key begged for a

door; without one it became only a shaped insistence on what was no

longer accessible.

Aunt Widad glanced up from threading a needle she plainly could no

longer see well enough to thread. “What key?”

“Yusef’s.”

“For the flat?”

“Yes.”

She absorbed this a moment. “Keep it.”

“Why?”

“Because if you give it to your husband now he will put it with the

others and it will become one more instrument. If you keep it, it

remains what it is.”

“Which is what?”

“Not yours,” said Aunt Widad. “That is sometimes the most exact category

available.”

Maryam closed her hand round the key again. It warmed almost

immediately. That, perhaps, was what made objects dangerous when carried

too long: they adapted themselves to one's body without asking whether

one had the right to keep them.

By the time Hanna returned it was nearly dark. He had acquired flour

somehow, and candles, and news that was not news but the current shape

of uncertainty: two more families gone from the upper road, a cousin

from Talbiya not yet arrived where he was expected, another lorry

promised for morning and distrusted already. He also brought, folded

into his inside pocket, a small official slip certifying something no

room any longer cared to hear certified.

He set down the flour, removed his hat, and looked once around the

schoolroom. His gaze had always been assessing. Now it assessed as

though each object had begun keeping time.

"They will let us have one of the convent rooms tomorrow if we choose

it," he said.

"Choose it over what?" said Aunt Widad.

"Over staying here another night and then finding the choice has been

made for us."

Her mother said, “Convents smell of boiled cabbage and supervision.”

“Then we will be morally nourished.”

“Do not joke.”

“It was not a joke.”

He sat at the desk, because sitting at the desk in these rooms had

become his nearest equivalent to authority, and pulled off one glove

finger by finger. His hands looked colder than his face.

Maryam said, “And the house?”

“The shutter held. Elias is there still.”

“And the flat?”

The question escaped more evenly than she expected. No one else in the

room looked up.

Hanna answered as if she had asked about a file. “The building is shut

before dark. Elias says no one has disturbed the door.”

That was all.

It was enough to make the room tilt slightly, though not in anything

anyone else could have named. The door had not been disturbed. Nothing

had entered. Nothing had emerged. The room stood, unopened and

unentered, not because it still held possibility, but because

possibility had already been overtaken by sequence elsewhere. She did

not have to choose whether to go there. The day had already done without

asking her. She felt, alongside grief, the shameful ease of having been

spared the last movement of will. She hated it at once and could not

prevent it existing.

Hanna was watching her now, not openly, only with the slight attention

he gave to matters that might become urgent if ignored too long. There

were many things he did not ask. It had taken Maryam years to learn that

silence in him was not emptiness. Sometimes it was merely the refusal to

demand a sentence from someone already carrying too many.

“You should sleep earlier tonight if we move tomorrow,” he said.

She almost answered with something sharp because sharpness would have

been easier than gratitude. Instead she said, “Perhaps.”

Leila, hearing the word move, looked up from the alphabet she had been

writing badly on the back of a circular. “Again?”

“Yes,” said Hanna.

“I dislike a world where one moves before one has decided where to keep

the pencils.”

“Then hold on to the pencils.”

This seemed to satisfy her. She gathered the three blue pencils into her

fist and sat on them as if history might otherwise take them.

Night came fully. The widow in the smaller room coughed again. A baby

somewhere further down the passage began and stopped and began again. A

pot was dropped in the convent kitchen. The room smelt now of flour,

damp wool, and extinguished candle rather than of school. One could

acclimatise to anything if given enough other people and insufficient

choice.

When at last the children had been made horizontal and the blankets

pulled up and the final cup drained and her mother’s complaints reduced

to murmur, Maryam lay down without first removing the key from her bag.

For a while she kept one hand resting against the clasp through the

folded blanket beside her, fingers tracing the outline of the metal

beneath the leather. It was absurd to touch it so often. It opened a

flat growing emptier by the day, a room she could not decently go to, a

desk nearly cleared, a life already redistributed into files, bundles,

unclaimed objects, and memory. Yet the key remained more honest than

most things around her. It promised only access, and even that only if

the door still stood and the road allowed.

Leila's breathing deepened beside her. Across the room Hanna was not yet

asleep; she could tell by the measured incompleteness of his stillness.

Huda turned once and settled. Aunt Widad, astonishingly, snored for half

a second and then denied it with a cough.

Maryam thought of the house. Not grandly. She thought of the hall where the stair light never fell

properly, of the washstand in the bedroom, of the drawer where the glove

might still lie, of the blue vase corrected first for grief and then for

normalcy, of the smell of cedar in the linen cupboard, of the side room

off the kitchen where Amina had slept because the roads had disagreed

with night. She thought of Yusef's flat and the chipped mug on the sill,

and because she did not know whether the mug remained there, the

ignorance itself became part of the thought. She thought of Tariq not as

an image — she had too much exactness left for that — but as a set of

unfinished weights: the flat, the question, the demand that had never

received an answer because history had removed answer from the list of

actions still available.

She grieved him in uncertainty. She grieved also the house, the quarter,

the afternoons the city had once allowed people to waste and still

survive them.

And beneath both griefs, because truth was meaner than dignity, ran the

low shameful relief that choice had collapsed ahead of her. The room

behind the school, the files, the children, the priests, the keys, the

blankets, Hanna's sequence, the routes and shutters and lists — all of

it had made the world so narrow that there was no longer enough width in

it to stage the old indecision. She had not chosen correctly. She had

not chosen at all. Yet the necessity others had begun carrying for her

left her momentarily freer of the act she had most dreaded. It was a

relief as ugly as the wash water in the basin. She knew it. It remained.

In the dark she took the key out at last and closed her hand round it

fully, not because it solved anything, but because a hand needed

something hard when thought would not quiet. The metal pressed against

the centre of her palm until it almost hurt.

By morning, she thought, the key would have to be given to Hanna or

Father Elias or some next arrangement more practical than the hand of a

woman lying awake among blankets in a schoolroom. Tonight it remained

only itself — too small to carry a room, too exact to lie about what it

opened, cold despite her hand.

The schoolroom remained what it was: too many sleepers in it, a cough through the wall, chalk dust in

the grain of the desks, and a draught at the lower edge of the shutter.

Somewhere in the passage someone rose to use the bucket and apologised

to no one in particular. Someone else whispered a prayer too tired to be

pious. From the convent side came the dull bell marking an hour the room

had no use for. Ordinary indignities persisted. So did ordinary mercies.

Under the blanket her hand found Leila's warm ankle and rested there a

moment, as if the child's body were the only honest inventory left to

her. Then she opened her other hand, looked at the key in the dark as if

darkness could tell brass from shadow, and laid it on the desk beside

her folded gloves.

In the morning it would still be there, small and displaced, opening

nothing in the room where it had come to rest.